four hands holds the severed head of a demon, the other a sword, implying the punishment of sin, but the third is stretched out in the act of giving a boon and the fourth offers benediction. The last two indicate her protection of those who resign themselves to her care.

This world, ever-moving towards destruction, is symbolised in Çakti; but she gives hope also that the virtuous will be saved. Beyond the sphere of virtue and vice, of pleasure and pain, is the permanent principle of the spiritual world—Çiva who is immovable representing Eternity in the midst of all that shifts. The Yogīs who try to attain a stage where pleasure does not please and sorrow does not cause pain, aim at the spiritual condition of Çiva. Thus they arrive at the permanent and abiding principle, and are not subject to the joys and pains that flesh is heir to. At this stage one may say that he is one with the divine spirit or শিবোহং শিবোহং (I am Çiva, I am Çiva.)

The noble qualities of Çiva to which we alluded in a previous chapter, acted on the multitude as a great attraction, but gradually as this religion took a subtle and mystic form, it grew unintelligible to the masses. Let us here deal with its popular aspects as they are found in our old literature.

The popular Çaivism.

We referred, in a previous chapter, to the songs of Çiva—Çiva according to popular notions, divested of all glory, sunk into a peasant, a beggar and a Gānjā smoker. He drank Siddhi and ate the fruit of the Dhuturā. An agricultural character was attributed to him by those rustic bards who composed the pastoral songs. The Paurāṅik conception

of Çiva as a Bhikṣu,—probably borrowed from the Buddhistic idea of renunciation,—degenerated amongst the masses, and the Great God was reduced to the level of a beggar. The mythology, that narrated the story of Çiva, swallowing poison to protect the universe from destruction, lent credulity to the story of his taking profuse doses of Siddhi and Dhuturā,—thus the peasants of Bengal gave a form to the Great God that mirrored the condition of their own life. But his edifying character was not altogether lost, in this humble delineation. Indifference to the world, and an ever contented disposition, not ruffled by circumstances, befitting a Yogī, could yet be discovered in the character given him by the rustic poets.

The god of the peasants.

Addicted to intoxicating drugs.

But Bengali literature gradually grew more refined as it attracted the notice of scholars; and Çiva as represented in the popular compositions, could no longer satisfy the enlightened taste of the multitudes who listened to the Çaiva songs. These songs fell into popular disfavour as the elements of the personal God were found more or less wanting in Çiva, and only a few writers, latterly, took up the subject for poetry. The character that had been attributed to Çiva by the people in the days of Buddhistic degeneracy, was still retained in these songs, but a new element was introduced into them, which served as an attraction to the rising generations inspired by the superior ideals of the Paurānik Renaissance.

The new element in Çaiva literature.

The domestic element is prominent in the later songs on Çiva. In them he plays the role of the patriarch of a family, where Kārtika and Gaṅeça his sons, Lakṣmi and Saraswati his daughters,

Çiva as the patriarch of a family.

The Joys and sorrows of Bengali homes under a mythological garb. The Āgamanī songs

Nandi and Bhringi his savage-servants, and above all Umā, his devoted wife, figure conspicuously. Umā was married to Çiva when she was merely a child. She was the daughter of Mount Himavata, who gave her to Çiva, in his old age owing to the pleading and intercession of Nārada. The poets who wrote on the subject of this marriage had before them the scenes of a Bengali home. In such homes girls of a very tender age, were occasionally given in marriage to old men and the situation created pathos too deep for expression. Umā, a girl of eight, was married to the old Çiva—who was a beggar, hopelessly addicted to intoxicating drugs and so poor, that he could not give a pair of shell-bracelets to his bride. There are innumerable songs in Bengali, describing the pathetic situation. In the month of Āçvina (October-November) the whole atmosphere of Bengal, rings with the Āgamanī songs, sung by the Vairāgīs which describe the meeting of Umā with her mother; and there is no Bengali to whom they do not appeal most tenderly. The domestic scenes of Bengal—the sorrows of Bengali parents—are really the themes of the songs, though they profess to deal with mythological subjects, which bear a realistic interest, full of deep pathos. There the queen of Himavata in the month of Āçvina, says to her lord —"Go thou and bring my Umā, I know not how she fares in Kailāsa without me. I heard from Nārada that she wept and cried 'o mother, o mother.' Çiva takes profuse quantity of Bhāṅg and Siddhi; he loses his senses under their influence, and rebukes Umā for no fault of hers. Çiva has sold all the clothes and valuable ornaments that you gave Umā

to purchase intoxicating drugs."* In another song the queen of Himavata says—" O Lord of the mountains, my Umā came to me in a dream and when my heart swelled with joy at the meeting, she disappeared. Alas! how cruel is she to her mother! then I felt that it is no fault of hers, O mountain, she is a true daughter of thee to inherit that heart of stone."† In another, when Uma grew older and gave birth to Kārtika and Gaṅeça the queen says, 'O Himavata, all that you said about my Umā, has pierced my heart as with a sword. My poor Gaṅeça, you said, was crying and going from door to door in hunger, and Kārtika, my darling, when almost starved fell on the dusty earth

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* "যাও যাও গিরি আনিতে গৌরী,
উমা কেমনে রয়েছে।
আমি শুনেছি শ্রবণে নারদবচনে,
মা মা বলে উমা কেঁদেছে॥
ভাঙ্গেতে ভাঙ্গড় পীরিতি বড়,
ত্রিভুবনের ভাঙ্গ করেছে জড়।
ভাঙ্গ খেয়ে ভোলা হয়ে দিগম্বর,
আমার উমারে কত কি বলেছে॥
উমার বসনভূষণ যত আভরণ,
তাও বেচে ভাঙ্গ খেয়েছে॥" Old song.

† "গিরি গৌরী আমার এসেছিল, স্বপ্নে দেখা দিয়ে,
চৈতন্য করিয়ে, চৈতন্যরূপিনী কোথায় লুকাল।
দেখা দিয়ে কেন এত মায়া তার।
মায়ের প্রতি মায়া নাহি মহামায়ার॥
আবার তারি গিরি কি দোষ অভয়ার।
পিতৃদোষে মেয়ে পাষাণী হ'ল॥" Old song.

and cried for food."* Yet Umā was the daughter of a king. The household of Çiva—a scene of extreme indigence is painted in contrast with that of king Himavata and the sorrows of the queen who was in affluence herself, at the recollection of Umā's sufferings and those of her sons, find expression in the old songs which at once appeal to the heart. Innumerable songs of this class are sung every year in Bengal by the professional singers who visit almost every house in the month of Āçvina; and where is the heart so hard that it can refrain from tears, while hearing them. The girls here, of too tender an age to play the wife, are often taken away from the custody of parents. With veils over their faces they have to stay in their husband's home, speak in whispers and subject themselves to the painful discipline of the daughter-in-law. At an age when they should skip and bound like wild deer, these tender beings have to live in a home to which as yet they are strangers, subject to possible censure at every step, and cut off from their parents and playmates. When the Āgamanī songs, describing the sorrows of Menakā —the queen of Himabata and of Umā, her daughter are sung by professional singers, the eyes of many a child-wife glisten behind her veil, and the hearts of their mothers cry out for the daughters who have been taken away from them. The Çephālikā flower falls to the ground in showers

* "তুমি যে কতদিন গিরিরাজ আমায় কয়েছ কত কথা,
সে কথা আছে শেলসম আমার হৃদয়ে গাথা।
আমার লম্বোদর নাকি উদরের জ্বালায় কেঁদে কেঁদে বেড়াত।
হয়ে অতি ক্ষুধার্ত্তিক সোণার কার্ত্তিক ধূলায় পড়ে লুটাত।"
Old song.

under the clear autumnal sky of Bengal and the breeze blows softly in the season of these songs. The singers generally have an Ekatārā or one-stringed lute with them, which chimes in well with their plaintive voice in the modulation of grief. The month of Āçvina, in the eyes of every Hindu, is inseparably associated with these songs even as it is with the Çephālikā flower and the clear sky of autumn. During the Pujās which take place in this month, friends and relations meet in Bengali homes, the joyful tears of many a mother are mingled with her daughters' while they narrate to one another, how the bitter days of separation were passed. The pictures, drawn by our village-painters are pleasant to us on account of many delicate associations. In them the queen Menakā stands with arms out-stretched, and Umā comes to her with her sons and daughters—the scene suggesting the sufferings of the whole year. But old Çiva, it must be remembered, is the Great God. He can, at his will, assume a young and handsome appearance and Umā, inspite of her yearnings to meet her mother, is a devoted wife. Çiva, beggar and eater of intoxicating drugs though he is, is tenderly devoted to Umā. He cannot bear separation from her. When she goes to her father's house, there in the picture, the Great God follows her above, through the skies, with looks indicating immeasurable love and tenderness, and in the Āgamani songs, reverence is not wanting for Çiva inspite of the humble characteristics attributed to him. Here is a song in which queen Menakā says :—

Song during the Pujā time in the month of Āsvina.

Reverence for Çiva. The character of a Yogi retained in the songs.

"O Himavata, I have this desire in my heart. Let me bring my daughter with my son-in-law and

give them a home in this mountainous region. He will be here my adopted son, and this mountain,—capital of ours will be a second Kailāsa (the abode of Çiva). I shall see my Umā and Çiva for all the twelve months of the year and the pain of my heart will be assuaged. My son-in-law is ever contented. It is so easy to please him! If I offer him the flower Kunda and leaves of Bel, he will make this place his home and will not wish to go away."*

Yet every one knows, while hearing or singing such songs, that Çiva cannot be bound to any earthly object. He is addicted to nothing; it is his compassion, that people mistake for love. He cares not for either raiment or food,—his contentment springs from within. He is absorbed in contemplation, he is immaculate and above all desire. Umā tries to bind him by a thousand ties of affection. But home and the funeral ground to him are alike—he aims at the superior delight which is derived from Yoga.

* "গিরি আমার মনে এই বাসনা।
আমি জামাতা সহিতে, আনিব দুহিতে
গিরিপুরে করব শিবস্থাপনা।
ঘরজামাই করি রাখব কৃত্তিবাস,
গিরিপুরী করব দ্বিতীয় কৈলাশ।
হরগৌরীরূপ হেরব বারমাস॥
ঘুচে যাবে আমার মনের যাতনা,
জামাই আশুতোষ,—অল্পেতে সন্তোষ,
কুন্দ বিল্বদলে পরম সন্তোষ।
ভুলে রবে ভোলা যেতে চাবে না॥" Old song.

Umā the house-wife.

The domestic element in the descriptions of Çiva, lends a charm to Çiva-songs in Bengali. Umā in Kailāsa plays the housewife, the perfect prototype of the Hindu wife, ever accustomed to patient and strenuous self-denial and labour, cheerfully borne for the sake of others. Her highest delight lies in distributing food to her husband, children and servants. She herself eats nothing till everyone in the house, nay every guest has been satisfied; but this pleasure of serving others while fasting herself invests her with a heavenly charm,—which is indicated in the following passage quoted from Çivāyana by Rāmeçvara:—*

A passage from Rāmeçvara's Çivāyana.

* "তিন ব্যক্তি ভোক্তা একা অন্ন দেন সতী।
এই দিতে এই নাই, হাঁড়ি পানে চায়॥
শুক্তা খেয়ে ভোক্তা চায় হস্ত দিয়া নাকে।
অন্নপূর্ণা অন্ন আন রুদ্রমূর্ত্তি ডাকে॥
গুহগণপতি ডাকে অন্ন আন মা।
হৈমবতী বলে বাছা ধৈর্য্য হয়ে খা॥
মুষকী মায়ের বাক্যে মৌনী হয়ে রয়।
শঙ্কর শিখায়ে দেন শিখিধ্বজ কয়॥
রাক্ষস জনক, জন্ম রাক্ষসীর পেটে।
যত পাব তত খাব ধৈর্য্য হবে বটে॥
হাসিয়া অভয়া অন্ন বিতরণ করে।
ঈষদুষ্ণ সুপ দিল বেসারীর পরে॥
লম্বোদর বলে শুন নগেন্দ্রের ঝী।
সুপ হল সাঙ্গ আন আর আছে কি॥
দড়বড়ি দেবী এনে দিলা ভাজা দশ।
খেতে খেতে গিরীশ গৌরীর গান যশ॥

"With his two sons Çiva sits down to dine. Three sit to eat and Umā serves food to them. As soon as she has served food, the plates are emptied and they look into the cooking pot. Padmāvati (the maid of Umā) observes how eagerly Çiva eats and smiles. Sukta (the first curry) is finished and they fall upon broth. Meantime the plates are all emptied of rice and they all want more "Mother!" says Kārtika, "Give us rice" and Gaṅeça also repeats the request, while the Lord of Destruction (Çiva) says—"Oh Umā bring more rice." Umā says to her sons, "My darlings, be patient: Gaṅeça becomes silent at these words of his mother but Çiva suggests a joke to Kārtika who says—'Our father and mother are Rakṣasas. We know only how to eat and know not how to be patient.' Umā smiles and distributes rice. Gaṅeça says 'I have finished my curry, what more have you in store?' Hastily she comes and serves ten different kinds of fried food. Çiva is much pleased and praises her for her good cooking. The fried Dhutarā fruit and cups of Siddhi are given to the Great God and he nods his head in approval as he sips. When all the curries are finished, they all call at the same time for more; Umā comes hastily to fill their plates and the wind play-fully catches her

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সিদ্ধিফল কোমল ধুতরা ফল ভাজা।
মুখে ফেলে মাথা নাড়ে দেবতার রাজা॥
দিতে নিতে গতায়াতে নাহি অবসর।
শ্রমে হল সজল কোমল কলেবর॥
ইন্দুমুখে বিন্দু বিন্দু ঘর্ম্ম বিন্দু সাজে।
মৌক্তিকের শ্রেণী যেন বিদ্যুতের মাঝে॥

draperies. The musical Nupura tinkles sweetly on her feet as she goes rapidly to and fro and her bracelets sound in harmony with them. She finds it hard to serve so many. The drops of sweat look like pearls on her beautiful face. As a skilful dancing girl moves gracefully to the sound of the musical instruments, so does Umā move briskly about while serving food to her lord and children. She next serves Pāyasa (pudding) of pleasant flavour, and then a sauce both sweet and sour. Her hair becomes dishevelled, and her dress grows loose. With sweetmeats of milk and rice, the dinner ends.

A prayer for shell-bracelets and the Sequel.

The domestic element again becomes pathetic in the description of Umā's wanting a pair of shell-bracelets from her husband. Her lord says that he is too poor to give them and a quarrel ensues, the sequel of which is that Umā sets out in anger for her father's home. Çiva then disguises himself as a bracelet-maker and goes to his father-in-law's house. There, with tears and begging of forgiveness on both sides, the devoted pair are reconciled and once more brought together.

Poems in honour of Çiva.

A considerable part of the Çunya Purāṅa, to which we have already referred, consists of songs about Çiva and these dating from the ninth century or thereabout form the oldest specimens of Çaiva-literature that we possess. Of other poems in honour of this god, which have come down to us, we notice some below :—

"খরবাদ্যে সুপদ্যে নর্ত্তকী যেন ফিরে।
সুরস পায়স দিল পিষ্টকের পরে॥
খসিল কাঁচলি এল্যায়ে গেল কেশ।
গবা বিতরণ কৈল দ্রবা হৈল শেষ॥"

(2) Çivāyaṇa by Rām Kriṣṇa, a voluminous poem.

(3) Mriga Byādha Saṁvāda by Rām Rāj.

(4) Do. by Çyāma Roy.

(5) Mrigalubdha by Ratirām. (This poet was a Brāhmin and a native of Suṁha Daṅdi in Chittāgong. He composed the poem in 1674 A. D.)

(6) Çiva Chaturdaçī by Raghu Rāma.

(7) Vaidyanāth Mangala by Çāṅkara Kavi Chandra, composed in the 17th century.

(8) Çivāyana by Rāmeçvara. This is a voluminous work and was written about 1750 A. D. Rāmeçvara was appointed by Rājā Yaçovanta Siṁha of Karṅagaḍa to write his Çivāyana. It enjoys great popularity. The poet was a native of Yadupur near the police station of Ghātāl in the district of Midnāpur where a zemindar named Hemāyata Siṁha oppressed him so greatly that he was obliged to leave his ancestral home and settle at Karṅagaḍa in the same district. Rāmeçvara belonged to the Rāḍhīya Brahmin class. His father was one Lakṣmaṅa Chakravarty and his mother's name was Rūpavatī.

Of all the poems in honour of Çiva—this Çivāyana by Rāmeçvara enjoys the greatest popularity. It was published by the Vangavāshi Press of Calcutta some years ago, and a portion of it, called Vāgdinir Pālā, is re-issued from the Battalā presses every year, a large number of copies being bought by the common people.

Though the number of poems dealing with Çiva exclusively is comparatively small, yet there are many others which treat of his marriage

Incidental descriptions of Çiva and Umā in other poems.

with Umā and their domestic life in detail. Such incidental descriptions of Çiva and Umā are found in all the Chandī Mangalas, in the Rāmāyaṅa by Krittivāsa, in the Manaṣa Mangala by Vijay Gupta, and in many other old Bengali poems in which they might be least expected. This of course shows that they are relatively older.

4. The Sākta-cult and its development in Bengal.

God as mother.

The idea of the femininity of God may have been characteristic of primitive Asiatic races—of Mongolians and Dravidians in particular, whose civilization, according to some scholars, preceded that of the Aryans. In the Vedas which represent the pure creed of the Indo-Aryans before it had any admixture of the religion of the primitive races of India,—we do not find any pronounced worship of god as mother. But the whole country was full of such worship and the Aryan settlers had erelong to recognise and adopt it. We find in the Tantras that some forms of the Sākta-cult were imported into the religious system of the Aryans from China.*

The great war between Chandī and Mahiṣ.

The great war between Chandī and Mahiṣāsūr is said to have occurred in the earliest part of the Satya-Yuga. The Hindus thus give it a date anterior to any event related in their own history, though there is no mention of this war in the Vedas. This fact is suggestive of the origin of the worship of the mother in a very primitive age and the non-mention of it in their earliest literature—the Vedas, only leads to the hypothesis, that it did not originally interest the Aryans.

* In the Rudra-Yāmala and other Hindu Tantras.

But the Aryans could not help adopting this creed in their religious worship after they had settled in the country for some time, because it had such a wide-spread influence and also because by its great tenderness, this faith is, religiously extremely attractive. When the Sākta-cult thus came to be recognised by the Indo-Aryans, they raised it into a highly refined and spiritual faith, Sanskritized its vocabulary and Aryanized its modes of worship.

Çākta cult was latterly recognised.

But this worship took centuries to reach such a state—Delai Chandī, Lakhai Chandī, Vaçuli, Thakurani—are some of the non-sanskritic names of the mother as worshipped in different localities—which still remind us of the primitive faith of the people, before they came in contact with Aryan civilization. The worship of the snake-goddess and of Chandī once prevailed in all parts of the ancient world and recent discoveries made in Crete by Dr. Evans attest that it existed there as early as 3000 B. C.

Some of the non-Sanskritic names of the mother.

But though Çakti-worship was recognised early,—the local divinities in all parts of India could not receive similar recognition and homage from the Indo-Aryan settlers without a great struggle—especially as the worship of these deities had much in it that was crude and unfit for admission by Hindus into their organised cults. The Çaivaism which was the earlier of the two to become an organized creed, had great fight with the creed of the people believing in various forms of the mother worship. Bengali Literature begins, so to speak, with this account of a fight between the Çaivas and the worshippers of those local deities who claimed to be Çakti, but

The local divinities were not recognised without a struggle.

whom the worshippers of Çiva called witches and regarded as quite unworthy of worship. At a later time the Çaiva creed was blended with the Çakti-cult even in its crude local forms, but this could not happen before a hard contested fight on either side.

This chapter will concern itself with the history of such struggle and the gradual elaboration of these local cults under the shadow of a clearly organised doctrine of the relation between Çiva and Çakti.

(*a*) Poems in honour of Manasā Devi.

In Chaitanya Bhāgavata, a work written in 1536, we find it mentioned that many people at the time took pride in worshipping Manasā Devi, the snake-goddess. The songs in honour of this deity may be traced back, as I have said, to a very early period and they have a wide circulation all over Bengal, especially in the East where the earliest writer of these songs, Hari Datta lived. The great respect, commanded by this deity in the lower Gangetic valley, is not difficult to explain. The plains of Bengal, especially the portions adjoining the sea, are infested with snakes, and deaths from snake-bite during the rainy season become so common as to cause considerable alarm to the people. The cottages of the poor villagers, offer no protection to them from the venomous enemy and when the floods come upon the mud-hovels and thatched roofs, snakes and other venomous reptiles take shelter there, and are not infrequently discovered hidden in beds or coiled up in pitchers and other household utensils. The poor people have no

The fear of snakes.

means of cutting down the jungles and keeping the village-paths clear. In their utter helplessness they are driven to take refuge in God. The God of the snakes is also the God of men and by propitiating him they hope to avert the danger with which unaided they cannot cope. A consolation comes to them surely when thus resigned to His mercy.

The goddess Manasā Devī who represents the divine power as seen in snakes has been a popular deity from very early times, but before her worship was recognised as a form of Çakti-worship, the followers of the Çaiva-religion offered a great resistance to it, as indeed they did to the worship of all other local deities of the later Çākta-cult. The history of the struggle of the Çaivas with the worshippers of Çakti, which was long protracted, is shrouded in the dark past. The flowers offered to Çakti, as Açoka and Javā for instance, are not acceptable to the great Çiva even now when that strife is over. The heroic firmness with which Chānd Sadāgara, Dhanapati Sadāgara and other followers of Çiva adhered to their faith and offered resistance to the spread of the worship of the local deities of the Sākta-cult, found in our old poems, opens a vista through which we have a glimpse of the struggle, which at one time split the whole Hindu community of Bengal.

Local deities recognised in the Çākta-pantheon after a severe fight with the Çaivites.

There is much that is crude in the poems on Manasā Devī and those on Chandī. This, however, proves that they once formed a part of the popular literature of the country before the people had come in contact with the refined classical taste of the Renaissance. The readers will have patiently

The personal element in the divinities.

to go through the manœuvres and plots formed by the deities that would often appear undignified and unworthy on their part. The propaganda of the Çākta-cult however was to restore faith in a personal divinity in the place of the impersonal Çiva. All through these poems one is sure to find the mother's heart in the divinities, eager to stretch out protecting hands to those children that cling to them. Into whatever danger a believer may fall, he cries out for the motherly help of the divinity whom he worships in a patient and prayerful spirit, and she is sure to appear to him with anxious solicitude to protect him. Instances of this personal element in the deities are to be found throughout the vast literature of the Sāktas. The characters of Çrimanta and Kālketu in Chandī Kāvya, of Sundara in Vidyā Sundara, of Lāu Sen in Dharma Mangal, as recast by the Hindu preists, and of Behulā in Manasā Mangal, have been all depicted as attaining great success in life by force of their devotion alone. When all resources failed and the great characters were reduced to utmost straits—some of them being doomed to die on the scaffold, they fixed their whole heart on the mother and solicited divine help with tearful eyes, despairing of saving themselves by their own power, and the mother was sure to come to her devotees stretching out the hand of succour.

Chautiça. One of the familiar ways adopted by the old Bengali poets in describing such mystic situations was to put in the mouth of a devotee a hymn addressed to her by names beginning with each of the thirty-four letters of the Bengali alphabet. The

gods and goddesses in our mythology are often known to their worshippers by hundreds of names and these hymns addressed with 34 names, of which there is quite a legion in our literature, are called Chautiça (lit 34).

This idea of a personal divinity as contrasted with that of the impersonal Çiva is the predominant feature in the literature of the Çākta cult.

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In the month of Çrāvaṅa (July-August) the villages of Lower Bengal present a unique scene. This is the time when Manasā Devī is worshipped. Hundreds of men in Sylhet, Backergunge and other districts throng to the river side or to the temples to recite the songs of Behulā. The vigorous boat-races attending the festivity and the enthusiasm that characterises the recitation of these songs cannot but strike an observer with an idea of their vast influence over the masses. There are sometimes a hundread oars in each of the long narrow boats, the rowers singing in loud chorus as they pull them with all their might. The boats move with the speed of an arrow, even flying past the river-steamers. These festivities of Manasā Pujā sometimes occupy a whole month, during which men keep vigil and recite the songs before the goddess, and are generally known as Bhāsān Yātrā. The wonderful devotion of Behulā to her husband is the theme of these songs; and a vast poetic literature has sprung up in Bengal during the last thousand years in commemoration of the events of her life and that of Chānd-sadāgara

The Bhāsān Yātrā.

who offered defiance to Manasā Devī for long years, yet ultimately was driven by strange circumstances to worship her. How wide-spread is the popularity of these songs in Bengal may be imagined from the fact that the birth-place of Chānd-Sadāgara is claimed by no less than nine districts, all equally proud of the hero of the Manasā Mangal. It reminds us of the seven cities which disputed the honour of Homer's birth. I may name here some of the places that claim a connection in one shape or another with the chief characters of Manasā-Mangala.

Villages and towns claiming connection with the characters of Manasā-Mangal.

(1) Champaka Nagara—said to have been the capital of Chānd Sadāgara, in the district of Burdwan and close to Champaka Nagara is a small river which is called Behulā, after the reputed heroine of Manasā Mangala.

(2) Champaka Nagara in Tippera.

(3) Dhubri in Assam. People here believe that Chānd was a resident of the place

(4) Mahāsthāna in the district of Bogra.

(5) The people of Darjeeling believe that the scene of the Manasā Mangal was laid on the banks of the river Ranit close by.

(6) Sanakā Grām near Kanṭa Nagar in the district of Dināǰpur: Sanakā was the queen of Chānd Sadāgara and Sanakā Nagar is believed to have been named after her.

(7) Champai Nagar in the District of Māldah.

(8) The Melā (exhibition) held in honour of Behulā in the District of Birbhum is said to have originated during Behulā's life-time.

(9) In Chittāgong, there is a spot pointed out as the site of the house of Kālukāmār—the builder of a steel house for Lakṣmindara, and there is besides a tank in the place which bears the name of Chānd Sadāgara.

We give here the story of Manasā Devi :—

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The story of Manasā Mangal.

It was ordained by the great god Çivā that unless and until Chānd Sadāgar, the merchant-king of Champaka Nagar, worshipped Manasā Devi, her claims to obtain *puja* amongst mortals would not be recognised.

Chānd Sadāgar's defiance.

At first she tried by gentle persuasion to prevail upon Chand Sadāgar to worship her, but the hero of the poems lent a deaf ear to her words. He carried in his hand a huge stick made of *hintal* wood and with it he tried, several times, to assault the goddess. The god whom Chānd worshipped was the great Çiva. Could he brook the idea of offering flowers at the feet of the deity who merely presided over snakes? He hated her from the bottom of his heart and called her ill names.

The wrath of the goddess of snakes knew no bounds at this defiant attitude. She determined to revenge herself by some means, fair or foul.

Guābāri destroyed

Chānd had made a beautiful garden outside the city, which was called "Guābāri." He had spent many lakhs of rupees in making it an earthly paradise. Now Manasā Devi commanded her retinue of serpents to destroy this fair garden by their venomous bites. They did so; and lo! this elysium

of Chānd, so rich in fruit and flowers, was reduced to smoke. The guards in great consternation went to Chānd and acquainted him with the fate of his far-famed Guābāri. Chānd came to the spot and smiled.

The garden revived.

To the wonder of all, there present, he uttered some *mantras* and the garden revived, wearing the fresh hues of its original verdure.

Mahā Jnān.

Manasā Devi's plot was thus foiled by Chānd, who possessed *Maha Jnan*—a power bestowed by Çiva, by which he could give life to the dead and revive all that was destroyed.

It was useless for the goddess to try other experiments. She felt that so long as Chānd possessed this power he was practically invincible.

The loss of Mahā-jnān.

She now appeared before the merchant in the guise of a youthful maiden. The poets who composed the songs have vied with one another in describing the beauty of this celestial maiden. Earthly beauty was as nothing compared to hers; even the moon sank behind the clouds in shame, being smitten by the superior light that emanated from the face of this exquisite creature. Chānd fell in love with her at first sight, but the fair maiden would not listen to any proposals from him unless he dispensed with his *Maha Jnan* and bestowed that power on her. The infatuated merchant, not suspecting that she was Manasā Devi in disguise, agreed to her condition; when lo! like a shooting star she vanished from the place, and appearing in the sky in her own form, related the story of her triumph.

Not a whit daunted.

But though deprived of his great power, Chānd was not a whit daunted.

The next step of Manasā Devi was again to destroy the beautiful garden upon which her curse had already fallen so ineffectually.

His friend comes to the rescue.

Chānd Sadāgar had an intimate friend in the city of Saṇkoor. He was called Saṇkoor Gaḍuḍia. He also possessed *Maha Jnan* and Chānd sent a messenger forthwith to fetch him to his palace. The great physician, for such was his calling, came to Champaka Nagar and in a moment restored the garden to its original form.

Sankur Gāḍuḍia is killed.

Manasā Devi's attempts were thus frustrated a second time, but her resources were inexhaustible. By a contrivance which for ingenuity and diplomacy may be called a great intellectual feat, she succeeded in killing Sankoor Gaḍuḍia, the physician and friend of Chānd.

The terrible retaliation.

The latter was now friendless and helpless. Manasā Devi not only did again destroy the Guābari, but the serpents appointed by her also killed one by one all his six sons.

The grief of Sanakā

Sanakā, the queen of the merchant-king, fell on her knees and implored her husband to put an end to this unequal quarrel ; for after all Manasā Devi was a goddess and he was a man!

Chānd undertakes a sea-voyage.

The six wives of the deceased sons of Chānd wore the widow's white *sari*, wiped away the beautiful marks of vermilion from their foreheads, broke their shell-bracelets and filled the house with wild lamentations. But with a firmness which was more than human, he was the more confirmed in his

resolution not to worship Manasā Devi. He was, however, greatly troubled by the constant wailings of the women of his house, and also by the unsolicited advice of his friends, who came from distant countries to offer him consolation in his distress. He resolved to undertake a sea-voyage with the intention of escaping for some time from his uncongenial surroundings. Seven great ships, headed by "Madhukar," the royal vessel, started one fine morning for the great sea, and Chānd had a very successful voyage; he went as far as Ceylon, and, loading his ships with valuable treasures and feeling once more fresh and lively for the change, was on his way home, when upon the dark waters of the lake Kālidaha, a great storm overtook his ships. This storm was raised by Manasā Devi. The ship "Sea-foam" sank first, next the "King's Darling" and then the "Royal Fish" and so on, till the six ships were all wrecked in the bosom of the lake Kālidaha. But the stately "Madhukar," on board which Chānd was, defied all storms and as often as the winds inspired by Manasā Devi tried to overthrow it, it struggled and rose to the surface of the waters like a playful fish.

The ships are wrecked.

Manasā Devi sought the aid of Hanumān, the great monkey, immortal through all ages, and with his aid at last succeeded in upsetting this ship also. Chānd fell into the great lake and was about to be drowned. Manasā Devi would not, however, allow the victim of her wrath to perish; because unless she was worshipped by him, she could not be recognised amongst men. She threw the great lotus which formed her own seat down into the lake, and it floated near Chānd. He was struggling to save

himself and at the sight of the *padma* flower, stretched out his arms to catch hold of it as a support; but one of the names of Manasā Devi was Padmā and the flower also bore the same name, so he contemptuously turned back, preferring death to her aid. But Manasā Devi now appeared and begged Chānd to submit to her. She would in that case pardon him and reward him with all that he had lost, including the lives of his six sons. But Chānd said, he could not defile his hand, reserved for the worship of Mahādeva, by offering flowers to the one-eyed goddess of snakes.

Prefers death to Manasā Devi's aid.

Somehow or other the merchant king escaped death, and after three days of severe struggle reached the shore. It was the beautiful city of his old friend Chandraketu where he touched land. Completely stripped of clothes, as he found himself, he picked up some rags from the cremation-ground, which he warpped round his waist, and straightway went to his friend's palace. Chandraketu gave him a warm reception, and as the merchant had not tasted any food for three days, he at once ordered a rich repast to be served to him; he also presented him with a valuable attire becoming his rank. When the hungry merchant sat down to dinner, Chandraketu incidentally remarked that it was not well for him to quarrel with Manasā Devi, and in the course of an animated discussion on the point, Chānd came to learn that Manasā Devi was the household deity of Chandraketu, and that there was a temple adjoining the palace dedicated to her. On this he would not touch any of the food. In a fit of rage he threw away the clothes presented to him by his friend; and, wearing his former rags

He is warmly received by Chandraketu.

again, left Chandraketu's palace, remarking that it was a pity he had entered that cursed abode, but he did not wish longer to disturb a fool in his paradise. He then begged alms from door to door, and when a sufficient quantity of rice and vegetables was collected, went to the river to bathe after carefully placing his little store in a secure place. But Manasā Devi in the meantime sent a large mouse which ate up the grain and vegetables, and Chānd on returning had to appease his hunger by swallowing raw plantain-skins which some children had left by the river-side. He next got admittance to a Brahmin's house in the capacity of a servant, and his master appointed him to reap the harvest in his fields, and pile up the grain. But Manasā Devi created a bewilderment in his brain so that he could not distinguish the grain from the chaff, and threw away the former and piled up the latter. When the Brahmin, his master, saw this, he was very angry and dismissed him at once. He next went with the woodmen to gather wood from the neighbouring hills. He knew the quality of wood better than the woodmen. So he collected a large quantity of valuable Sandal wood, and was on his way to the market with it. At Manasā Devi's order, however, Hanumān touched with his toe the load which was being carried by Chānd. It immediately became so heavy that Chānd had to throw it down and go empty-handed. In this plight, when he was moving about the forest like a disconsolate mad man, he could not help cursing Manasā Devi. Now, at this moment some birds had come near the traps placed there by the fowlers to catch them. Being startled by the

Begs from door to door.

Eats plantain-skins.

Is dismissed from the Brahmin's house.

Throws down the load of valuable sandal-wood.

careless steps of the merchant, they flew away. The fowlers, in great disappointment, came up to Chānd, and, taking him for a mischievous knave, assaulted him.

Is assaulted by the fowlers.

After suffering all imaginable ills at the hands of the infuriated Manasā Devi, Chānd was able to return to Champaka Nagar, to his own great relief and to the delight of his queen Sanakā.

Returns home.

Soon afterwards another son was born to him. It was a remarkably handsome child, and they called him Lakṣmindara or favourite of the goddess of wealth. Chānd consulted astrologers and they were unanimous in declaring to him privately that the boy was destined to die on the night of his marriage-day, by snake-bite.

Another son born to him.

Doomed to die in early youth.

Chānd had how given up all hopes of worldly happiness. Night and day, he worshipped the great Mahādeva and prayed for strength to keep up his determination. Now Lakṣmindara, who grew to be a most handsome and accomplished prince, came of that age when youths of his caste generally married, and the queen Sanakā sought for a suitable bride for her son. The family priest, Janārdan, brought information that in the whole world there was not another creature in womanly form so lovely and beautiful as Behulā—the accomplished daughter of Sāha, the merchant of Nichhani Nagar. Behulā's face was like a full-blown lotus, her eyes were soft and playful as those of a wild gazelle, her hair wore the tints of summer clouds and when dishevelled, fell down her back and reached the ankles. She sang like a cuckoo and danced better than any dancing-girl in the whole city of Champaka Nagar.

Behulā, the accomplished daughter of Sāha, the merchant.

The steel house on mount Sāntāli.

Chānd knew that he would lose his dear son on the marriage-day yet could not resist the wishes of his poor queen. He built a house of steel on mount Sāntāli, taking precautions that there was no crevice left in it for even a pin to pass through. The steel-house was guarded by armed sentinels; weasels and peacocks were let loose all around it to kill snakes, should they come into its neighbourhood. All kinds of medicinal herbs which were known to be antidotes to snake-poison and the strong scent of which would make snakes and reptiles shudder and shrink into a corner, were strewn round the house, and snake-charmers and physicians were assembled there from all parts of the world, to guard the place against all species of creeping animals.

The builder makes an opening.

Manasā Devi paid a visit to the man who had made the steel-house, and asked him to keep an opening in it through which a hair might pass. The builder said that the house was now complete and that he had received wages and rewards from the merchant king; how could he again go there and make an opening? The goddess threatened to kill him and all the members of his family on the spot. So he obeyed. He went back to mount Sāntāli on the pretext of inspecting the building more thoroughly and with a few strokes of his chisel made a small opening, which he filled up with powdered coal.

The first ominous sign.

When Laksmindara was about to set out with the nuptial party for marriage, the bridegroom's crown that he wore, bedecked with jewels and flowers, fell from his head; and this was the first ominous sign.

The second one.

When the marriage ceremony was being celebrated in the great pavilion which had been built for the occasion, the golden umbrella over the bridegroom's head gave way—the silver rod which supported it, having suddenly broken from some mysterious cause; and this was the second inauspicious sign.

The third one.

When Behulā, the bride, was being carried round Lakṣmindara, she carelessly wiped from her forehead with her own hand the sacred vermilion-mark, the sign of the married woman whose husband is living. This was the third inauspicious sign.

The pair taken to the steel-house.

As soon as the marriage was over, Chānd took Lakṣmindara and Behulā to the steel-house on mount Sāntāli.

This was the terrible night, when the question of life and death for Lakṣmindara would be solved: the astrologers had said, if his life could be saved that night, he would live a hundred years.

The couple left to themselves.

There Behulā and Lakṣmindara were left to themselves. The coy maiden beheld her husband: the garland of *rangan* flowers, which he wore, hung loosely round his neck touching his right arm and breast,—his silken attire of deep scarlet half covered his handsome person, and Behulā looked upon her husband with that feeling of adoration which a Brāhmin feels when he approaches his household-god. Lakṣmindara's eyes also drank deep of the beauty of the maiden, and he asked her to come closer to him so that he might embrace her. The bashful maiden would not listen to any such thing—she hid her face with her tender hands and turned away. Fatigued by the labours and fasting

required for the marriage ceremony, Lakṣmindara fell asleep. But Behulā, though equally fatigued, sat near him on the bed and watched him—for he appeared to her as a priceless treasure and she must not trust too much to her good fortune. After a while, Lakṣmindara awoke and said to Behulā, "My darling, I am very hungry; can you prepare some rice for me?" Saying this he again fell asleep. Behulā did not know what to do. How could she prepare rice there? But her resources never failed her. The plate required for the sacred ceremony contained some cocoanuts; there were also rice and some coloured earthen cups there. She took three cocoanuts and made a hearth with them. One earthen cup was filled with the sweet milk of a cocoanut and rice was placed in it. She took a silken robe and with that kindled a fire to prepare the rice. There she sat, like Annapurṅā, cooking rice for her husband.

Behulā cooks rice.

At this moment Manasā Devī called to her all her snakes,—great reptiles and venomous adders,—and asked who would undertake to bite Lakṣmindara. The difficulties were great, and many hesitated; but the snake Bankarāj, whose poison was as drops of liquid fire, came forward, and obeying the command of the goddess, glided towards mount Sāntāli.

A mysterious opening and a snake.

All of a sudden Behulā saw that a mysterious opening was being made in the steel wall, and a snake entering the room. She took a cup of milk, with a ripe plantain in it, and offered it to the venomous intruder. The snake stooped low to drink the milk, and Behulā, with a golden hook, caught it fast and made it a prisoner. While again watching

the cup on which rice was boiling, she saw another snake coming through the same passage. It was the great Udaynāg with fiery eyes. Behulā made him a prisoner also, following the same device; and after a while the snake Kāladanta shared in the same way the fate of its predecessors. Then for some time nothing more was seen; the rice was ready and she called to her husband to rise and partake of the meal. But Lakṣmindara was fast asleep and did not respond.

The snake Udaynāg

The snake Kāladanta.

Fatigued with labour, fast and vigil, Behulā at this moment felt an irresistible inclination to sleep. She sat beside her husband with her eyes still fixed on the mysterious crevice in the wall. The three serpents lay under a large pot and could not stir. Behulā's eyes became closed in sleep but at times opened wide, gazing at the small opening. Towards the last watch of the night when everything was still and when even the rustling sound of leaves was not heard in that mountainous region, Behulā yielded to the fatal influence of sleep and reclining on a pillow near the feet of her husband, lay like a flower, innocent and beautiful.

Behulā sleeps.

Now came Kālnāgini, that snake who had destroyed the Guābāri, and killed Chānd's eldest son, Çridhar, and approached with the speed of lightning the bed of Lakṣmindara. At this very moment the sleeping prince touched the snake with his foot and it at once turned and bit him in the toe. Lakṣmindara cried out. "Ho, daughter of the merchant Sāha, dost thou sleep? I am dying of a snake's bite!" Behulā rose from the bed and perceived the snake passing out swiftly through the opening in the wall.

The fatal bite.

Lakṣmindara died. The next moment the sun rose, shedding its golden hues over the mountain-forests and the birds began to sing blithely on the wild trees. Queen Sanakā with her maids of honour came to the house and saw a most heart-rending sight. Prince Lakṣmindara lay there dead, and the widowed girl was sobbing over him. With dishevelled hair, she was bending over the departed prince. Sanakā swooned, and the maids said—"Oh luckless wretch, it is to thine evil fortune we owe this crushing bereavement. The vermilion-marks on thy brow have not lost their lustre,—they have still a deep scarlet hue, the tint of *alakta* on thy feet is yet unsoiled by dust, thy marriage attire of silk is as fresh as new, and yet thou art already a widow! No snake could have done this, it is thy breath that has extinguished the life's fire in the prince, wretch that thou art." Behulā did not hear these reproaches; for her mind was working on far other themes. The prince had asked her to embrace him, he had asked her to prepare rice for him: the first and the last requests of one who was all in all to her! How unfortunate was she that she had not been able to fulfil these wishes! At this recollection the tears again flowed from her eyes unceasingly.

The luckless bride.

Behulā on the raft with the corpse.

The body of Lakṣmindara was taken to the burning ghāt. But Behulā insisted that it should not be burnt. The custom in the country in cases of snake-bite was to place the corpse on a raft made of plantain stems called a *bhela* and leave it on the river, in the hope that the skill of a physician or a snake-charmer might bring it back to life. Behulā's arguments were appreciated, and a raft of plantain-stems was prepared. The corpse of the prince

was placed on it, and it was floated on the river Gāngoor. At this moment, to the wonder of all there assembled, Behulā herself stepped on the raft and sat down beside the corpse, expressing her intention to accompany her husband's body over the waters and not to leave it until it should be restored to life.

Her unshaken resolve.

They called her a mad woman who had lost her senses under the great shock received immediately after her marriage, and entreated her to return home. The maidens, who had so bitterly reproached her, were now sorry for her misfortune and tenderly said how very foolish it would be for a woman of her youth to set out for unknown regions with a corpse. Where was it ever heard that a dead body was restored to life! But she sat like a fairy or an angel watching over the dead prince with eyes full of infinite affection and infinite sorrow. The queen maddened with grief lamented bitterly and begged the beautiful girl to desist from her foolish intention. Behulā only said, "Adored mother, you will find the rice I prepared in the golden plate in the steel-house on mount Sāntāli. There the lamp is still burning. Go mother, cease weeping, and close the door of that room. So long as that rice remains fresh and that lamp burns, know that my hopes of restoring my husband to life will not be abandoned." The people of Champaknagar, who had all assembled there, shed tears and cried, "Oh honoured lady, adopt not this mad course!" Behulā only said, "Nay, bless me, sirs, that I may have my husband restored to me once more!"

The raft passed swifty down the stream and Champaknagar soon vanished out of sight. The news reached her father's house, and her five

brothers, of whom Hari Sādhu was the eldest, came to the river side, to take her back to their home. The brothers wept bitterly as they saw the forlorn girl sitting beside a corpse, and said, "We will burn the corpse of the prince with sandal wood, alight on shore. Though you cannot wear shell-bracelets, yet, we will give you golden ones; though sacred vermilion will be refused, yet we can adorn your forehead with red powder; though you may not take fish and meat, we will feed you with all kinds of dainties. You are our only sister. You will be adored in our home, come then to the bank! How heartless were these people of Champaknagar! they felt no compunction at allowing you to accompany a corpse alone on the bosom of deep waters in this condition." Behulā could not answer for some time, for tears choked her voice, but when she spoke, she was resolute and firm. She asked them to return and give her respects to her poor parents. She could not bear the idea of living in a world without her husband. Even the dead body of the prince had for her an attraction which nothing else possessed in her eyes. She was determined to restore it to life.

Preserved from harm.

The brothers went away overwhelmed with grief, and poor Behulā, fasting and sorrowing over her lot, went on over the waters,—she herself knew not whither. Wicked men amongst whom the chief were Godā, Dhanā and Manā became enamoured of the extraordinary beauty of the devoted creature and tried to carry her away by force, but God, who preserves the children, preserved her also who was equally helpless, and resigned. They could not touch her person.

The decomposed corpse.

When she drew near to a place called Bhāgher Bāk, the corpse began to decompose. Decay set in and the form of the beautiful bridegroom became swollen and rotten; an intolerable stench came out of it and swarms of flies and maggots gathered round the putrid body. Behulā saw before her eyes the workings of the immutable law of nature—the end reserved in the normal course for all human beings, and seeing this, she grew indifferent to bodily pain. She washed and cleansed the corpse, she ate nothing, and when her grief was great, she wept alone in that forlorn condition. She passed the ghāt of Noādā and Srigālghāta. People came to see her from the neighbouring villages and called her a mad woman who had lost her senses from grief.

The force of prayer

Whence came the strength and hope that sustained her in this distress? She chanted the name of Manasā Devī a hundred thousand times a day and remained absorved in prayer, till her body became inert and motionless. Pale and emaciated with the dear relics of the prince's body by her side, she suffered intensely. In dark nights the winds rose and crocodiles gathered round her raft, eager to devour the decomposed body. Jackals also came to carry it off whenever the raft drew near the banks, but she was preserved by Providence from their attacks.

Completely resigned.

Being completely resigned, in her extraordinary devotion to Manasa Devi, and passing through unheard-of sufferings, she felt that a power was growing in her, which she could not define, but could feel nevertheless to be more than human. Sometimes she saw the evil spirits of the air in

horrid shapes dissuading her with threats and menaces from her extraordinary course, at others angelic faces peeped through the sky trying to win her to a life of ease and luxury, but she sat like a marble statute, unmoved either by fear or by temptation—sounding the very depths of suffering and praying with unfaltering faith for the life of her dear husband.

Netā strangles her child.

Six months passed in this way; the boat touched the ghāt of Netā, the washer-woman of the Gods; and in the fine morning air when she came there, Behulā saw Netā washing clothes on the bank of the river Gāngoor. Behulā felt that she was no human being, for her head was incircled by a halo of light. A beautiful child was teasing her as she washed, and to the wonder of Behulā, she strangled the child and kept it beside her.

Behulā said nothing, but sat on her raft by the skeleton of her husband, silently watching this mysterious woman.

The child comes back to life.

When, however, the last rays of the sun faded from the western sky, Netā sprinkled a few drops of water over the face of the child, and lo! it smiled as if just awakened from sleep.

Behulā and Netā

Netā was just about to ascend to the divine regions with the clothes and the child, when Behulā landed and fell at her feet weeping. She uttered no word, but shed unceasing tears.

Netā raised her from the ground and assured the unfortunate maid that she would carry her to the heavenly regions where the gods might be moved to grant her prayer.

There in high-heaven Behulā was ordered to dance before the assembled gods, and she did her part so well that the gods were mightily pleased, and Manasā Devī was requested by them to restore Lakṣmindara to life. Manasā Devī complied with this request after having extorted a promise from Behulā that she would induce her father-in-law to worship her. Manasā Devī was pleased with her devotion and wished to know if she had any other boon to ask. With clasped hands and tearful eyes, she said, "The sight of my widowed sisters-in-law will pain me, Divine mother! In your mercy restore my husband's brothers to life." This Manasā Devī did and further rewarded her by giving back the seven ships loaded with treasures, which Chānd had lost in the waters of Kālidaha. The Guābāri of Chānd was also restored to its original condition.

Manasā Devī grants all that Behulā seeks.

Behulā embarked with her husband and his brothers on board the ships and started homewards. She related to her husband the story of her sufferings, pointing to the places of their occurrence as they sailed back up the noble river Gāngoor, and her beautiful eyes swam with tears at their recollection. But the heart of Lakṣmindara was like to break for pain as he listened to the story of all she had endured.

On her way home.

When the ships came near Nichhaninagar, Behulā besought her husband to allow her to pay a flying visit to her poor parents, striken with grief. To this Lakṣmindara readily consented, saying, "Let us both go there under the guise of a Yogī and Yoginī." Behulā agreed gladly and immediately adopted the earings, the ochre-coloured clothes

Behulā and Laksmindara visit Nichhaninagar in disguise.

and the knotted hair distinctive of Yoginīs. Lakṣmindara took a *kamandalu* in his hand, and covered his beautiful body with ashes like a Yogī.

The meeting.

The seeming ascetics passed through Baruipārā and other places, and came to the home of Sāha, the merchant of Nichhaninagar. They entered the house by the back-door, and came directly to the inner apartments. At that moment, Amalā, the mother of Behulā, was coming out of the kitchen with a golden plate full of rice, for the dinner of Hari Sādhu, her eldest son, when the sight of the Yogī and Yoginī made her tremble with grief, the golden plate fell from her hand, and she wailed aloud, "This Yoginī is just like my Behulā!" she could say only this and no more. She ran up to the supposed Yoginī throwing her arms about her and swooned away. Behulā held her mother's head in her arms and tenderly caressed her, weeping profusely. When Amalā came to her senses, Behulā softly said, "We are come back, mother, once more to your arms. Yonder Yogī is your son-in-law restored to life."

To Champak Nagar.

The people of the whole village came to see them, but Behulā would not stop there even for a day. She was eager to go back to Champak Nagar, and in spite of their affectionate remonstrances, embarked once more on board the ship "Madhukar" and started for Champak Nagar that very day.

Behulā disguised as a sweeper-girl.

When they reached that city, however, she played another trick. She disguised herself as a sweeper-girl. While on her way back from heaven she had employed an artist to prepare a fan bedecked with precious stones in which the pictures of all the

members of Chāṇd's family were painted in living colours represented by the natural hues of precious stones.

With this fan in her hand, Behulā landed on the banks of the river Gāngoor. At that very moment her widowed sisters-in-law were coming to carry water, and were attracted by the fan, no less than by the beauty of the sweeper-girl. While examining the fan closely, they were struck with wonder to see the likenesses of the members of their own family painted upon the fan. They wanted to know who this sweeper-girl was and what she meant to do with the fan. Behulā said that she was called Behulā, the sweeper-girl, her husband's name was Lakṣmindara, the sweeper, and his father's name was Chānd, the sweeper, and her own father's name was Sāha, the sweeper. The fan was for sale, and its price was one lakh of rupees.

At this strange story the widows wept and went speedily home to acquaint queen Sanakā with what they had seen and heard. Sanakā ran to the house of steel and to her surprise found the lamp still burning and the rice still fresh on the golden plate. Then she came to the bank of the river and seeing the pictures on the fan and the face of the sweeper-girl, which reminded her of Behulā, she fell to the earth and began to rend the air with loud lamentations. Behulā then said, "Mother, do not weep. Look at your sons. Manasā Devī has restored them to life. But we cannot enter Champak Nagar until my father-in-law worships Manasā Devī. So I have brought all of you here by a device."

Once more the seven sons stood near their sorrow-stricken parents, and the tears that were shed were holy, for Behulā's wonderful devotion more than anything else caused them to flow.

Chānd worships Manasā Devī.

Chānd could not resist all this. Events had been too much for him. He saw in the sweet and resigned countenance of Behulā that Manasā Devī's victory was complete, and that it would be impossible for him to resist the appeal silently expressed in the eyes of his beloved daughter-in-law.

Chānd worshipped Manasā in the month of Srāvan on the 11th day of the waning moon. Some say that he offered flowers to Manasā Devī with his left hand as a mark of contempt, turning his face away from her all the while. But however this be, Manasā Devī was pleased and granted him wealth and prosperity. His friend, Sankoor Garudia was restored to life.

Behulā and Lakṣmindara, who were Ushā and Aniruddha in Heaven, and had been obliged to take a mortal frame under a curse, went back after a while to their celestial home.

Manasā Devī's claims to obtain *puja* among mortals have ever since been an established fact.*

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Sixty works on Manasā Devī. Their importance.

About sixty works on Manasā Devī, written by different writers at various times, but all before the 18th century have been brought to light by the researches of scholars within the last 15 years. Vijay Gupta's work, published by the Ādarça press

* Originally written for the Modern Review from which the story is now reprinted.

of Backergunge in 1896, contains 232 pages (royal octavo.) printed in double columns. It contains 15,000 lines and exceeds Milton's Paradise lost by half its bulk. Many of the other works referred to above are equally voluminous. Some of them contain graphic accounts of the sea voyage of Chānd Sadāgara and descriptions of the manner in which commercial enterprises were undertaken by the Bengalis in ancient times, with incidental references to the flourishing condition of Bengal and her industry. The geographical notices of places, the names of which are to be found in many of these works, bear witness to the changes constantly brought about in the plains of the Gangetic valley by its ever-shifting river courses.

Hari Datta the earliest writer of these songs.

The earliest writer on Manasā Devī in Bengal was Hari Datta, who was blind of one eye. We have come across only 20 lines of his composition. They describe the ornaments made of snakes which decorated the person of Manasā Devī. Hari Datta was born in the district of Mymensingh and probably lived in the 12th century. We have come across a description of him in a later poem written by Vijay Gupta in honour of Manasā Devī. Manasā Devī is said to have appeared before Vijay Gupta in a dream and said :—

The defects of his poems.

"An illiterate man first wrote a poem in my honour; but he had no idea of my power and glory. He was Hari Datta, the one-eyed. His irregular and metreless doggerel became obsolete and were lost in course of time. His words were vulgar, his lines did not rhyme and his songs

had no merit by which to attract the people. The singers tried to please by rude gestures and clownish leaps."*

He probably lived in the 12th century.

Vijay Gupta's work was written in 1484, when Hari Datta's poems, once so popular, had already grown obsolete. The ungracious references made to his deficiencies in metre and rhyme and to a preponderance of rude words in his poems, only prove them to be antiquated specimens of the earliest form of written Bengali. We may, on these grounds, safely declare Hari Datta to have lived a few centuries before Vijay Gupta. We are inclined to place him in the 12th century A.D.

Vijay Gupta.

Vijay Gupta's Manasā Maṅgal is one of the most popular works of its class. In Eastern Bengal, especially in the district of Backergunge, it is esteemed sacred and always read on the occasion of the worship of Manasā Devī. There they call poems about Manasā Devī, Rayanī. This word is a corruption of the word Rajānī or night, and the word Yāgaraṅa which is often used for these

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* মূর্খে রচিল গীত না জানে মাহাত্ম্য।
প্রথমে রচিল গীত কাণা হরিদত্ত॥
হরিদত্তের যত গীত লুপ্ত হৈল কালে।
ঘোড়াগাথা নাহি কিছু ভাবে মোরে ছলে॥
কথার সঙ্গতি নাই নাহিক সুস্বর।
এক গাইতে আর গায় নাই মিত্রাক্ষর॥
গীতে মতি না দেয় কিছু মিছা লাফ ফাল।
দেখিয়া শুনিয়া মোর উপজে বেতাল॥

Bijay Gupta's Padmā Purān.

songs, means vigil. These facts imply that poems about Manasā Devī used to be recited during the night. **Rayāni and Yagarańa.**

This happens during the whole of the Bengali month of Çrāvańa.

Vijay Gupta was born in the year 1448 in the village of Fullaçrī in the district of Backergunge. The pot with which he worshipped Manasā Devī is still preserved there in the temple dedicated to the goddess. Fullaçrī is a well-known village, and is the birth place of many scholars whose names are not unfamiliar to the literary world. Kavīndra Trilochana Dās, Jānakī Nāth Kavikanṭhhāra, Bhavānī Nāth Dās Saraswātī, Raghu Rām Dās Kanṭhābharṇa and Kavikarṅapur were all inhabitants of this particular village and Vijay Gupta with just pride speaks of it as Pandit Nagar or City of scholars. Here are some of his opening lines :— **Fullaçri—the native village of the poet.**

"In Çaka 1406 (1484 A.D.) Husen Sāhā is the Emperor of Gauḍa, and Rājā Arjuna as the morning sun of war rules Muluk Fateabād (the modern Faridpur and a part of Backergunge) which extends up to Bangrorā. On the west lies the river Ghāgarā, on the east the river Ghańteçvara, and between them the village of Fullaçrī, City of scholars. Brāhmins versed in four Vedās, and Vaīdyas skilled **His opening lines.**

ছায়াশূন্যবেদশশীপরিমিত শক।
সনাতন হুসেন সাহ নৃপতি তিলক॥
উত্তরে অর্জ্জুনরাজা প্রতাপেতে যম।
মুল্লুক ফতেয়াবাদ বঙ্গরোড়া তক সীম॥
পশ্চিমে ঘাঘর নদী পূর্ব্বে ঘণ্টেশ্বর।
মধ্যে ফুলশ্রী গ্রাম পণ্ডিতনগর॥

in their own Çāstras, and Kāyasthas who are expert-writers all live in this place. Whosoever dwells in this blessed spot has a share in its glory. In such a place is the home of Vijay." Ghanteçvara and Ghāgrā have both been silted up, though traces of them may yet be discovered and the site of the village Fullaçrī has become changed in course of time. The more important part of the village is now calld Gailā.

The contents of his Manasā Maṇgal.

Vijay Gupta belonged to the Vaidya caste, his father's name being Sanātana and his mother's, Rukminī. His Manasā Maṇgal is divided into the following cantos :—

1. Consultation.
2. Hymns to the gods.
3. Dreams.
4. The garden house of Chānd.
5. Birth of Manasā Devī.
6. An introductory notice of Manasā Devī.
7. The lamentations of Chandī
8. The beginning of the quarrel with Chānd.
9. Quarrel with Chandī.
10. Chandī restored to consciousness.
11. Marriage of Manasā Devī.

চারিবেদধারী তথা ব্রাহ্মণসকল।
বৈদ্য জাতি বৈসে তথা শাস্ত্রেতে কুশল॥
কায়স্থজাতি বৈসে তথা লিখিতে প্রচুর।
আর যত জাতি নিজ শাস্ত্রেতে চতুর॥
স্থান গুণে যেই জন্মে সেই গুণময়।
হেন ফুলশ্রী গ্রামে নিবসে বিজয়॥

Vijay Gupta's Padma Purāṅ.

12. Separation from her husband.
13. Birth of eight snakes
14. The churning of the sea.
15. Curse of Çiva on Manoharā, the cow.
16. Necter produced by churning.
17. Çiva loses his senses by swallowing poison.
18. Çiva restored to his senses.
19. Manasā Devī exiled to the forest.
20. Manasā Devī worshipped by the shepherds.
21. The story of Hāsan Husen.
22. Chānd's birth under the curse of Padmā.
23. The insult offered to Sanakā.
24. The destruction of the Guābāḍī (garden of Chānd).
25. Manasā Devī disguised as a milk-maid.
26. A heated discussion between Manasā Devī and the disciples of Çaṇkar Gāḍuriā.
27. Manasā Devī makes friendship with Kamalā, the wife of Çaṇkara Gāḍuriā.
28. The story of a chaste woman.
29. Death of Çaṇkara Gāḍuriā.
30. The destruction of Chānd's garden.
31. The Mahājñāna or knowledge by which life can be restored, is lost.
32. Manasā Devī kills the six sons of Chānd.
33. Manasā Devī is worshipped in the house of a fisherman.
34. Uṣā abducted by Aniruddha.
35. Manasā Devī's fight with the king of death (Yama).
36. Chānd undertakes a commercial tour.
37. Trade by barter.
38. The distress of Chānd.
39. Fourteen ships of Chānd destroyed.

40. Chānd introduces himself.
41. Birth of Lakṣmīndara.
42. Manasā Devī disguised as an ant.
43. The building of the house of steel.
44. Manasā Devī's conversation with Tārāvatī.
45. Lakṣmīndara sets out for his marriage.
46. The gods attend the marriage ceremony.
47. The canopy falls.
48. Lakṣmīndara sets out for home.
49. Eight snakes made prisoners.
50. A message sent to the serpent Kālī.
51. Kālī goes to bite Lakṣmīndara.
52. Lakṣmīndara is bitten.
53. His dying words.
54. The dream of Behulā.
55. The lamentations of Behulā and of Sanakā.
56. A white crow bears the message to Ujāni.
57. Hari Sādhu marches to meet his sister Behulā.
58. The interview.
59. Dom ghāt.
60. Dhanā and Manā ghāts.
61. The ghāt of a knave.
62. Netā comes as a tiger and a vulture.
63. The washerwoman's ghāt.
64. Behulā dances before Çiva.
65. Padmā sent to Manasā Devī.
66. Their meeting.
67. Grievances of the past twelve months.
68. Lakṣmīndara and his brothers restored to life and the ships recovered.
69. Çankar Gaḍuriā restored to life.
70. Behulā returns home.

71. The ghāts of Netā, of a knave, of Dhanā and Manā, of a man with elephantiasis, and of Hari Sādhu.

72. Behulā disguised as a sweeper-girl.

73. The trial of Behulā.

74. The meeting.

75. Manasā Devī worshipped.

76. The ascent into heaven (of Behulā and Lakṣmindara.)

These chapter-headings roughly indicate the contents of other poems on the same subject also. The literature in honour of Manasā Devī is vast and varied and is interesting from many different points of view. We have, however, no space to consider all these points with that thoroughness which they deserve.

Nārāyaṅa Deva.

Contemporary with Vijay Gupta was Nārāyaṅa Deva, another poet who lived in Boragrām in the sub-division of Kishoreganj in the district of Mymensingh. The Manasā Maṇgal of Nārāyaṅa Deva is almost as popular as that of Vijay Gupta in Eastern Bengal though a greater sanctity is attached to the latter's poem, owing to the preservation of his worship-pot in the village temple of Phullaçri. Nārāyaṅa Deva belonged to the Kāyastha caste. His father was Narasiṁha Deva. The ancestors of the poet were originally inhabitants of Magadha. Latterly they came down to Rāḍa Deça and settled there. From Rāḍa they made another move and settled in Mymensingh. Some descendants of Nārāyaṅa Deva still dwell in Boragrām, being 17th in descent from the poet.

Nārāyaṇa Deva's poetry.

Nārāyaṇa Deva was a fine poet. The following passage will show something of his pathos : Behulā is lamenting for the death of Lakṣmīndara :*—

Behulā laments.

" Where art thou gone, my lord, without me ? Awake beloved, lift up thine eyes and look upon thy Behulā. Alas ! that beauty which shone so bright, putting the sun and moon to shame, has been stolen away by the bite of Kālī, the snake. My *Sāri* of silk must now be torn off, my bracelets of shell must now be broken, and I, unfortunate that I am, must wipe off the vermilion from my fore-head. Oh my lord ! how long will you sleep ? Will you not wake and speak to me ? Will you not look again at my face ? Oh ! what fault have I committed against you, that you should make me wretched for ever ! To whose care have you left your miserable Behulā ?"

Again, Behulā is on the raft with the body of her husband, and her brother Nārāyani Sādhu is trying to dissuade her from the insane course she is following† :—

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* অমৃত সমান প্রভুরে তোমাব মুখের বাণী।
পুনরপি না শুনিলাম মুই অভাগিনী।
হাতের শঙ্খ ভাঙ্গিব কঙ্কণ করিব চুর।
মুছিয়া ফেলিব আমি সীথির সিন্দুর।
এ হেন সুন্দর রূপ প্রভুরে প্রকাশিত রজনী।
চন্দ্র সূর্য্য জিনিয়া রূপ হরিল নাগিনী।
চাঁপার কলিকা সম প্রভুরে তোমার কোমল অঙ্গুলি।
তুমি আমার প্রভুরে—অভাগী বেহুলারে ডাক চাহ চক্ষু মেলি।

† নারায়ণী শুনি বোলে বিপুলা বচন।
কি কারণে কৈলা ভইন অশক্য কথন॥

"Hearing Beḥulā's words, Nārāyaṅi Sādhu, her brother, says, "Why do you, O sister, follow a wild fancy that could never be carried into practice? How did such an idea seize you? Where was it ever heard that gods and men can meet? Allow me, O sister, to burn your dead husband. How can you all alone reach heaven, the abode of the gods. How can we let you drift out to sea! Where is the abode of the gods that you would reach? With precious sandal and scented bark I will burn Lakṣmīndara's corpse and perform here the ceremony of his funeral. Come back, O sister, to your childhood's home. You may fast like a widow, but we shall feed you with every dainty. Your shell-bracelets may be broken, and the vermilion gone from your head. This is no matter! for we shall give you other and

Nārāyaṅī entreats her to return home.

বিষম সায়স ভইন কৈলা কি কারণ।
দেবতা মনিষ্য কোথা হইছে দরশন॥
আজ্ঞা দেহ ভইন মরা পুড়িবারে।
একেশ্বর কেমনে যাইবা দেবঘরে॥
কেমতে ছাড়িয়া দিমু সাগর ভিতর।
কথাতে পাইবা তুমি দেবের নগর॥
আগোরি চন্দন কাটে লখাই পুড়িমু।
লক্ষিন্দর কর্ম্ম ভইন এই খানে করিমু॥
নেউটিয়া চল ভইন আপনার ঘরে।
একেশ্বর কেমতে যাইবে দেবঘরে।
মৎস্যমাংস এড়ি ভইন যত উপহার।
সর্ব্বদ্রব্য দিমু আমি তুমি খাইবার।
শঙ্খসিন্দূরমাত্র না পরিবা তুমি।
নানা অলঙ্কার তোমা দিমু আমি।

richer ornaments to wear. When my mother asks me about you, how can I tell her that we left her Behulā drifting on the water?" At this point the brother's emotion overcomes him ; Behulā to soothe him, said—'But I have come here determined to restore my husband's life, and you ask me to leave him to be devoured by the beasts of prey that live in the water ? Our relations at Champak Nagar would ask me what I have done with his body, and what should I say to them in reply ?' Hearing these words Nārāyani Sādhu, weeping, said, "Oh sister, I cannot leave you, I cannot go. That madman Chānd Sadāgara has no proper feeling, his mind has gone astray. He has floated down the living with the dead ! On the turbulent river, the waves rise and fall. If you should fall, you will be devoured by sea fish and shark. O how shall I answer our mother when she asks me about you ! What shall I say to our friends in Ujāninagar ?" Thus by his lamentations Nārāyani Sādhu strove to soften her heart, and bring her back to home. The

Behulā's reply.

Nārāyani laments.

মাএ জিজ্ঞাসিলে আমি কি দিব উত্তর।
বিপুলা রাখিআ আইলা জলের উপর।
বিপুলা রাখিতে সাধু করএ ক্রন্দন।
বিপুলাএ বোলে কিছু প্রবোধবচন।
জীআইতে আইল প্রভু যাইমু পলাইয়া।
কেমতে মুখত জন্তু দিবাম তুলিয়া।
অসতী হইব মনিষ্য লোকেতে প্রচার।
কি কারণে এতেক যে রাখিমু খাথার।
গোত্র জ্ঞাতি আছে চম্পক নগর।
তারা কি বলিব আমি কি দিব উত্তর।

poet Nārāyaṅa lays down these verses at the feet of Manasā Devī.

Behulā bids farewell to her brother.

When however having tried every means in his power, he failed to dissuade Behulā, then, with a grieved heart he left her, and she bidding farewell to her brother, sailed on and on. The raft flew swiftly, like a shooting-star, and she came to a place called the Bāgher Bānk."

বিপুলা শুনিআ বাক্য নিষ্ঠুর বচন।
সকরুণ ভাসে সাধু করএ ক্রন্দন।
শুকবি নারায়ণ দেবের সরস পাঁচালী।
নারায়ণী করুণা শুন একটি লাচাড়ি।
কাঁদে নারায়ণী সাধু কহএ বিপুলা চাইআ।
প্রাণে না সয় দুঃখ না দিমু এড়িয়া।
অবুদ্ধিয়া সদাগর বুদ্ধি অতি ছার।
জীয়তা ভাসাইআ দিছে সইতে মরার।
বিষম সাগরে ঢেউ তোলপার করে।
জলেত পড়িলে খাইব মৎস্য আর মকরে।
মাএ জিজ্ঞাসিলে আমি কি দিব উত্তর।
কি কথা কহিব আমি উজানী নগর।
বিপুলা রাখিতে সাধু করএ ক্রন্দন।
নারায়ণ দেবে কহে মনসাচরণ।
বিস্তর যতন করি রাখিতে না পারিয়া।
চিত্তে ক্ষেমা দিয়া বায় ভেরুআ ভাসাইয়া।
ভাইত বিদায় করি বিপুলা সুন্দরী।
ছাড়াইয়া জাএ তবে ভুরাখান মেলি।
নৈথত্রসঞ্চার যেন ভুরার চলন।
সম্মুখে বাঘের বাঁকে দিলা দরশন।

Kṣemānanda.

The next Manasā Maṅgal that we light upon was written by Kṣemānanda—a Kāyastha, who adopted also the name of Ketakā Dās. Ketakā occurs in the poem, as a name of Manasā Devī. thus Ketakā Dās means 'servant of Manasā Devī.'

In his autobiographical notice the poet refers to Bārā Khān, as the ruler of Selimābād in the district of Burdwan. Now, this Bārā Khān, as we know from other sources, made a deed of gift of twenty bighās of land to one Çivarām Bhattāchāryya in the year 1640 A. D. Kṣemānanda regrets the circumstance that the Khān has been killed in battle. Hence his Manasā Māṅgal must have been written at some date later than 1640. Kṣemānanda was born in the village of Kānthrā in the district of Burdwan and held lands in the Tāluk of one Oskarṅa Rāy.

Kṣemānanda's Manasār Bhāsāna contains 5,000 lines, and forms rather a brief version of the story as compared with other poems on the same subject. But it happens to-day to be the most popular poem on Manasā Devī. Its poetical merits, no less than its brevity, account for this extensive popularity. I give here an extract from it :—*

The reason of his popularity.

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* মায়রূপে ভিক্ষা মাগে বেহুলা নথাই।
নিছনি নগরে লোক কেহ চিনে নাই।
বেহুলা নথাই দোঁহে যোগী আর যোগিণী।
ঘরে ঘরে মাগে ভিক্ষা হইয়া মায়াবিনী
সবাকার বাড়ী গিয়া শিঙ্গার ধ্বনি করে।
শিব শিব বলিয়া তাদের নিখরে।
বেহুলা নথাই ভিক্ষা মাগে বাড়ী বাড়ী।
থালের উপরে কেউ দেয় চাউল কড়ি।

Lakṣmīndara and Behulā are disguised as a Yogī and Yoginī.

Yogī and Yoginī.

"Lakṣmīndara and Behulā in disguise, begged from door to door. But the people of Nichhani Nagar did not recognise them. They visited every house begging alms, and they sounded the horn as they passed, reciting the name of Çiva. People threw rice and cowries on their plate; but as soon as they were given, the alms disappeared and no one could tell how they had vanished. Behulā's father was Sāha—the merchant. His house stood in the centre of the village; around it were large and beautiful straw-built sheds, which were like lofty walls, and inside was a house that sparkled with gold. There lived Sāha the merchant with his wife Amalā. Behulā went to see her parents. As she was disguised, no one recognised her. It was mid-day and the sun was up. The seeming Yogī and Yoginī entered the inner appartments. The Yogī sounded his horn and Amalā came out.

থালে দিতে চাল কড়ি আচম্বিতে উভে।
বুঝিতে না পারে কেহ বলে নানা ভাবে।
বেহুলার বাপ যিনি সায় সদাগর।
নগরের মধ্যস্থলে তার বটে ঘর।
অপূর্ব্ব ঘরের দ্বার বিচিত্র আকার।
প্রাচীর প্রমাণ তার চারিদিকে ঘর।
বাটীর ভিতরে দ্বার সোণার নিছনি।
সায় সদাগর তাতে অমলা বেণেণী।
বেহুলা নাচনী গেল মা বাপ দেখিতে।
মায়া বলে কেহ তারে না পারে চিনিতে।

On a golden plate she brought rice and cowries to present to the supposed ascetics. But Lakṣmīndara hid his face for a moment on seeing his mother-in-law. Behulā smiled softly ; the smile on her lips was as sweet as nectar. Amalā placed cowries and rice on her plate, but they disappeared as soon as given, through the spell cast by Manasā Devī. Amalā saw this and asked the reason saying ' Tell me, O Yoginī !—who you are ! There does not dwell a creature in the three worlds more unfortunate than I ! Beholding you my grief overpowers me. There was, O Yoginī—a daughter of mine, who strangely resembled you ; but she sailed away with her husband's dead body, and I know not to what region she has gone. On seeing you, O Yoginī, my grief for her is rekindled.

দুই প্রহর বেলা যখন গগণ মণ্ডলে ।
যোগী আর যোগিণী তারা প্রবেশে মহলে ।
সত্য জানি বলি হয় শিঙ্গার যে ধ্বনি ।
ঘর হইতে শুনে তাহা অমলা বেণেণী ।
সুবর্ণের থালায় দিবেন চাল কড়ি ।
নথাই অন্তর হইল দেখিয়া শ্বাশুড়ি ।
নথাই বিমুখ হইল পরম লজ্জায় ।
বেহুলা ঈষৎ হাসে পিযুষের প্রায় ।
চাল কড়ি দেয় বামা যোগিণীর থালে ।
আচম্বিতে উভ তাহা দেবী অনুবলে ।
অমলা বেণেণী তখন দেখি এত সব ।
যোগিণীরে জিজ্ঞাসিল করি বহু স্তব
সত্য সত্য কহ মোরে শুন গো যোগিনী ।
ত্রিভুবন মধ্যে আমি বড় অভাগিনী ।

Tell me then in your mercy, how is it that the rice and cowries have disappeared.' Behulā said 'We are Yogī and Yoginī, we live under the trees. We beg alms in the day-time and at evening we return to our resting place. We know nothing more than this.' But Amalā her mother looked intently at the face of Behulā, beautiful as a lotus, and said 'No, you are Behulā—my own Behulā ; Oh ! my heart breaks to see you; my Behulā and Lakṣmīndara, stand before me ! Tell me truly that you are no other.' 'O mother' Behulā said 'what introduction do we need to you ? We are your own Behulā and Lakṣmīndara, cry no more, O mother. Here is the husband of my heart, restored to life !' At these words, Amalā broke into sobs, and hearing her weep, the people of the

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তোমায় দেখিয়া শোকে কান্দে মম প্রাণ।
মোর এক কন্যা ছিল তোমার সমান।
না জানি কোথায় গেল মড়া লৈয়ে কোলে।
যোগিণী জাগালে শোক বেহুলা বদলে।
বিশেষ করিয়া মোরে কহ অর্থমূল।
থালে দিতে নাই কেন কড়ি আর তণ্ডুল।
বেহুলা বলেন তুমি কি কর জিজ্ঞাসা।
যোগী যোগিণী মোরা তরুতলে বাসা।
নগরে মাগিয়া খাই হাতে করি থালা।
সন্ধ্যাকাল হইলে মোরা যাই তরুতলা।
ইহা বিনা আর মোরা কিছু নাহি জানি।
ইথে বিনা বুঝ তুমি অমলা বেণেনী।
অমলা বেহুলা মুখপদ্ম যে নেহালে।
দ্বিতীয় বেহুলা তুমি বেহুলা বদলে।

village ran to her house. They asked her what it was that made her cry! Some said that Behulā had returned. People were struck with wonder,—the dead Lakṣmīndara had come to life again! Said they 'we never saw or heard of such a thing—Behulā has restored her husband to life.'

Other authors of Mansā Maṅgal.

The names of most of the other authors of Manasā Maṅgal known up to now, are here enumerated. The latest of these writers, Rājā Rājsiṁha of Susung Durgāpur in the district of Mymensing lived 125 years ago.

4. Rāmajīvana (1770 A. D.)
5. Rājā Rājsiṁha.

তোমারে দেখিয়া মোর বিদরে হৃদয়।
বেহুলা নথাই বটে দেহ পরিচয়।
বেহুলা বলেন পরিচয় দিব কি।
যোগী তোর জামাই যোগিণী তোর ঝি।
বেহুলা নথাই বটে না কান্দিহ আর।
প্রাণপতি জিয়াইয়া করি যে উদ্ধার।
শুনিয়া অমলা কান্দে পাইয়া পূর্ব্ব শোক।
ক্রন্দন শুনিয়া আইল নগরের লোক।
কেন কান্দ শোন বলি অমলা বেণেণী।
কেহ বলে দেশে আইল বেহুলা নাচুণী।
দেখিয়া শুনিয়া লোকে লাগে চমৎকার।
মৃত লখিন্দর জিয়ে আইল পুনর্ব্বার
কোথাও না দেখি হেন কোথাও না শুনি।
মৃত পতি জিয়াইল বেহুলা নাচুনী।

From Behulā's visit to her father's house by Ketakā Dās Kṣemananda.

6. Anupa Chandra.
7. Krishnānanda.
8. Gangādās Sen.
9. Gopī Chandra.
10. Pāndit Gangā Dās.
11. Golaka Chandra.
12. Govinda Dās.
13. Chandrapati.
14. Jagat Vallabha.
15. Vipra Jagannātha.
16. Jagannāth Sen.
17. Jagamohan Mitra.
18. Jaydev Dās.
19. Dwija Jay Rām.
20. Vipra Jānakināth.
21. Jānakīnath Dās.
22. Nanda Lāl.
23. Nārāyaṇa.
24. Dwija Valarāma.
25. Valarāma Dās.
26. Vāṇeçwar.
27. Madhusudan De.
28. Yadunāth Pandit.
29. Raghunāth.
30. Viprarata Dev.
31. Rāmākāntha.
32. Rāti Kānthasen.
33. Dwija Rasik Chandra.
34. Rādhā Krishṇa.
35. Rāmchandra.
36. Viprarām Dās.
37. Rāmdās Sen.
38. Rām Nidhi.
39. Rām Vinoda.

40. Dwija Vaṁçī Dās.
41. Vaṁçīdhana.
42. Vanamālī
43. Vardhamān Dās.
44. Vallabha Ghose.
45. Vijaya.
46. Vipra Dās.
47. Viçveçvar.
48. Viṣṇu Pāl.
49. Ṣasthībara Sen.
50. Sītāpati.
51. Sukavi Dās.
52. Sukha Dās.
53. Sudām Dās.
54. Dwija Hari Rām.
55. Dwija Hridaya.
56. Kamal Nārāyaṇa.
57. Kavi Karṇapur.
58. Haridās.

Behulā typifies the ideal of womanhood in Bengal.

In closing this account of the literature of the Manasā-cult, it must be remembered that in a country where women commonly courted death on their husband's funeral pyre, this story of Behulā may be regarded as the poet's natural tribute at the feet of their ideal.

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(6) Songs in honour of Chandī Devī.

Religion the main spring of our activity.

Religion has been the main-spring of activity in this country from the earliest times. Astronomy originated with us, from the necessity for calculating the auspicious times for holding sacrifices. Geometry came into existence in order to settle the

shape and size of altars. Poetry welled up for the singing of hymns to God. Mundane considerations never seriously occupied the attention of Indians or served as any inspiration to them.

How the poems gradually improved.

Bengali poetry was employed in its earlier stages for religious purposes. Poems in honour of Manasā Devī, Chandī and other local deities testify to the same inspiring motive in their writers. The songs in honour of the house-hold deities had to be recited on the occasions of their worship. This was enjoined as a part of the religious function itself. Men and women assembled in great numbers in places of worship, inspired by faith, and the poets who wrote the poems gradually felt the need to make their performance really interesting and attractive. The earliest specimens of songs, in honour of the tutelary deities of Bengal, are generally short. They gave stories in brief form illustrating the might and grace of particular deities. For this purpose, a short and simple tale, without any pretensions to scholarship or poetical merit, was first composed ; the next poet sought to improve upon this work, and as particular religious sects gained ground and counted increasing numbers of votaries, their religious poems also improved, till the mere outlines of the earlier writers grew into elaborate poems in the hands of later poets.

Religion inspires art and poetry.

Here, in Bengal, people lived in straw-built huts themselves, while the oratory of their tutelary deity was often made of bricks, and rich people living in brick-built mansions, always spent far larger sums of money on their chapels than on their own dwelling rooms. The finest touches of decora-

tive art they could command were employed to adorn the temple. The idea of luxury could have no hold upon a people who lived plainly themselves but applied their æsthetic talents and capital to religious purposes. It could not produce any heart-burning by creating a sense of social inequality, as the ownership of a Matha or temple could not give rise to jealousy, however great and costly might be its decoration. The portals of a temple were open to all equally. At the same time art received its highest impetus from religious motive.

Bengali poetry also, like these chapels, had for its chief and primary object the worship of deities till it gradually become intermixed and enriched with romantic incidents of the human world, even as the walls and door-ways of a temple were decorated with fresco-paintings and sculptures on bas-relief representing scenes from life.

However crude may be the poetic literature dealt with in these chapters, it always makes an attempt to give expression to the truth that righteousness is upheld by the Almighty's law, that faith conquers in the long run and that the sceptic with all his brilliance and power ultimately sinks into insignificance.

The songs to which we have referred, formed the *popular* literature of Bengal and existed in some crude shape in the country before the Pourānik Renaissance. Though latterly taken up by the Brahmanic School, their subjects had been conceived and worked out by the people in an earlier epoch of our history when Brahmanic power had not yet asserted itself. The Brahmins improved these compositions by introducing Sanskrit

The poems originated with the people.

words and many fine passages of classical beauty into them, but the subject-matter of the poems proves that it was the people who gave them their original shape. The chief characters do not belong to the highest castes and the Brahmin has hardly any part in the drama of the poems. Dhanapati, Çrimanta, Lahanā, Khullanā, Chānd, Behulā,—the main personages in all these poems, belong to the merchant-classes, which do not hold a very high position in Hindu society. The hunter Kālaketu comes from one of the lowest castes. In the manner in which the deities are represented to help their votaries, there is evidently a coarse and rustic element which indicates that the poems originated with the populace, rather than with the more refined classes. In any case, it is the people who still patronise them, for by far the larger number of the Mss. of these poems I recovered from the houses of carpenters, blacksmiths and other artizans. The Sanskritic School of poets, while embellishing the style and diction of these works, could not, at the same time, rebuild the plot or otherwise improve their subject-matter.

History of the Chandī cult.

The history of the origin of the Chandi-cult is not easy to trace. Whether she was originally the deity of the Mongolians and Dravadians, latterly admitted into the Hindu pantheon, as we have supposed,—or she represents in an altered garb the mythological tradition of Semeremis, the queen of Assyria, who conquered Bactria about 2000 B. C.—or as the Indian Anna Purna she is to be identified with Anna Perenna the goddess of the Romans, distributing cakes, whose festivals were celebrated on the 15th of March, is a problem which is not

within the scope of this treatise to solve. The late discovery made in Crete by Dr. Evans of the image of a goddess standing on a rock with lions on either sides, which is referred to a period as remote as 3000 B. C. has offered another startling point in regard to the history of the Chandī-cult. The mother in the Hindu mythology rides a lion, and in Mārkandeya Chandī there is a well-known passage where she stands on a rock with a lion beside, her for warring against the demons.

As heretofore mentioned, there was latterly an attempt on the part of the Brahmin poets to connect the humble deities worshipped by rural folk with the gods and goddesses of the Paurānic pantheon. Maṅgal Chandī—a popular deity, was thus associated by the later poets with that Chandi who was described by Mārkandeya.

There are two stories which from the subject-matter of all poems in honour of Maṅgal Chandi. The first one is—

The story of Kālaketu.

Nilāmbara, son of Indra, was born into this world under a curse, as Kālaketu, the hunter. He married Phullarā, daughter of Ṣaṇjayaketu, who used to sell in the market the venison and other flesh that he brought by hunting, and thus the pair earned their livelihood. The wild beasts of the forest, with the lion at their head, applied to Chandī for protection, as Kālaketu seemed bent on annihilating them. The lion himself was somewhat crest-fallen as he could not give effective aid to those who owed allegiance to him as their Lord. Chandi was moved to compassion and granted the

Kālaketu and the beasts.

boon that Kālaketu should no longer be able to molest or destroy them.

It was morning and the dairy maids were carrying their curds in pitchers to the market for sale. On the right the cows were grazing in the pastures and the village looked lovely under the morning breeze. Kālaketu the hunter, with his quiver on his back and a great bow in his hand, and crystal ear-drops in his ears went forth on his usual hunting excursion. As he was about to enter the dense forest, he saw a lizard of a golden colour. This lizard, he thought, was not a good omen. He tied up the animal with the string of his bow and thought it would serve for a meal if no other should be forthcoming that day.

The lizard tied up.

By the will of Chandī, a dense fog covered the forest that morning, and though Kālaketu wandered all round it in quest of a quarry, he could find none. Growing hungry, as the day advanced, with his fruitless search, he returned home, and acquainted his wife Phullarā with the tale of his disappointment. He suggested that she should go to their neighbour Bimalā and ask for the loan of a few seers of *khud* or rice-dust and some salt, and pointed out the lizard which lay bound with the string of his bow; this might also be killed and cooked, as no better could be found, to appease their hunger for the day.

Kālaketu returns home.

Phullarā went to her friend Bimalā for the loan and in the meantime Kālaketu found in the cottage a small quantity of flesh left unsold the day before. He carried this to Golā ghāt to try if any purchaser could be found for it.

Goes to Golā Ghāt.

The lizard was Chandī in disguise.

The lizard, who was no other than Chandī herself, now came out from the noose in which she was tied and assumed the form of a beautiful woman. Her complexion was of the colour of Atasi flower and her dark hair fell down her back in luxuriant curls. She looked like a damsel of sixteen. Her silk *sāri*, her golden bracelets, her necklace sparkling with precious diamonds, her bodice embroidered with gems inset by Viçva Karmā himself, the god of art, the majesty of her demeanour—all indicated her noble rank, seemingly that of a queen. When poor Phullarā came back to her hut, she could not trust her own eyes. Bewildered, she made a low obeisance to the lady, asking her who she was and why she had condescended to grace their lowly dwelling place with her august presence.

Phullarā is bewildered.

She misunderstands Chandī.

Chandī gave her story in language which had a double meaning. She said that her husband was old and poor and showered his favour on her co-wife, whom he placed on his head, while she was treated with great indifference. This referred to Çiva, the co-wife being the Ganges, who is represented as borne on the head of the Great God. But Phullarā understood the statement in its ordinary sense and did not at all suspect her guest, to be the goddess Chandī.

She advises her to return to her own home.

Poor Phullarā, living in great poverty, prided herself on the love of her husband and was contented. She did not now wish the beautiful damsel to be seen by Kālaketu; so hiding her jealousy as best she could, with smiles, she advised her to return to her own home. "For" said she "the night is approaching, and it is not safe for one of your position to spend the night in a stranger's

house." "You call your husband a stranger to me?" Said Chandī, "but he is devoted to me!" and indeed it was true that Kālaketu the hunter was a worshipper of Chandī. At these words of the goddess, Phullarā's voice became choked with tears; but without manifesting any external sign of her emotion, she quoted from the Çāstras to show the grave indiscretion of staying in a strange house without permission. "Think of Sītā" she said "how faultless she was, yet she was put to shame, because she had lived in Rāvaṇa's house for a time; Reṇukā, the wife of Bhrigu, was beheaded because her husband suspected her. If your co-wife quarrels with you, you can surely give tit for tat. Why should you leave your husband's roof for that?"

Phullarā describes her poverty.

"I understand my own affairs," said Chandi, "it is not for you to instruct me in my duty." At this, a feeling of great unrest overtook Phullarā, and she tried by a description of her abject poverty to work upon her guest's mind, that she might give up the idea of staying with them. She said, "only look, lady, at my poor hut, the roof made of palm leaves, supported on a single post made of ricinus tree! It breaks every year in the summer-storms. In the month of Vaiçākha, the fierce sun glares over head and its rays are like living fire. There is no shade to be found under the trees, my feet burn on the hot sands, as I go to the market to sell the meat. My torn rags are so scanty that I can scarcely draw them up to cover my head. If I leave my basket in the market for a moment, the kites fall upon it, and empty it immediately. Through the days of

The Vāra-Masi.

Jyaiṣṭha we have scarcely any food, and live, for the most part, on wild berries. In the months of Aṣāḍha and Çrāvaṇa, when the newly formed clouds cover the sky, the village roads become muddy and pools full of water, a host of leeches bite me as I go out, though a snake-bite would be more welcome, for it would end my miseries. In the month of Bhādra, our whole village is flooded and scarcely can I find a customer for my meat. At the approach of Açvina, every one, seems to be happy, and the goddess Umā is worshipped in big houses. There is dance and merry-making, and people are dressed in beautiful raiment. But goats are sacrificed to the Goddess at every house, so our meat will not sell in the market, and in this hut we have so often to fast. In the winter-months, the little fire that we kindle with stray fuel gathered from the woods scarcely warms us. For want of clothes, I often wear the skin of a deer, which but ill protects me from cold. Then comes the spring season, when the jasmine blooms and the bee whispers love to it gathering its honey. With the spring's soft influence in their hearts, maidens and youths are love-sick. But poor Phullarā feels only the pain of hunger. Why do you, Oh noble lady, court a life so wretched as must be that of a hunter's wife." Her eyes glistened with tears as she related the story of her woes.

Love's amends.

Nor did she at all exaggerate her miseries; only Kālaketu's love made such amends for the ills of life that she did not mind them. When the hunter's well-formed strong arm served as a pillow to her in the night, what she did she care for want of a nice bed? When eating what she

had cooked, Kālaketu praised her for her good cooking, what did she care that no food was left for her! Did she not feel gratified that her husband was happy, though she might have to fast all day herself? And who was this woman that came now to rob her of her husband's love—the only thing she prized in life? Alas, exposure and hardship had sullied her youthful beauty; could she ever be a match for this paragon of beauty! She had no qualifications to commend her to her husband, except her love for him. What will she do now? Her heart broke at these thoughts. But Chandī was not at all moved by the accounts of poverty. "Very well Phullarā," she said, "from this day there will be no more poverty in this house. You see my jewels? With them I can buy a kingdom. Come, do not grieve, you will have a share of my wealth and I shall not be blamed for coming here: for Kālaketu himself brought me, drawing me hither by his noble qualities."

Phullarā feels Jealousy.

This was what Phullarā understood her to say. But indeed her words bore another sense, and in that sense were true; for she said Kālaketu himself had brought her there *bound with the string of his bow.* The word গুণ in Bengali means both a bow-string and noble qualities.

Grief was like to rend Phullarā's heart at these last words of Chandī. She could no longer suppress her feelings. Great tears fell from her eyes, and she turned and went weeping all the way to meet Kālaketu at Golāghāt. There, as the hunter was negotiating the sale, Phullarā approached him with tearful eyes. He was struck with wonder—never

The Jealous wife and her hungry lord.

having seen her moved in such a manner—and asked what was it that caused her so much pain. "You have no co-wife," he said "and no sister-in-law nor mother-in-law to quarrel with you in the house. Why then, O my darling, do you weep?" Phullarā replied, "I have none, my lord, to quarrel with. It is true that you are my all. But it is you who have caused me this pain. What fault did you find in me that you have become a villain like Rāvana! Whose wife have you brought to our house? The king of Kaliṅga is a cruel tyrant. He will kill you and rob me of my honour by force, if he gets the slightest inkling of your act."

Kālaketu stood wonder-struck for a moment and then said "This is no time for joking. I am dying of hunger. If what you charge me with is false, I shall cut off your nose with a knife. Kālaketu's address was rough but straight-forward, as befitted an illiterate huntsman of his class. It is difficult for the foreign reader to understand the abhorrence with which the huntsman is regarded in Bengal life. He is something of a poacher, something of a trapper and altogether a savage. Throughout this poem, the poet seeks to deprive Kālaketu of any refinement as will appear from this coarse threat to his wife. Phullarā, of course, was far from being sorry at his abuse; for his words indicated his innocence. Both of them, therefore, hurried home, and when near the hut, Kālaketu saw a strange sight, as though ten thousand moons illumined the vault of night. A damsel whose beauty dazzled the eyes, was standing with gaze fixed on the sky. The glowing light of evening fell on her profuse black hair, tinting it with a golden hue. She looked like

A Strange sight.

a statue of stainless marble carved in relief against the azure. She wore a crown on her head which shone in the light, the diamonds sparkling with wonderful brilliance. The majesty of her form struck the huntsman dumb. He fell to the ground, bowing down to her in reverence. After this, he asked her who she was and what was her mission there. Chandī stood silent without a word. Then Kālaketu said, "The home of a huntsman is deemed unholy. The bones of animals lie strewn around it, and it is filled with the smell of rotten meat. For any one, of your position, this is not a fit place to come to. It will require you a bath in the Ganges to cleanse you of your sin, in coming to visit such foul quarters. Why is it, O mother, I ask again, that you have come here?" Chandī still gave no reply. The hunter continued :—

"The world will speak ill of you if you remain in this house ; and infamy, you know, is death to woman. Come with me, leave the house and I am ready to lead you back to your home. But I shall not go alone with you ; Phullarā will accompany us, and we shall select a path frequented by our friends. In reply to this Chandī uttered not a word, and Kālaketu said impatiently "You are no doubt the daughter of a rich man and a rich man's wife too. I am only a poor huntsman whose touch is avoided by all. What business can there possibly be that would bring you to my house? I humbly beg that you should leave this house at once." But Chandī smiled and did not at all seem inclined to move. Then the huntsman said 'Be witness, O setting sun, that this woman means mischief;" and taking his bow he aimed an arrow at her. To his great surprise he

He aims an arrow at her.

found, however, that he could not shoot. His hands seemed to be controlled by a mysterious power. The arrow could not be released and both it and the bow became rigid in his hands. Phullarā came to his rescue, but could not take away either the bow or the arrow from her husband's hands. Kālaketu stood like one, turned to stone, and for causes unknown to himself, tears fell from his eyes. He tried to speak but could not. He seemed to be fixed to the spot by a spell and stood, looking like a painted archer.

A painted archer.

Chandī appears in her own form.

Chandī said, "My son, I am Chandī. I have come to help you in your poverty. You will worship me on the third day of every week. Only place my *ghat* in your home and there will be no end to your prosperity.

Kālaketu, now restored to speech, said "Pardon me, but how can I believe you to be Chandī? My whole life has been spent in wickedness. I have killed numberless animals—in fact killing is my avocation. You probably know some spell by which you have overpowered me. If you are really Chandī then mercifully show yourself to me, O Divine Mother, in that form in which you are worshipped by the world."

In a moment the figure of the damsel grew in size. The crown on her head seemed to touch the starry regions of the sky, and her ten arms holding the lotus, the discus, the triand, and other weapons were extended outwards in the ten directions. Her gracious face, full of majesty and glory, smiled on him with motherly love. Her apparel bedecked with jewels, fluttered in the evening breeze. One of

her feet was placed on a lion and the other on the demon-king Mahiṣāsura. Thus sublime and awe-inspiring, she revealed herself to the sight of the mortal couple and the winds threw treasures of the flowers to the feet of the gracious mother of the universe.

Kālaketu and Phullarā with folded palms stood before Chandī, tears still flowing from their eyes. Gradually the form of Chandī faded away in the sky. The whole thing appeared to have been an illusion. The tint of the Divine Mother was merged in the colour of the Atasī flower which abounded in the place. Her hair vanished in the clouds. Her majesty spread itself in the quiet glow of the firmament, and slowly the glorious vision passed away. The earth and heaven appeared like the sacred emblem of her divine presence. Then, once more she stood before them in the form of the beautiful damsel standing at the cottage door, and asking what boon the couple would beg of her. Kālaketu only half articulately said, "Oh Mother, we want nothing more, our life is made blessed; our wants are all satisfied."

Chandī gives them wealth.

Chandī now bestowed a valuable ring on the huntsman and showed where a great treasure lay buried in seven jars. She also helped him to carry the treasure to his cottage. Her command was, that Kālaketu should found a kingdom in Guzrat with the money and there rule his subjects justly, and introduce the worship of Chandī amongst them.

Kālaketu and Murari Çila.

Next morning Kālaketu went forth with the ring to turn into hard-cash. The money changer to whom he applied was Murāri Çila, a dishonest fellow, who

tried to cheat him of the precious possession by paying him a nominal value. But the diamond in the ring was peerless and Chandī had told Kālaketu of its value. After much haggling the price was settled at seven crores of rupees.

Kālaketu becomes king of Gujrāt.

With this money, and the treasure found in the jars, he proceeded to Guzrat where he cut down the forests and founded a city in honour of Chandī. A great flood in the meantime overtook the kingdom of Kaliṅga and the people there became homeless. With Vulān Maṅdala at their head they came to Guzrāt in crowds to inhabit it. Amongst them came Bhāru Datta—a knave who, with his glib tongue and high sounding phrases won his way into the confidence of King Kālaketu ; but Bhāru grievously oppressed the people, and so he was turned out of Guzrāt by order of the King. While in this plight he uttered a mysterious threat, saying, "Phullarā the Queen will soon be reduced again to her old position as the wife of a huntsman. She will once more carry baskets on her head as she used to do." He went to Kaliṅga and there gaining access to the court of the king, gave information as to how Kālaketu formerly a poor huntsman in his dominion, had now founded a new kingdom in Guzrat by taking away with him, nearly half the population of Kaliṅga. At this report the monarch's anger knew no bounds. He led an hostile expedition and Kālaketu was conquered and thrown into prison. There in deep despair, the huntsman offered prayer to Chandī. He was to be beheaded the next morning. In this desperate plight he looked up to heaven and prayed with all his heart to have once more a sight of that Mother of the Universe

Bhāru Datta.

Kālaketu is conquered by the king of Kaliṅga.

who had condescended to visit his cottage when he was a huntsman. She came again and held out her gracious hand offering him her benediction. That night a terrible dream was dreamt by the king of Kalinga that his army was destroyed mysteriously by some unseen agency. He was so impressed that next day he restored Kālaketu to his kingdom, and his own army was restored to life by the grace of Chandī. Bhāru Datta was turned out from both the kingdoms and the two kings became fast friends.

Restored to his kingdom.

Bhāru punished.

Shortly after this, Kālaketu died and went to heaven, as Nilāmvara, son of Indra the period of the curse having expired. Phullarā who had been Chhāya, Nilāmbara's wife and had been born as the daughter of Sañjayaketu with the object of sharing the misfortunes of her husband, accompanied him to heaven, on the expiration of her self-imposed term of life on earth.

The term of curse over.

Puṣpaketu, son of Kālaketu and Phullarā, then became the King of Guzrāt.

Puspaketu succeeds.

We now pass to the second of these two companion-stories, which, although different, always form a single volume:

The Story of Çrīmanta Sadāgar.

Ratnamālā, a nymph of Indra's heaven was, under a curse, born on earth as Khullanā.

Khullanā.

The merchant Dhanapati was in the full vigour of his youth. He was a well built man of handsome features, well-versed in the fashionable learning of the day and immensely rich. He had a wife named Lahaṅā.

Dhanapati and his favourite play.

His favourite amusement was playing with pigeons. The male pigeon was taken to the forest and there let loose while its mate was kept in the house of our hero—many miles off. The male pigeon would then, inspite of obstructions, fly back home to join his companion and the homeward flight of the bird through the sky would be enthusiastically watched by the young men who sported with them. One day Dhanapati had loosed his male pigeons, as usual, in an adjoining wood. All of them returned except one who was pursued by a kite. Seeing no other way to escape from his enemy, the pigeon dropped to the ground and hid itself in the outer garments of a very young and fascinating maiden. This lady was no other than Khullanā—the daughter of Lakṣapati—the merchant. The girl was much pleased with the beauty of the bird and gave it shelter.

Now, Dhanapati waited some time for his favourite pigeon but when it grew late and the wanderer was not forthcoming, he commenced a vigorous search with his companions. He ran along the steep edge of the hills, through thorny plants and briers, till breathless, coming to the limits of a village named Ichhāṇinagar, he heard that Lakṣapati's daughter Khullanā had taken possession of his pet-bird. He at once hied to the mango groves where Khullanā was gaily rambling with her maids. Khullanā knew that Dhanapati was the husband of her cousin Lahanā. This relationship, gives a woman liberty in Hindu society to make a little fun and Khullanā did not allow the opportunity to slip. In coquettish tones, she argued with Danapati—now begging for his bird, that it had come of its own

The merchant and the pretty damsel.

accord and she could not give it up. The kite would have killed it and as she had saved its life, Dhanapati had no right over it. The more the young merchant argued this point, the more did she smile sweetly and stood firm in her resolve not to return the pigeon.

The charming smiles of this young and lovely damsel made Dhanapati's head giddy. He forgot all about his pigeon and stood rooted to the spot lost in a reverie. The girl, however, returned the bird and disappeared with her maids. But the echo of her joyous laughter rang in Dhanapati's ears after she had gone.

Proposes to marry.

His first act on returning home was to depute Janārdana, a Brahmin and a match-maker, to propose to Lakṣapati that he should give him his daughter in marriage.

Lakṣapati could make no objection to such a proposal. Considering all points, where could he expect to find a better birde-groom than Dhanapati? He had already a wife, it was true, but people of his rank and position were scarcely expected to remain contented with one wife, and this could not be held as a disqualification. Lakṣapati's wife however, objected to give her fair daughter to Dhanapati, because she knew his wife Lahanā, to be a termagant. "It would be better," she said, "to drown our Khullanā in the Ganges than to give her away to a man who has already a wife and that wife of the temper of Lahanā." The astrologer was called in; he examined the marks on the palm of Khullanā and prophesied that if she were not given to a man who already had a wife, she was

sure to become a widow. Now, widowhood in India is held more terrible than death. So the frightened mother immediately gave her consent. But Dhanapati himself had to obtain the permission of Lahanā to marry a second wife. The news of these negotiations had already reached Lahanā, and she sat in one corner of her room as angry as the summar-clouds when it is ready to hurl the thunder-bolt. But though a shrew and obstinate, she could be weak to the verge of folly. Dhanapati had nothing else to plead than to say a few sweet words to her ; "You are so beautiful, my darling ; but having no one to aid you in the duties of the kitchen, you are growing sickly. How I pity your lot! If you do not mind it, dear wife, I shall find for you one who will be like a maid-servant in the kitchen and carry out all your orders in domestic affairs." He shewed her also five *tolas* of gold which he intended to give to the goldsmith to make a pair of bracelets of a wonderfully beautiful pattern for her. Lahanā's anger was dispersed like the summar-clouds at these sweet words from her husband and, accepting his gift, she readily gave her consent to the proposed match. Thus Khullanā was married to Dhanapati.

Lahanā is won over.

The marriage.

At that very time a pair of birds called çuka and sārī was purchased by the king of Ujāni. These birds had a marvellous gift, they talked like men. As there was no artist in the country who could make a beautiful cage of gold for the birds, and as the artists of Gauḍa were noted for their skill in making gold-cages, the king asked Dhanapati to go to Gauḍa and give orders for a first-class gold cage; he was to see it done and carry it to

The merchant is sent to Gauḍa.

Ujāni. While giving this order, the King smiled and said, "I depute you for this task because I know that you have recently married a very beautiful bride, and you will not wish to stay long at Gauḍa; I shall therefore have the thing done in the shortest possible time."

Dhanapati Sadāgara left Ujāni for Gauḍa consigning young and lovely Khullanā to the care of Lahanā.

Durvalā poisons Lahanā's mind.

Now Lahanā bore Khullanā no grudge. True to the promises she had made to her husband, she treated the girl with great kindness, taking particular care to prepare dainties for her, and looking to her comfort with the watchful eyes of a loving sister. But Durvalā, the maid-servant, did not like this state of things. As long as there was no quarrel between the co-wives, thought she, the task of the maid-servant was but thankless drudgery. "As soon as there is a quarrel between such persons, either will hold my services dear if I can abuse the other." Thinking in this strain, she privately warned Lahanā against indulging in such affection for the co-wife. "Your dárk thick hair is already strewn with gray," she said, "the hair of Khullanā, on the other hand, is as black as a cluster of bees and as pleasant to see as the plumes of a peacock. Your cheeks are darkened by the shadows of passing youth, whereas young Khullanā's face glows with the freshness of the dawn; while her beauty is gradually brightening, yours is waning. When the merchant returns, he will be drawn by the fresher charms of his young wife and your position will be permanently in the

The contrast.

kitchen. Why not take early steps to save yourself from such coming danger? You are feeding a venomous snake with milk. Take care, or it may bite you and so put an end to your life."

Now, Lahanā, as already said, was rather stupid. She lent a credulous ear to this mischievous advice, and asked Durvalā if she could help her with any device by which she might get rid of her co-wife or otherwise bring her husband completely within her own control. Durvalā went in her turn to Līlā, a Brahmin widow, versed in the charms by which a wife may fully control her husband. She prescribed a charm which required the following ingredients: tortoise-claws, raven's blood, dragon's scales, shark's suet, bat's wool, dog's gall, lizard's intestine, and an owlet dwelling in the cavity of a rock.* Ending her advice, however, Līlā said "This charm will doubtless have its due effect; but I am not sure how far it will help you to gain your end. In some cases it fails and I cannot say, with certainty, that in yours it will be infallible. There is one thing, however, which I can assure you, will help you to win your husband's love, and is better to my mind, than all these medicinal charms put together." "What is that?" asked Lahanā with eagerness. "It is sweet words," Līlā said, "and a loving temper that will act best of all to win the love

The charm.

Lahanā dismisses Līlā.

* These extraordinary ingredients for the preparation of charms were used by the Indian gypsies who wandered all over the world during the middle ages, and were thus known to the people of East and West alike. We find them again in the description of the witch's broth in Macbeth which includes among other things, adder's fork, eye of newt, scale of dragon, maw of shark, wool of bat, gall of goat, lizard's legs and wings of owlet. This list strikingly tallies with that given in this Chandi Kāvya by Mukundarām who was a Bengali, contemporary of Shakespeare.

of your husband." Lahanā said: "But it is absurd! I have hitherto ruled my house alone. If I find that he grows indiffierent to me, while Khullanā is in high favour, I shall not be able to brook it. My course has always been like this. If I found a flaw in my husband, however small it might be, I made much of it, and continually harped upon his weak point. I cannot consent to live here like a tame lamb. It was foolish to send for you, Lilā, in order to receive this advice!" She then dismissed the wise woman, and after consultation with Durvalā, had recourse to another device. She had a letter written, purporting to have been addressed to herself by Dhanapati, from Gauḍa. It ran as follows:—

Another device.

The false letter.

"My blessings on you, my loving wife, Lahanā! I hope you and all with you are all well. I am at Gauḍa and shall probably stay for sometime longer. I have some misgivings about Khullanā, and my decision is deliberate. I feel that my marriage with her has not been approved of by the gods. It was an inauspicious affair. No sooner was I married to her, than there came a command from the Rājā of Ujānī requiring me to leave home and to sojourn in distant parts; and since then I have had no peace of mind. It is not safe or desirable to treat Khullanā with love and affection, lest Providence be further enraged and hurl more miseries upon me. You must do as I say. As soon as you get this letter, strip her of all ornaments and fine apparel. Give her a rag of coarse *khuea* cloth to wear, and appoint her to tend the sheep in the fields. Give her half a meal of coarse quality and let her sleep in the place where the rice is husked. Do not omit to carry out these orders."

Lahanā thought if Khullanā were treated in this way, her beauty would fade and she would never be able to gain full control over her husband's heart. This would happen as a matter of course from hardship, starvation and exposure.

Lahanā professes great love.

This letter was enclosed in an envelope, and Lahanā, with tearful eyes, professing great love for Khullanā, met her and showed it to her, at the same time saying, that she was bound to carry out her husband's orders, though she would do so with the greatest reluctance and her heart, in fact, was breaking at the thought of what was before her.

Now, Khullanā was very intelligent, and though not a shrew like Lahanā, she could not be so easily made to yield to the stratagem without resistance. She saw the letter and pronounced it a forgery, declaring it impossible that her husband should write in such a manner about her. The hand-writing was not his, and the whole thing was the work of Lahanā inspite of this great love which she professed for her. A hot discussion was soon followed by an exchange of blows. Lahanā was the stronger of the two. So Khullanā could not long maintain the fight and had to yield to superior force.

Exchange of blows.

Khullanā tends the sheep.

Thereupon the youthful Khullanā, as beautiful as picture, clothed in rags and with only the leaf of a fig tree to protect her head from the sun, went out to the fields to tend the sheep. Unaccustomed to walking, she grew tired and weary and she could not manage the animals. They ran into the rice fields and ate up the plants, while the owners reproached her. She wiped away her tears with one hand, while

the other held the shephard's crook. By this time the spring had come. The trees were hung with blossoms and the fields were covered with fresh green verdure. The bees hummed in concert with the songs of the birds; and the Mādhavī, the Açoka, and the Mālatī flowers looked like fringes on the border-line of the sky. Amidst all this beauty, Khullanā, inspite of her hardships, felt a longing to see her husband. She went up to the bee and begged it not to hum. She prayed the Kokila to go to Gauḍa and bring her, by its cooings, to her husband's recollection. She caressed the tender Mādhabī creeper, rich with the treasures of the spring that clung to the Açoka tree and called it most fortunate to have its supporter at hand.

The gay spring and Khullanā.

A few days passed in this manner and her beauty gradually faded. She could not eat the coarse food, she could not sleep on the hard ground, she could not manage the sheep that were placed in her charge. One day at noontide, as she was reposing in the shade of a tree, Chandī appeared before her in a dream in the guise of her mother. "The sight of your misery rends my heart, O Khullanā," she said. "The sheep named Sarvaçī has been eaten up by a fox. Lahanā will all but kill you to-day." The girl awoke with a start and sought for Sārvaçī. Alas! Sarvaçī was gone. Tears rolled down her cheeks, as she cried "Sārvaçī, Sarvaçī," all about the field. She did not abandon her search till evening. But the sheep was not found. Khullanā did not venture to return home, for fear of Lahanā's punishment. In the evening strolling all round the field with tearful eyes,

Sarvaçī lost.

famished, worn-out, and fatigued as she was, she could no longer walk. The shades of evening spread over the earth. It was all so cool! There was a consolation in the very darkness of the night—a healing breath in the breeze and Khullanā thought she was safe from the sight of men and began to weep in silence, resigning herself to Chandī, when suddenly she saw at a little distance, lights kindled by five beautiful damsels. They were doing some thing which she could not understand. With slow pace she came up to them and introduced herself to these damsels, who were no other than five nymphs of Indra's heaven. They were grieved to hear of the miseries of Khullanā, and asked her to worship Chandī as they were there doing, giving her every assurance that the cause of her grief would be removed thereby.

Khullanā worships Chandī.

There, with heart cleansed of all sin by her manifold sufferings,—with the resignation and faith of one who is helpless,—she offered flowers to Chandī, and a feeling of pure satisfaction and complacency stole over her which she had never known before. She felt contented with her lot and now cared not what might befal her. She slept at night with the five nymphs and had a quiet and undisturbed rest Next morning she looked prettier than she had ever done before.

As Khullanā did not return home at night, Lahanā felt great anxiety about her safety. "Has any evil," she thought, "befallen Khullanā? Who knows what has come upon her, she may have been killed by some wild beast, or which would be worse, she may have been taken away by wicked men, young and beautiful as she is! My husband will

Lahanā's fears.

shortly return and what shall I say to him? He especially commended her to my charge." Lahanā felt uneasy and could not sleep all night.

Dhanapati sets out for home.

That very night Dhanapati, the merchant, had a dream, in which Khullanā seemed to appear before him, and tenderly censure him for forgetting her so long. He felt a great desire to meet his young wife, and as the cage was now ready, set out for home, the very next morning.

Lahanā's repentence.

In the meantime Lahanā had sent her people to search for Khullanā. In the morning she came of her own accord and Lahanā having repented of her wickedness, received her with open arms, and began once more to show her all that loving care with which she had treated her before Durvalā had poisoned her mind against her.

Dhanapati returned to Ujānī. There, after an interview with the king Vikrama Keçarī, from whom he received praise and rewards, he came home, and went straight to the inner appartments of his house. After a formal interview with Lahanā, he hastened to meet Khullanā. She was dressed in the finest attire and looked exceedingly beautiful! The merchant addressed her with loving words but the coy damsel would give no response, which only enhanced his eagerness to enjoy her company. When they were alone together, in answer to his words of endearment, tears flowed from her eyes. Her confidence was gradually won, and then she produced the letter given her by Lahanā, commanding that Khullanā should be sent away to the forest to tend the sheep. Dhanapati was taken by surprise at this disclosure, and heard with anger

Dhanapati and Khullanā.

and regret the sad tale of the miseries endured by Khullanā in his absence. Being now convinced of her husband's affection, Khullanā willingly forgave the wickedness of the co-wife and gave free expression to the sweetness of her own feeling, while Dhanapati bitterly repented having left her in the care of so dangerous a woman as Lahanā.

Next day Khullanā was asked by Dhanapati to provide a banquet for some friends whom he had invited; and Lahanā's anger knew no bounds at being thus passed over in her own house. The invited guests thoroughly enjoyed the viands prepared for them by Khullanā, and lavished praise on her skilful cooking. This further wounded the feelings of Lahanā, who had eaten nothing the whole day. In the evening, however, Khullanā went to her and fell at her feet, asking forgiveness for any unknown offence she might have given her, and matters were mended by this kindly act.

The co-wives become friendly to one another.

The quarrel amongst clansmen.

The poets here introduce an episode describing the *srad* ceremony of the father of Dhanapati, in which all his caste-men were invited to his house; there a dispute arose as to which of them should receive precedence as the head-Kulin in that assembly. Dhanapati himself assigned the preference to Chānd the merchant, but at this, the argument waxed so hot that many of the host's clansmen forsook him. At this stage some wicked men present in the meeting, who wanted to lower Dhanapati in the estimation of all, seemed to cast a slur on the honour of his family by their insinuations against Khullanā's character, as she had been, for a period, deprived of the protection of Zenana-life,

and sent to the fields to tend the sheep. Dhanapati was naturally indignant at this ; but as the party against him, who were jealous of his wealth and power, grew strong, Khullanā, inspite of her husband's strong objections, stepped forward on the scene and declared her unshaken resolve to pass through a number of ordeals with a view to establishing her innocence. The ordeals began. A venomous snake was let loose to bite her, but she appeared livelier after the bite, Chandī having herself protected her favourite. Her enemies, however, said that it was all a trick, the snake was a harmless one. Next she was branded with a red-hot iron ; but by the grace of Chandī, it did not leave any mark on her person. The relations again said that this was also a trick. The iron-bar was made red by some device without being heated.

The ordeals.

Next a house of lac was built and Khullanā was placed inside, and it was set on fire. The fire spread with fury ; the lac-house was destroyed. Dhanapati grew mad with grief ; he offered to throw himself into the fire and put an end to his life, as without his loving wife Khullanā who had suffered great ills in life and now met a tragic death all for his own fault, life would be unbearable. But just as he stepped forward to fling himself into the burning embers, there appeared Khullanā fresher and livelier, than ever,—her red apparel shining in the glare of the fire, and not a hair of her head touched by the flames with which she was surrounded.

The relations and friends stood wonder-struck at this spectacle. Instinctively they bowed to her

in reverence, and the matter came to an end, Khullanā having aquitted herself triumphantly in all the trials.

The sea-voyage.

Dhanapati next undertook a sea-voyage for trade. He fixed a day for setting out from home and called in an astrologer to say whether that date would be auspicious or not. The fortune-teller ventured to say that he disapproved of the day, but such a contradiction seemed to Dhanapati like impertinence, and he ordered his servants to turn him out of the house with contumely. Khullanā meanwhile was worshipping Chandī in order to gain her favour and win her blessings for her husband on the eve of his departure.

Dhanapati offends Chandī.

When Dhanapati came to bid farewell to his wife and found her engaged in this worship of Chandī, he grew very angry and saying "What witch is this you are worshipping, wife!" he kicked over the *ghat* and went away with a frown.

The disaster.

On the high sea, the six ships of Dhanapati were all wrecked by a storm, which was sent by Chandī,—all, save the Madhukara—that is to say, the flag-ship in which the merchant himself had embarked. After this disaster he went to Ceylon. Near that Island in the great Indian ocean he saw a strange sight. Lotuses with red petals and large green leaves were springing up all over the blue waters, and moving gently in the breeze. On the noblest and loveliest of these flowers was seated a woman of unparalleled beauty. Her majestic looks and the light that shone about her face spread a quiet glow over the blue waters, and she looked as if painted against the blue horizon.

The wonderful vision.

One might almost have imagined that the lotuses blushed for shame at being eclipsed by her resplendent beauty. And what was this woman doing? Wonder of wonders! she had caught with one tender hand a huge elephant which with the other she was putting into her mouth. The stem of the lotus was shaking under its strange load, in which the beautiful and the grotesque were fantastically blended, and Dhanapati cried out in wonder: "But how can the weak lotus bear so heavy a burden!"

The king disbelieves the story.

He landed in Ceylon and had an interview with the king to whom he related this wonderful vision. The king only smiled and said it was a mad man's story, and all the courtiers laughed at him. It was a marvel, added the king, that his ship itself had not been swallowed up by the lady! But when the merchant insisted on his point, and talked in all other respects like a sane man, he entered into an agreement with him, to the effect that he would forego half his kingdom and bestow it on Dhanapati if he could show him the same phenomenon. Should it prove, however, that all was a mere fantasy, as the king thought, his ships and all his property would be confiscated and he would be thrown into a dungeon for life for putting a monarch to such trouble.

The contract.

Dhanapati thrown into prison.

They both embarked on a ship and reached the spot where Dhanapati had witnessed the extraordinary spectacle. But a wide space of blue waters confronted them, huge blue waves, rolling in from the blue sea,—blue waves, moving to the blue horizon, and nothing more—no lady, no lotus, no elephant met their eyes. The merchant looked

everywhere in vain for them. Alas, he was thrown into a dungeon, and condemned to be there in chains for the remainder of his life.

The play of the boys.

At Ujāni, a son was born to Khullanā, a lovely child whom everyone in the village loved dearly. He was named Çrimanta. He played manly games with his comrades. The play of *Ha-do-do*, by which the muscles become strong, was his favourite, but the pastoral games of Çrikriṣṇa were the craze of the young men of that period. One of the boys would act the part of the demon of the whirl-wind—Trinavarta. He would sweep down like a whirl-wind and surprise the others who were acting the parts of the Vrindavana-shepherds, and Çrimanta, figuring as Kriṣṇa, would kill Trinavarta after a severe battle. Sometimes a boy would take the part of Jasodā, but Çrīmanta, the young Kriṣṇa, proved too heavy for this, when the former tried to lift him in her arms. Poor Jaṣodā fell to the ground with her Kriṣṇa and the sound of laughter was heard among the boys, who enjoyed failure and success with equal zest. At one time Narasiṁha Dās, one of the companions of Çrimanta, became Bramhā, the god with four faces, and took away a kid belonging to the shepherds. Çrīmanta, as Kriṣṇa, produced an illusion and in a mysterious way the kid was made to reappear and Bramhā's attempt to thwart Kriṣṇa was foiled.

Thus all that Kriṣṇa did with the shepherds in the groves of Vrindā was re-enacted in Ujani, and no one there played his part so well as Çrimanta, the son of Dhanapati.

The doting mother and her child.

Then he was sent to a day-school belonging to Dwija Janārdana. The boy acquired Sanskrit rhetoric and grammar in no time. He displayed wonderful intelligence and power of grasping the texts. Whatever he laid his hands on, he did with marvellous grace, for surely his birth had been the result of a boon, granted by Chandī to his mother Khullanā, as a reward for her life-long devotion to that goddess in the midst of many sufferings.

Much as Çrīmanta was loved, however, his father's long and unexplained absence from home, cast a gloom on the family ; and going to school at the age of twelve, the sensitive child was wounded by a slight levelled against his birth, by his teacher on the score of his father's long absence from home.

Now Çrīmanta was loved by all, he had never been accustomed to harshness. His teacher's remarks, therefore, cut him to the quick. He was now a lad of some twelve years. He made for home straight way and going there shut himself up in a room alone, not even seeing his mother.

Khullanā made enquiries about him and discovered him in his solitude sobbing out his misery, and when his mother had asked him again and again what was the matter, he told her what the teacher had said, weeping all the while vehemently ; he expressed his desire to go at once in search of his father, wherever he might be, nor would he touch food, until his mother gave him permission to set out on this quest.

Resolved on sea voyage

Poor Khullanā did not know what to do. Her dear lord had been away for more than twelve years. She bore a sorrow in her heart for which

there was no cure. Every night when others were asleep, she would lie and weep for long hours till her eyes closing in sleep, she sometime dreamt, that her husband had come back, and was speaking sweetly to her. But when morning dawned, she knew no joy, for it woke her up to stern reality taking from her this sweet interview. When her neighbours would talk of their husbands, she would retire to her room, with pale face, to hide her tears. The only consolation of her life was her son Çrīmanta. When she saw him in such distress about his father,—she felt that her heart would break. She was wounded at a vital point and could only cry helplessly without trying to hide her tears. How would she be able to live without her son—a mere lad, who was the only solace of her lonely life! But the boy, though so young, possessed unflinching determination. Khullanā, Lahanā, Durvalā and other inmates of the house tried all that was in their power to dissuade him from his course, but in vain; and when nothing could shake his resolve, Khullanā sent information to King Vikrama Keçarī with a piteous representation of her case and asked his help in bringing Çrīmanta to his senses. The King readily consented to give his aid in counselling the boy to a right course; but Çrīmanta would not touch food and seemed resolved to starve himself if permission were not granted him for going. When the king called him into his presence, he could not reply to him, his voice being choked with tears.

The king intervenes.

But to no avail.

It was very difficult to deal with such a headstrong boy. Khullanā at last in deep anguish of heart gave him permission to undertake a sea-

The mothers' consent.

voyage, and young Çrīmanta gladly made himself ready for the journey. Khullanā gave him sound advices as to how he should proceed with his mission, and so did the king, who also ordered seven good ships to be built for him. They were made ready in a short time, and Çrīmanta set sail in them on an auspicious day.

Khullanā all the while was engaged in worshipping Chandī. What else could she do in her utter despair? Her husband was gone and now her child also was to be parted from her. The *ghat* of Chandī was her only solace in this deplorable condition. When the ships sailed, she stood looking, with wistful eyes at the southern skies at which the unfurled sails seemed to be aiming. She resigned herself to the will of Chandī and remained fixed to the spot like a statue.

He departs.

Çrīmanta was overjoyed as the sea-wind touched him. He was determined to find his father or die in the attempt. He had felt all along that his mother was sad, without being able to divine the reasons. He had always marked the melancholy expression of her lovely face, and he now understood, that her sorrow was all for the absence of her lord. If he could not make his mother happy, what was the good of his living at all. "O divine mother Chandī, do thou help this poor boy to gain his object,"—he prayed day and night and the ships went on, towards Ceylon.

There is here a long catalogue of the cargo and a detailed description of the voyage. Last of all he came to Ceylon, but near the Island, upon the waters of the great Indian Ocean the same spectacle

The same spectacle again.

that had caused his father's trouble, met his eyes also. A large space of blue water was covered with lotuses and upon the finest and noblest of them, sat the same mysterious and beautiful woman with dishevelled hair. She also was swallowing an elephant.

The wonder which a spectacle like this naturally creates in one's mind had its effect on Çrīmanta and when he landed in Ceylon, in an interview with the king Çālibāhana, the very first thing that he related was concerning the woman seated on the lotus. "Why, this is another crazy head!" cried the king, and he tried to convince the boy that it was a silly story,—a mere fantasy of his brain; but Çrimanta would not stop till an agreement was made that if he succeeded in showing it to the king, he would give him his only daughter in marriage with half the kingdom as her dowry, but if it proved a failure he should be beheaded. The king already loved the boy for his handsome appearance and keen intelligence, but as Çrimanta seemed determined to bring ruin upon himself, there was no help for it.

And a similar contract.

They sailed to the spot on board a ship. But alas! the illusion was not there. By order of the king, Çrimanta was now taken to the place of execution. He was now a young and beautiful boy of twelve, so lovely that the women shed tears as they saw him carried for execution. Çrīmanta recollected his mother's face and tears came into his eyes. He had come to seek his father, but he was not destined to meet him in this world. He thought of his playmates of Ujāni, of the fair fields and meadows, where they sported,—of Durvalā, the maid-servant, of his step-mother

Doomed to execution.

Lahanā, of his grand-mother, and of every other person and object associated with his dear home, and tears which he could not check, streamed down his cheeks. On the scaffold he clasped his hands, and cried "Chandī, Chandī, O divine mother! look at your child! O Chandī, I would by your grace find out my father,—I am now going to be taken away from both my parents." He collected himself in a moment,—the growing emotions were checked, and he named all the names of Chandī, beginning with each of the 34 characters of the Bengali Alphabet, and offered hymns to the goddess. There, like a statue, he sat and looked like a yogi, though a mere lad. In his distress the boy attained the resigned spirit of an old man, and God being both father and mother to us, comes to man when he is thus resigned; when we know that we are mere tools in the divine hand, and that He is the main actor on this stage, and knowing so cling unto Him as a helpless child does to the mother, then the divine grace becomes unfailing.

Prays to Chandī.

Chandī appeared on the scaffold. The divine mother took Çrimanta in her arms and the executioner was overawed by her presence. Information was sent to king Çālivāhana that a mysterious woman was protecting Çrimanta, and the king ordered that the boy should be taken from her by force, if necessary, and executed without delay.

Chandī Kills the King's Army.

But the men who tried to apply force, were killed on the spot. Others were sent to their succour. They also shared the same fate, and a vast army, belonging to the king, came to the

field. Strange and mysterious creatures rose from underground, rending the very entrails of the earth, some with more heads than one and others without any head at all. Goblins called Kavandhas and Vetāls worked destruction on the royal forces, whose heroic feats in arms, seemed like child's play before the destructive agencies unloosed by Chandī. The goblins took the skulls of dead soldiers, and filling them with warm blood, drank from them in wild and horrid ecstacy. They picked up heads that rolled in the fields, and with human entrails threaded them into ghastly garlands and put them on and danced. The witches cut corpses to pieces like butchers and dressed them, and sold them to new comers of their own sort. The heads of elephants were used as balls, with which a horrid-faced hob-goblin played, and others came to join the party, who like the fabled anthropophagi, had heads beneath their shoulders. There, aloof from the field of destruction, sat Chandī like a mother, and Çrīmanta clung to her, like a helpless child, filled with courage and confidence, as is the baby by its mother's side.

King Çālivāhana heard the story and himself came to the field. There he witnessed this spectacle of destruction, and felt that it was Chandī's wrath that had overtaken his army. He presented himself with reverence and humilation before the goddess, and worshipped her, praying a thousand forgivenesses. Chandī was propitiated. She restored the army to life and king Çālivāhana gave his daughter in marriage to Çrīmanta with half his kingdom for dowry. By the grace of Chandī, the king now also saw the wonderful spectacle

Chandī is propitiated.

which she had created as an illusion to bewilder the father and the son on the waters of the sea ;— the thick array of lotuses blooming on all sides and the mysteriously beautiful woman in the act of swallowing an elephant.

The dungeon horrible and its inmate.

Next came the pathetic interview between father and son. Dhanapati was imprisoned in a horrible dungeon. The prison house extended two miles in length and was almost without any breadth, and so low that a child could not stand upright in it. The floor was covered with worms. Here in chains for twelve years with the coarsest of grain for food, the princely merchant Dhanapati had lain like an earth-worm. For these twelve years he had not shaved. So his beard fell down to his knees. His nails looked like the claws of a wild beast and his eyes were almost blind with cataract. The foot with which he had kicked the *ghat* of Chandi was heavy with elephantiasis.

The father and the son.

By order of Çrimanta the merchant was brought before him. Khullanā had described his father to him before he left Ujāni. The merchant, she said, had seven moles on the breast, and a black mark on the left side of his nose. He was tall, his eyes were large, and the grace of his person was like that of a god. Though so aged and afflicted with unsightly diseases, Çrimanta was yet able to see instinctively that it was his father who stood before him in chains. He felt a satisfaction which brought tears of joy to his eyes. He had the chains removed at once. The matted locks were combed and cleansed. The barber was employed to shave the beard and cut the hair, and anoint the body with perfumed oil. Çrimanta now asked Dhanapati

who he was, and what had brought him to Ceylon. Dhanapati said "My name is Dhanapati Datta. I am a native of Ujāni in Mangalakota in Burdwan. I came here to trade but owing to an optical illusion which completely overpowered me, I brought about my own misfortunes. The tale would be a long one, and you need not listen sir, to its details. How thankful am I to you, O prince! for my release. If you permit, I may now start for my home to meet my beloved and long lost family."

Çrīmanta asked if he had left any children behind him. "I had two wives" said Dhanapati "the younger Khullanā was to give birth to a child, but I could not wait at home to see it born. If a child were born to her in due course, that one must be now a little more than twelve years of age" and here Dhanapati manifested extreme anguish of heart. Çrīmanta showed him the letter written by Dhanapati to Khullanā in which the merchant had alluded to the child that would be born to her. Dhanapati wept bitterly over the letter. It brought to his recollection his dear wife and all the sufferings he had passed through during these twelve years. He implored Çrīmanta to tell him how he came into possession of an article which belonged to his wife, and if he knew anything about Khullanā and other inmates of his house. Finally he said, "the sight of you, dear sir, I do not know why, has filled my heart with great delight. If I had had a son, he would have been exactly of your age." This was too much for Çrīmanta, who at these words fell prostrate at his father's feet, and said "Father! I am your unfortunate son. I started from home with seven ships, with the object of finding you. Gra-

cious Heaven has at last granted my prayers. But how it pains me to see you in this condition!"

Dhanapati worships Chandī.

Dhanapati would by no means agree to worship Chandī, but Çrīmanta's entreaties became irresistible and eventually he yielded to them. As soon as he offered a flower to the cup of Chandi, his diseases—the cataract in his eyes and the elephantiasis in his foot, were cured, and he became once more prince-like and full of the glory of vigorous manhood.

The happy end.

King Çālivāhana came with a hundred excuses and entertained the father and the son with all manner of courtesy. Çrīmanta sailed homewards with Çuçīlā the princess, whom he had married, and with immense riches and a good number of ships that he had received as a dowry, together with the riches and ships of his father, returned by the king with interest. In due time he reached Ujāni. There king Vikramkeçarī of Ujāni also gave Çrīmanta his own daughter in marriage. So with two wives he lived in happiness and prosperity, and Khullanā's happiness knew no bounds at having her dear lord back. They all lived many years in enjoyment of all kinds of earthly fortune, and zealously did they worship Chandī whose grace had given them prosperity and happiness. In due time Khullanā, who, as has been already said, was a nymph of Indra's heaven, and Çrīmanta who was the Gandharvya named Mālādhar, both born on earth under a curse—came to the end of their earthly careers. They then ascended into heaven, and the worship of Chandī spread in the country.

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The Astamaṇgalā.

These two stories form the subject matter of all poems on Chandi. In the Chaitanya Bhāgbata, a work to which we have already alluded, we find that these devotional epics were generally sung at night. They were generally allowed to take eight nights. Hence a poem in honour of Chandi was divided into eight parts, or Aṣtamaṇgalā, each part being sung in a night. The poems must have been fairly long, to engage the audience for eight successive nights.

Janārdana and Mānik Dutta.

1. & 2. We have also a few short poems on Chandi which seem to be the earliest known specimens of such poetry. One we find with the signature of Dwija Janārdana, and another with that of Mānick Dutta. The latter refers to the temple of Dvāravāsini in Gouḍa. Dvāravāsini was worshipped with great pomp by the Hindu and Buddhist kings of Gouḍa. With the fall of their power, the temple of the goddess, where hundreds of pilgrims from different parts of the country flocked to offer prayers, became deserted and eventually in the 16th century, was reduced to a heap of bricks. Mānick Dutta refers to the flourishing condition of this temple which must have belonged to an age not earlier than the 13th century. His poem also gives an account of creation on the lines of the Çunya Purāna, with obvious traces of Buddhism. We must remember that the later writers of poem on Maṇgala Chandi tried to identify this goddess with Chandi as described by Mārkaṅdeya, but originally she had no connection whatever with the Paurānic deity. Maṇgal Chandi was a popular deity worshipped in the villages by the rustic people, mostly women, and the Paurānic element introduced

into it, is the work of subsequent writers. This will be evident from a perusal of the short poem by Mānick Dutta which possesses, as I have said, far greater traces of Buddhistic influence than of Paurānic religion.

Mānik Dutta and Dwija Janārdana lived probably towards the end of the 13th century.

Madan Datta.

3. A third poem on Maṇgala Chandī was written by Madan Datta.

Muktarām Sen.

4. Sāradā Maṇgal is another poem on Chandī by Muktārāma Sen—a Vaidya who settled in Devagrām in Chittagong. He wrote his poem in 1547. His mother with heroic devotion ascended the funeral pyre of her husband. "This sight," says the poet, "gave me a religious tendency from my childhood. Since that time I have cared not living for earthly objects; hence I desire to write this religious poem."

Other Authors.

Some other authors of poems on Chandī are :—

5. Devī Dās Sen.
6. Çiva Nārāyana Dev.
7. Kīrti Chandra Dās.
8. Balarāma Kavi Kaṇkana.
9. Mādhavāchāryya.

Madhāvacharyya.

Mādhavāchāryya's Chandī Maṇgal was published some years ago by Pundit Chandra Kantha of Chittagong. Mādhavācharyya wrote his poem in 1579. He was a native of Trivenī. His father Parāsara was a man of great scholarship and piety, he was also wealthy, and spent much in charity. We find in the poem of Mādhavāchāryya a reference to the Mogal Emperor Akbar of Delhi

who was a contemporary of the poet and of whom he speaks in terms of high regard.

Mādhavāchāryya's poem was first sung by a glee-party consisting of recruits from the lower classes and he prays to Chandī in the preliminary chapter that she may not be offended with him for their incorrect pronunciation. It is said that Mādhavāchāryya later on came and settled at Navingour (modern Nanpur) in the district of Mymensing. It will be seen that Mukundarāma Kavi Kaṇkan's Chandī Maṇgal is a great improvement on the poem by Mādhavāchāryya as indeed it is upon all other poems of this cult. In dealing with Mukundarāma we shall touch on all the important features of the literature of the Chandī cult, so a separate notice of them is unnecessary. Mādhavācharyya's poem was up till lately extensively read in Chittagong, and in the back-woods of Bengal. But the printing of Mukundarāma's work has carried it to all parts of the country, and it has now almost driven the former poem out of its strongholds in those backward regions where it held undisputed sway for more than three centuries.

Mukundarām Kavikaṇkan and his Chandī-maṇgal.

We have now come to consider one of the greatest of Bengali poets. Mukundarāma was not given to idealism; he depicted what he saw with his own eyes. One who reads his poems closely will find the Bengali home of the 16th century mirrored in his pages. They are full of realistic interest. It is for the intense realism of his description that Prof. Cowell calls him the Crabbe of Bengal and Dr. Grierson speaks of his poetry "as coming from the heart and not

A realistic poet.

from the school, and as full of passages adorned with true poetry and descriptive power." But before dealing with his composition, we propose here to give an account of his life.

His life.

In the autobiography affixed to his poem he says that he was a native of Dāmunyā in the district of Burdwan. He held some lands under one Gopināth Nandi who owned considerable estates in Pergunnah Selimābād. Unfortunately for the people, a Muhamadan governor named Mamud Sherif was entrusted with the administration of the Pergunnah. Under his rule the traders groaned. He made false measurements of lands; a *kura* was measured as fifteen *kathas*; and rents were assessed on waste lands. The poor man's prayer was not heeded. The money-lenders became exacting. Each Rupee was short by 2½ annas. No purchasers were to be found for cattle or stock. The landlord Gopinath Nandi was made prisoner and the poor people became stunned with fear and grief. Lest they should abscond, constables were appointed to keep watch over every cottage. In deep distress the poor people sold their spades and every utensil they possessed. Things worth a Rupee were sold at ten annas. The poet, helped by Çrīmanta Khān, an inhabitant of Chandibāti, and being counselled by Muniva Khān as to the course he should follow, left Dāmunyā with his brother Rāmānanda. He reached Bhetnā where Ruparāy helped him with some money and where afterwards Jadu Nandi of the Teli caste opened his hospitable doors to the small family of our poet. There he spent three days. Then, sailing down the stream of Goḍāi he reached Ṭeywettyā and, passing

Dwarukeçvar, crossed the Dāmodara and came to the village Kuchuttyā. "There without oil," says the poet "we had our bath and appeased our hunger by drinking water. The famished children cried for food. On the banks of a pond with offerings of Sāluka and Sāplā flowers I worshipped Chandī. Exhausted, famished, and frightened, I fell asleep and dreamt that the goddess Chandī appeared to me."

Chandī taught him metres and their laws, and bade him sing a song in her honour.

He next went to Arrāh Brāhmanbhumi, where Rājā Bānkurā Rāy was much pleased with his poetry. He ordered five *aras* of rice* to be presented to the poet and cleared all his debts, and besides appointed him as a tutor to his son Raghu Nāth Rāy. There enjoying the patronage of the Rājā, he began to write his poem on Chandī which was destined to win for him such great celebrity. The Rājā lavished rewards upon the chief singer, who sung the poem in his court, and held our poet in great esteem.

He composes his great poem.

But Mukundarām never forgot the village of Dāmunyā from which he had been driven by the oppression of Māmud Sherif. We can trace his yearning for his native place in the autobiographical account. Though by the favour of the Rājā, he now enjoyed plenty at Brāhāmanbhumi, Dāmunyā where he had owned only a few acres of land and tilled them with his own hands, was far dearer to him by many tender associations. His family had lived at Dāmunyā for eight generations. The

His great love for his native village.

* About 3 cwt.

village with the noble river Ratnānu flowing by it was ever-beloved, nay, sacred in his eyes. He writes of Dāmunyā in the following lines:—

*"Kāyasthas, Brāhmins and Vaidyas of pure origin,—all honest men live in Dāmunyā. The southern part of the village is inhabited by poets and scholars. The Great God Çivā by his grace has favoured this village with his presence. He is known by the name of Chakrāditya, and the village possesses a special sanctity and is visited by pilgrims on account of his temple there which Vrisa Datta erected on the banks of the Ratnānu. O, Ratnānu! I drank thy water, dear and sacred to me as Ganges water, and from the virtue earned by so doing, I was endowed with poetical talents even from my boyhood and my very first production was a poem in honour of Çiva. The people of Dāmunyā are devoted to the worship

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* কুলে শীলে নিরবদ্য, কায়স্থ ব্রাহ্মণ বৈদ্য
দামুন্যায় সজ্জনের স্থান।
অতিশয় গুণ বাড়া, সুধন্য দক্ষিণ পাড়া
সুপণ্ডিত সুকবি সমান।
ধন্য ধন্য কলিকালে, রত্নানু নদীর কুলে
অবতার করিলা শঙ্কর।
ধরি চক্রাদিত্য নাম, দামুন্যা করিলা ধাম
তীর্থ কৈলা সেই সে নগর।
বুঝিয়া তোমার তত্ত্ব, দেউল দিলা বৃষ দত্ত
কত কাল তথায় বিহার।
কে বুঝে তোমার মায়া, সুরকুল তেয়াগিয়া
বরদান করিলা সঞ্চার।

of Chakrāditya. The village belongs to him and we lived in his jurisdiction. Jasavanta Adhikari who is the ornament of the Kanjuri family, Umapati Rāy, whose free hand bestows charity on every one who is in need of it, the saintly Sarvānanda of the Nāg family and other good people all dwell in that village. There is besides Içān Pundit, well-versed in the Upanishads, belonging to the Katāditya Vandighati family and Lokanāth Misra, Dhananjay Misra of the Bengal Pasi Brahmin family who adorn our village."

He next traces his own genealogy from Ṭapan Ojhā, a Rājā of the family of the Karori Brahmins

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গঙ্গাসম সুনির্ম্মল, তোমার চরণ জল
পান কৈনু শিশুকাল হৈতে।
সেইত পুণ্যের ফলে, কবি হই শিশুকালে
রচিলাম তোমার সংগীতে।
হরি নন্দী ভাগ্যবান, শিবে কৈল ভূমি দান
মাধব ওঝা ধামাধিকারিণী।
দামুন্যার লোক যত, শিবের চরণে নত
সেই পুরী হরের ধরণী।
কাঞ্জরি কুলের আর, যশোমন্ত অধিকার
কল্পতরু নাগ উমাপতি।
অশেষ পুণ্যবন্ধ, নাগ ঋষি সর্ব্বানন্দ
সেই পুরী সজ্জন বসতি।
কাঁটাদিয়া বন্দঘাটি, বেদান্ত নিগম পাটি
ঈশাণ পণ্ডিত মহাশয়।
ধন্য ধন্য পুরোবাসী, বন্দ্য সে বাঙ্গাল পাশী
লোকনাথ মিশ্র ধনঞ্জয়।"

and names all his ancestors, concluding the list with blessings on his eldest son Çivarām.

All this shows how, though cut off from Dāmunyā, his mind was yet full of pleasant recollections of its scenes. The river Ratnānu, the village god Chakrāditya, and even the temple erected by Vrisa Datta, and the dear friends whom he could never hope to meet again for many long years, inspired his imagination and were sacredly kept in his memory. We may imagine him to look wistfully towards Dāmunyā from the far off Brāhmanbhumi, even as Adam did towards the garden of Eden after bidding it a last farewell.

Towards the last years of his life when the economic stability of the country was improved, he returned to Dāmunyā and there erected a small temple which he dedicated to the worship of the goddess Chandī. This deity was named by him Simhabāhini, the goddess who rides on a lion, and she is still worshipped there. The manuscript of Chandī Kāvya written by his own hands was till lately in the custody of his descendant Jogendra Nath Bhattāchāryya and I had it copied by a Pundit under the direction of the Bangyia Sahitya Parisat of Calcutta.

We have seen a deed of gift under the seal and signature of Barakhān, Governor of Pergunnah Selimābād, dated 1640 A.D. conferring the right of twenty bighas of land on Çivarām Bhattāchāryya, the eldest son of Mukundarām, of whom the poet speaks so often in his Chandī Mangal.

Mukundarām, who his generally known by his title of Kavikankan, finished his celebrated Chandi

Finished his poem in 1589 A. D.

Kāvya in 1589 A.D. when Mānsiṁha was the governor of Bengal: the poet refers to Mānsiṁha with great regard in the introductory canto of his work.

The contents.

His poem is divided into three parts; besides the usual prelminaries in which he offers hymns to various gods and goddesses, he gives an account of himself and of his native village of Dāmunyā.

Of the three main chapters, the first is devoted to Çiva; this is evidently that first production, to which he refers in his account of Dāmunyā. The sacrificial ceremony of Dakṣa, the catastrophe that befell him, the death of Satī who was re-born as Umā, and the austerities she passed through in her new life, with the object of regaining Çiva for her husband, the killing of Madan by the fires of Çiva's third eye, the bewailings of Ratī, the wife of Madan (full of tender pathos; such as "let the years that I might have lived be added to your life, my dear husband, do you live for ever, letting me die here at your feet") the marriage, the various domestic scenes in Kailāsh, the dispute between Çiva and Umā, and the worship of Çiva by Indra and so forth, form the subject-matter of the first canto.

The second canto gives the story of Kālketu the hunter, and the third that of the merchant-princes Dhanapati and Çrimanta.

The works of Mukundarām contain in all more than 25,000 lines and a considerable portion of this has been rendered into English verse by Prof. E. B. Cowell.

Depicts Bengali home.

The poets of Bengal had been long aiming at a faithful depictment of scenes of their own home-life, and in Mukundarām their efforts reached the high water-mark of success. Like all great poets Mukundarām represents his own people and the pecularities of the age in which he lived. The human world as he observed it in Bengal was constantly before his mind. Under the garb of the gods of heaven and even of the beasts of the forest, it is the people of Bengal who appear before our view in the characters that he has painted. The beasts of the forest complain to Chandī that they are in terror of Kalketu the hunter. The tiger who amongst the lower animals, is held to belong to the Kṣatriya or warrior caste, the great elephant whose might is fully equal to his enormous bulk, the rhinoceroes with his dreaded sword, the great buffalo whose red-eyes frighten the enemy away,—all look crest-fallen and humiliated. Their speeches strangely disclose the political life of Bengal as it was in Mukundarām's time, even as the speeches of the fallen cherub in Milton's "Pandemonium" recall the views and sentiments of the Radicals during the Civil War in the time of Charles I.

The beasts talk politics.

The humbler beasts complain to Chandī that they are poor innocent animals who graze in the fields and are neither Neogis nor Chaudries who own estates. The conversation of Chandī with the beasts, humiliated and stricken as they are by the arrows of Kālketu, is full of significant hints indicating how the sun of the glory of the Hindu chiefs was setting before the superior martial power of the Moslem invaders, and how the yoke of Muhammadan rule fell upon all ranks in society without sparing even the lowest.

A dark Chapter of Bengal history.

The period was indeed a dark one for Bengal. The Muhammadan autocrats were making their power felt. In the Padma Purāṅ of Vijay Gupta we find good Brahmins with sandal marks on their foreheads and Tulsi leaves on their heads, being bound and dragged before the Kāzi and there put to abject humiliation for no fault. We quote the following passage from Von Neor's Akbar.

"When the Collector of the Dewan asks them (the Hindoos) to pay the tax, they should pay it with all humility and submission: and if the Collector wishes to spit into their mouths, they should open their mouths without the slightest fear of contamination so that the Collector may do so. The object of such humiliation and spitting into their mouths is to prove the obedience of the infidel subjects under protection and promote if possible the glory of Islam,—the true religion and to show contempt to false religion."

The human interest in his poem.

We have already described how, owing to the oppression of Mamud Sherif in Pergunnah Selimābād, the poet had been obliged to leave his native village. We have seen how, while describing a ficticious warfare between Kālketu and the beasts, Mukundarām unconsciously represented the political condition of his country. It is this reality which saves his poem from dullness even in the minutest details of the story. As in the case of the beasts, so also in the description of natural scenery, the human world constantly recurs; and in whatever he sees on earth or heaven, he finds human society first and everything else in its light. Here is an extract from one of his descriptions of a flower-covered meadow.

*" The bee merrily extracts honey from one flower and then enters the next, even as does the village-priest, receiving presents from one house, immediately turn to visit the neighbour's."

The domestic life of Bengal so dominated his imagination, that even looking at the gay flower with the bee upon it, the poet is reminded of the Brahmin priest! Mr. Cowell justly remarks "Wherever he may place his scenes, in Çiva's heaven or India or Ceylon, Mukundarām never loses sight of Bengal. He carries everywhere the village life of his own early days."

In a few touches he often calls up a picture or a scene which seems to throb with life. Kālaketu the hunter, when a boy, is introduced to us by the poet in the following passage :—

Kālaketu as a boy.

†"His mouth, eyes, ears and nose were as fine as if they had been carved by a chisel, and his arms were as strong as iron-bars. On his forehead he wore an ornament called Kapāltati. A tiger's claw hung on his breast. He used to besmear his body with the red dust of the play-ground. Amongst the children he looked like their chief. One who attempted to wrestle with him was treated to a hundred blows,—in fact, it soon became a question

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* এক ফুলে মকরন্দ, পান করি সদানন্দ
ধায় অলি অপর কুসুমে।
এক ঘরে পেয়ে মান, গ্রামযাজি দ্বিজ যান
অন্য ঘরে আপন সম্ভ্রমে।

† নাক মুখ চক্ষু কাণ, কুন্দে যেন নিরমান
দুই বাহু লোহার সাবল।

* * * *

of life and death with his antagonist. If any one of his comrades, who were no match for him in strength, persisted in wrestling, in spite of his evident inferiority, Kālaketu would throw him to the ground with great force, and no one dared to challenge him after such an experience. With his companions he marched out to hunt the hare; if the animals fled, there was no escape from the dogs that he let loose to pursue them. With infallible aim, he threw iron-balls at birds who fell to the ground where our hero caught them and bound with creepers. He hung the burden on his shoulders and returned home with his booty."

A contrast.

The descriptions are refreshing, for they offer a contrast to those copied in the Bengali poems of the period, from the stereotyped accounts of men and women to be found in the latter-day Sanskrit works.

বিচিত্র কপালতটী, গলায় জালের কাঁটি
কর যোড়া লোহার শিকলি।
বুক শোভে ব্যাঘ্র নখে, অঙ্গে রাঙ্গা ধুলি মাখে
কটিতটে শোভয়ে ত্রিবলী।
দুই চক্ষু যেন নাটা, খেলে দাণ্ডা গুলি ভাটা
কাণে শোভে ফটিক কুণ্ডল।
পরিধান রাঙ্গা ধুতি, মস্তকে জালের দড়ি
শিশু মাঝে যেমন মণ্ডল।
সহিয়া শতেক ঠেলা, যার সঙ্গে করে খেলা
তার হয় জীবন সংশয়।
যে জন আকুড়ি করে, আছাড়ি ধরণী পাড়ে
ডরে কেহ নিকটে না রয়।

A social gathering.

Mukundarām's description of a social gathering is always endowed with life-like vividness. Dhanapati was giving precedence to Chānd as a Kulīna in an assembly of his caste-men. The poet thus describes the scene.

* "So he (Dhanapati) weighing all points in his mind, offered water first to Chānd the merchant. He put the sandal-mark on his forehead and hung the garland of honour about his neck. At this stage, Çaṅkha Datta said, 'In the assembly of merchants, the place of precedence has always been mine. Your head seems to be turned by your riches, you do not pay me the respect that I deserve. On the Çrādā ceremony of the father of Dhuṣa Datta, sixteen hundred persons belonging to the Beṇiā caste were present and the first seat of honour was given to me. Dhuṣa Datta knows it well and Chānd may have heard of it too.'

সঙ্গে শিশুগণ ফিরে, শশারু তাড়িয়ে ধরে
দূরে গেলে ধরায় কুক্কুরে।
বিহঙ্গম বাঁটুলে বিন্ধে, লতায় জড়িয়ে বাঁধে
স্কন্ধে ভার বীর আইসে ঘরে॥"

* এমন বিচার সাধু করি মনে মনে।
আগে জল দিল চাঁদ বেণের চরণে॥
কপালে চন্দন দিয়া মালা দিল গলে।
এমন সময়ে শঙ্খ দত্ত কিছু বলে॥
বণিক সভায় আমি আগে পাই মান।
সম্পদে মাতিয়া নাহি কর অবধান॥
যে কালে বাপের কর্ম্ম কৈল ধুস দত্ত।
তাহার সভায় বেণে ছিল ষোলশত॥

Hearing this Dhanapati said. "But in that assembly Chānd was not present. In point of social position, in the respect that he commands, and for his wealth, who is there that can bear a comparison with him? Even in the outer appartments of his mansion, there are seven jars filled with gold." Nilāmbara Dās smiled at this and said "A new discovery indeed! Is precedence in caste obtained by wealth? The widows of his six sons bemoan their lot in his desolate house. With all his riches I count Chānd as nothing but a bull in this assembly!" Chānd retorted "I know you well Nilāmbara Dās; will you gentlemen, present here, kindly bear with me for a moment while I relate to you the history of his father! His father used to sell myrobalans. The scum of the city were his purchasers. He would openly mix with harlots, and then without even cleansing himself by a bath he would

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ষোলশতের আগে শঙ্খ দত্ত পাইল মান।
ধুসদত্ত জানে ইহা চন্দ্র মতিমান॥
ইহা শুনি ধনপতি করিল উত্তর।
সেই কালে নাহি ছিল চাঁদ সদাগর॥
ধনে মানে কুলে শীলে চাঁদ নহে বাঁকা।
বাহির মহলে যার সাত ঘড়াই টাকা॥
ইহা শুনি হাসি কহে নীলাম্বর দাস।
ধন হেতু হয় কিবা কুলের প্রকাশ॥
ছয় বধূ যার ঘরে নিবসয়ে রাঁড়।
ধন হেতু চাঁদ বেণে সভা মধ্যে ষাঁড়॥
চাঁদ বলে তোরে জানি নীলাম্বর দাস।
তোমার বাপের কিছু শুন ইতিহাস॥

sit down to eat. He was so great a miser, that he stowed his cowrie bundles here, there and everywhere. Son of such a worthy father, you are not ashamed, O Nilāmbara, to talk aloud in a meeting like this?" Nilāmbara Dās did not look at Chānd, in his contempt, but turned towards Rām Rāy who was his son-in-law, and said "What fault can there be in one's plying his trade? Is not the keeping of cowrie bundles a legitimate function for all of us who belong to the Beniā caste? He continued "If the question of caste is to rise at all, why not take into account the case of Dhanapati himself? His wife tended the sheep in the fields. Is this not a great stigma on him?"

হাটে হাটে তোর বাপ বেচিত আমলা।
যতন করিয়া তাহা কিনিত অবলা॥
নিরন্তর হাতা হাতি বারবধূর সনে।
নাহি স্নান করি বেটা বসিত ভোজনে॥
কড়ির পুঁটলী সে বাঁধিত তিন ঠাঁই।
সভা মধ্যে কহ কথা কিছু মনে নাই॥
নীলাম্বর দাস কহে শুন রাম রায়।
পশরা করিলে তাহে জাতি নাহি যায়॥
কড়ির পুঁটলী বাঁধি জাতির ব্যাভার।
আঁটো ছোপড়া খাইলে নহে কুলের খাথার॥
নীলাম্বর দাস রাম রায়ের শ্বশুর।
ধনপতি গঞ্জি কিছু বলিলা প্রচুর॥
জাতিবাদ হয় যদি তবে হই বঙ্ক॥
বনে জায়া ছাগ রাখে এ বড় কলঙ্ক॥"

Kavikaṇkaṅ-Chandī.

I am afraid the translation will not give any adequate idea of the animation which characterises this controversy in the original. In the discussion, points are brought home in colloquial dialect, by references to matters pertaining to caste-honour and this point is not likely to be appreciated by non-Hindu readers, but in it nevertheless lies the realistic interest of the passage.

A description of the spring.

In the description of the spring-season which adorns the forest with fresh leaves and flowers, the poet ushers in the fair damsel Khullanā who has just entered her teens, with singular poetic effect. Her lovely presence enlivens the whole scene, adorned as this is with all the gay blossoms around her. Everything becomes part of a lovely romance, showing that our poet, though trained in the school of realistic poetry, had yet access to the land of the lotus.

*"With Kāmadeva (the god of love) as a companion, the spring season entered the woods. The damsel was taken by surprize by the blossoms all around as she strolled on the banks of the Ajay. The trees and creepers became suddenly lit up with

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*সঙ্গেতে মকর-কেতু, আইল বসন্ত ঋতু
তরু লতাগণ চমকিত।
অজয় নদের কুলে, অশোক তরুর মূলে
কামশরে বামা পুলকিত।
লোহিত পল্লবগণ, বামার হরয়ে মন
দেখি মনে ভাবয়ে খুল্লনা।
বসন্ত আসিয়া কিবা, অটবী করিল শোভা
ভালে দিয়া কুঙ্কুম চন্দনা।

new joy. On the banks of the Ajay, under the shade of an Açoka tree, Khullanā felt the tender emotions natural to youth. The red of the young leaves on the tree-tops about her, charmed her heart; and she wonderingly thought that the spring as the first sign of its advent had placed vermilion-marks on the brows of the trees. The joyful bee drank honey from one flower, and straightway visited the next just as the village priest having received presents at one house moves onward to another. Moved by the gentle breeze, the trees dropped the flowers, and Khullanā received their floral gifts with joined hands keeping them for the worship of Kāma Deva (the god of love) that the god might create a longing in the merchant's heart for meeting her. The southern breeze blew softly. She pressed the Açoka and Kiṁçuka to her breast. The Ketakī, Dhātaki, Champaka, and the Kāñchana bloomed on all sides, and the bees roamed in their drunken ecstacy from flower to flower. The Açoka tree was surrounded by creepers, she hastened to it and said 'O my friend, how fortunate you are! you are far

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এক ফুলে মকরন্দে, পান করি মহানন্দে
ধায় অলি অপর কুসুমে।
এক ঘরে প্যায়া মান, গ্রামযাজি দ্বিজ যান
অন্য ঘরে আপনার মনে।
মন্দ মন্দ প্রভঞ্জনে, পড়য়ে কুসুম বনে
অঞ্চল পাতি লইয়া খুল্লনা।
হইয়া কামের দাস, প্রভু আসিবেন পাশ
ভাবি করে কামের অর্চ্চনা।

more happy than I am.' The creeper she embraced and said 'Tell me by what virtues you have earned the great love in which you are held! The whole forest is made bright by your lovely presence.' The peacock with its partner sounded a gay note but Khullanā was only made sad by it. The bee and her mate drank honey from the same flower and they were so happy! Khullanā clasped her hands and said 'Sing no more, O happy pair, hearing your sweet hum, I am reminded of my absent love.

মন্দ মন্দ বহে হিম দক্ষিণ পবন।
অশোক কিংশুকে রামা করে আলিঙ্গন।
কেতকী ধাতকী ফোটে চম্পক কাঞ্চন।
কুসুম পরাগে শ্লথ হইল অলিগণ।
লতায় বেষ্টিত রামা দেখিয়া অশোক।
খুল্লনা বলেন সই তুমি বড় লোক।
আমা হইতে তোমার জনম দেখি ভালো।
তোমার সোহাগে সখি বন কৈল আলো।
সই সই বলি রামা কোলে কৈল লতা।
স্বরূপে বলিবি সই তপ কৈলি কোথা।

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ভ্রমরী ভ্রমর, তোরে যুড়ি কর
না গাও মধুর গীত।
সঙ্গে তোর বধূ, পান কর মধু
কি কব সুখের ওর।
অনাথী দেখিয়া, তোর নাহি দয়া
চিত্ত হৈল মোর চোর।

From Kavikaṅkaṅ Chandī.

While your mate is with you and you reside in the lotus, alas, how can you realise Khullanā's woes ! Now the humming bees move away, but the cadence of the Kokila's cooings fills the whole sky and Khullanā, like a deluded soul, can only tell her woes to the birds.'

A money-changer's shop.

From pastoral and romantic scenes, let us by way of contrast descend into a money-changer's shop. The passage quoted below contains a description of the interview between Kālaketu and Murāri Çil.

* The money changer Murāri was a knave, he used to lend money and keep accounts. As soon as he learnt from the voice, that Kālaketu had come to the house, he withdrew to the inner appartments, as he owed Kālaketu one and half boorist of cowries as the price of flesh supplied by him. "Where are you uncle" calls Kālaketu, "please come down, I have an urgent business with you !" But the wife of Murāri came out and said "The money-changer is not at home. Your uncle went

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* বেনে বড় দুষ্টশীল, নামেতে মুরারী শীল
লেখা জোখা করে টাকা কড়ি।
পাইয়া বীরের সাড়া, প্রবেশে ভিতর পাড়া
মাংসের ধারয়ে দেড় বুড়ি।
খুড়া খুড়া ডাকে কালকেতু।
কোথা হে বণিক রাজ, বিশেষ আছয়ে কাজ,
আমি আইলাম সেই হেতু॥
বীরের বচন শুনি, আসিয়া বলে বেণ্যাণী
আজি ঘরে নাহিক পোদ্দার।

† One boori is less than a pice.

Murāri Çil. out at early dawn to collect interest from his debtors, the little money that we owe you will be paid to-morrow. You need not wait for him to-day. Bring some fuel and some sweet plums from the woods to-morrow, when we shall pay for them and also clear our own old bill." "I wanted to turn a ring into cash" said Kālaketu. "If Murāri is out, I must hurry away, and find some other money-changer for it. "Wait a moment" said she "let me see what sort of a ring you have." Tempted by the prospect of making a profit, Murāri crept out of the inner appartments by the back door carrying in his hands scales and a purse for bargaining.

প্রভাতে তোমার খুড়া, গিয়াছে খাতক পাড়া
কালি দিব মাংসের উধার।
আজি কালকেতু যাহ ঘর।
কাষ্ঠ আন এক ভার, হাল বাকী দিব ধার
মিষ্ট কিছু আনিহ বদর।
শুনগো শুনগো খুড়ি, কিছু কার্য্য আছে দেরী
ভাঙ্গাইব একটি অঙ্গুরী।
আমার জোহার খুড়ি, কালি দিহ বাকী কড়ি
অন্য বণিকের যাই বাড়ী।
বাপা এক দণ্ড কর বিলম্বন,
সহাস্য বদনে বাণী, বলে বেণে নিতম্বিনী
দেখি বাপা অঙ্গুরী কেমন।
ধনের পাইয়া আশ, আসিতে বীরের পাশ
ধায় বেণে খিড়কির পথে।

The hunter greeted him pleasantly and Murāri said 'How is it nephew that I never see you now-a-days. Your conduct is very strange!' Kālaketu replied 'Uncle I go to the forest early in the morning to spread my nets, and with arrows in hand I wander the whole day long. Phullarā meanwhile sells game in the market and we both come home late in the evening. For this reason you do not see me now as often as you used to do. But uncle I have a ring to dispose of. Will you kindly help me with what it may be worth and save me from great perplexity.' With this he tendered the ring, and the money-changer put it into the scale and noted the

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মনে বড় কুতুহলী, কাঁধেতে কড়ির থলী
হরপী তরাজু করি হাতে ॥
করে বীর বেণেরে জোহার ।
বেণে বলে ভাইপো, এবে নাহি দেখিতো
এ তোর কেমন ব্যবহার ।
খুড়া উঠিয়া প্রভাত কালে, কাননে এড়িয়া জালে
হাতে শর চারি প্রহর ভ্রমি ।
ফুল্লরা পশার করে, সন্ধ্যাকালে যাই ঘরে
এই হেতু নাহি দেখ তুমি ।
খুড়া ভাঙ্গাইব একটি অঙ্গুরী ।
হয়ে মোরে অনুকুল, উচিত করিও মূল
তবে সে বিপদে আমি তরি ।
বীর দেয় অঙ্গুরি, বেণিয়া প্রণাম করি
জোঁখে রত্ন চড়ায়্যে পড়্যান ।
কুঁচ দিয়া করে মান, ষোল রতি ছুই ধান
শ্রীকবিকঙ্কণ রস গান ।

weight to its last grain. He weighs it and declares the weight to be 16 ratis and 2 dhāns: sings Kavikaṅkaṅa the poet.

"No gold or silver is this my nephew! It is bell-metal polished with care,—so it looks bright. Per *rati* you may have ten gandās of cowries. The price of two *dhans* will be five gandās more. The price of the ring comes to eight *panas* and five *gandas* of cowries. Now I owe you for game one and a half *boori*. The total, therefore, is eight *panas* and two and half *booris* of cowries. But the whole

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সোণা রূপা নহে বাপা এ বেঙ্গা পিতল।
ঘসিয়া মাজিয়া বাপা করেছ উজ্জ্বল॥
রতি প্রতি হ'ল বাপা দশগণ্ডা দর।
দুধানের কড়ি আর পাঁচ গণ্ডা ধর॥
অষ্টপণ পঞ্চগণ্ডা অঙ্গুরীর কড়ি।
মাংসের পিছিলা বাকী ধারি দেড় বুড়ি॥
একুনে হইল অষ্ট পোণ আড়াই বুড়ি।
কিছু চালু, চালু খুদ, কিছু লহ কড়ি॥
কালকেতু বলে খুড়া মূল্য নাহি পাই।
যে জন অঙ্গুরী দিল দিব তার ঠাই॥
বেণে বলে দরে বাড়াইলাম পঞ্চবট।
আমা সঙ্গে সওদা করি না পাবে কপট॥
ধন্যকেতু ভায়া সঙ্গে ছিল নেনা দেন।
তাহা হইতে দেখি বাপা বড়ই সেয়ানা॥
কালকেতু বলে খুড়া না কর ঝগড়া।
অঙ্গুরী লইয়া আমি যাই অন্য পাড়া॥
বেণে বলে দরে বাড়াইলাম আড়াই বুড়ি।
চালু খুদ না লইও গুণে লও কড়ি॥

of this need not be paid in cash. Take a portion of the price in cowries and the rest in dust of rice. Kālaketu said 'O my uncle this is far from being the price of the ring. I shall return it to its owner.' The money-changer said 'well, well, I agree to give five *batas* more. You won't find any dishonesty in me! Why, I had money transaction with your father Dharmaketu. But I see that you are far cleverer than your father ever was!' 'No uncle, said Kālaketu, we need not quarrel over the matter. Allow me to go to some other merchant.' 'All right' the money-changer said, "I offer you two and half *booris* more. You need not take the dust of rice, it shall all be paid in cowries."

The contrast.

Thus Kālaketu's straight-forwardness and Murāri's craft are shewn in contrast. Murāri hides himself in his house for fear of having to pay an old debt and when at last, getting scent of a profitable bargain he comes out, he accuses the hunter of not having visited his house! Kālaketu is intelligent enough to understand his knavery, but he is above pettiness and gives him frank and cordial replies.

The characters are life-like.

We find, portrayed in the poems of Mukundarāma all classes of our people, from the wealthiest to the poorest,—all ranks of our society represented as vividly as in life itself. In Çālivahana and Vikramakeçarī we have types of our great land-owners—those rājās whose caprices were equal to their favours,—the luxury of their courts, and the great pressure put upon the Kotwāls or town-inspectors for any mal-administration complained of by the

people. In Dhanapati and his rich kinsmen we have a picture of high life, with side-lights on the flourishing condition of Bengal when trade brought hoards of wealth to her people. In Lahanā and Khullanā,—two distinct types of women, we find the feelings of jealousy and envy which sometimes rend Hindu families in twain and also the great devotion and fidelity which characterise the patient Hindu wife. When we come down from the higher ranks of the Hindu community to the lower, we find our hero Kālaketu and his wife Phullarā, representing all stages of poverty-stricken rustic life, but the manliness of Kālaketu and the chaste-womanhood of Phullarā exemplify the noble qualities which, with all their ignorance and superstition, characterise the masses of Bengal. The poet was a lover of village-life and did not fail to observe the good traits in the characters of humble rustic folk, whom he vindicates in his vivid sketches. The knaves Bhāru Datta and Murāri Çil are true types and the maid servants of the class of Durvalā who cheat their masters of money, while entrusted with marketting and poison the hearts of the inmates of the house against one another, are not even now difficult to find. In a word, all phases of Bengali life in the 16th century from the king of Kaliṅga with his autocratic temper to Vulānmandal anxious for the safety of his fellow Rāyats, are picturesquely represented. We find in the poem, the crystal columns of the wealthy man's mansion, side by side with the hut of the poor-folk having a single ricinus post and roofed with palm leaves, the hole made in the earth to ferment the rice-water, and the abundance of gold plate at the

All phases of Bengali-life.

rich man's table; the deer-skin worn by poor people and the sky-coloured sāḍi of gauze of the high born lady; the hā-du-du-du, and other manly sports of country people, and the rich men's games of chess and dice, together with the theatricals of the period in which scenes from Kriṣṇa's life were played. But through all descriptions runs that devotional feeling for Chandī which hallows every situation in life, and testifies to the spiritual awakening of Bengal in those days. This last gives a more than poetic interest in our eyes to the celebrated work of Mukundarāma. Though our author describes every phase of Bengali life, he is particularly successful in delineating the miseries of rustic people. Through all the romance of situations that he creates, there rises a sound of woe – a deep pathetic tone and a murmur of grief and wailing, and a gloomy effect is left on the mind of the reader, hightened by the provincialisms of the style of the poems, reminding him of the life of the poor in Bengali villages. The redeeming feature of it, as I have said, is the feeling of absolute resignation to the deity, which pervades the poem investing every episode of it with sweetness.

Devotional feeling.

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A few more writers after Mukundarāma, composed poems on Chandī; we give a brief notice of them below :—

Other poems on Chandī.

10. Bhabānīçaṅkara, a Kāyastha whose ancestor Nara Dās left Rāḍadeça (western Bengal) on account of poverty and settled at Chakraçālā in Chittagong. Bhabānīçaṅkara wrote his poem about

Bhabānī Çankara.

the middle of the seventeenth century. In localities where the poem of Mukundarāma was yet unknown, works on Chandī of lesser poetical merit were admired and Bhabānīçaṅkar enjoyed a short-lived popularity in Chittagong in the latter half of the 17th century.

Jaynarāyana Sen.

11. The next writer was Jaynārāyaṇa Sen—a Vaidya who wrote his poem about the year 1763. Jaynārāyaṇa was relative of the far-famed Rājā Rājballāva of Vikrampur and was an eminent poet. He belonged to an age when the Bengali language had grown highly Sanskritised and Bengali poets took great pride in displaying the wealth of Sanskrit metres in Bengali. Though in the delineation of characters, conception of plot and in pathos, Jaynārāyaṇa is assuredly no match for Mukundarāma, yet living as he did directly in the midst of court-influence where a high flown classical taste predominated and in an age when word painting and artistic modes of expression were the craze of the poets, Jaynārāyaṇa shews a commendable skill in bringing into his poem a great variety of metres taken from Sanskrit models. Here is a passage in which our poet describes the attempts of Kāmadeva (the god of love) to conquer the great god Çiva.

Kāmadeva's attempt to conquer Çiva.

* "Kāmadeva made himself ready to march on an expedition of conquest against Çiva. The humming of the bees was his war-drum. The new

* মহেশ করিতে জয় রতি-পতি সাজিল।
দামামা ভ্রমর রব সঘনে বাজিল।
নবকিশলয়েতে পতাকা দশদিশেতে
উড়িল কোকিল সেনা সব চারি পাশেতে।

purple leaves which shot forth from the trees were his flags, and his army consisted of Kokilas that flew in all directions at the royal order. The breeze began to blow gaily. The god (Kāmadeva) now appeared on the scene with sprightly steps; a floral bow hung on his back, and he carried blithely in his hand the five flowers which were his five

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ত্রিগুণ পবন হয় যোগ গতি বেগেতে।
ফুলধনু পিঠে ফুলশর কর-পরেতে।
ভ্রমাইয়া ভাঙ্গে আড় হেরি আঁখি-কোণেতে।
কুসুম-কবচ হাতে কিরীট সাজে শিরেতে।
বাম বাহু রতিগলে রতিবাহু গলেতে।
ভুবন মোহন শর হর মন মোহিতে॥
বায়ুবেগে সকলে উতরে হিমগিরিতে।
আগমন মদন সকল ঋতু সহিতে॥
কুসুমে প্রকাশ গিরি বন-উপবনেতে।
নানা ফুল ফুটিল ছুটিল রব পিকেতে॥
ছুটিল মানিনী মান লাগিল ধ্বনি কাণেতে।
মৃত তরু জীবিত নবীন ফুল-পাতেতে॥
থর থর কেতকী কাঁপিছে মৃদু বাতেতে।
অকালে অশোক ফোটে সেফালিকা-দিনেতে॥
ললিত মালতী ফোটে যুথিকার ডালেতে।
বকুল কদম্ব নাগকেশরের পরেতে॥
মধুকর রব বলি ডাকে মন মদেতে।
কুহরিছে কোকিলসমূহ পাঁচ শরেতে॥
নবলতা মাধবীর নত শির ভূমেতে।
পলাশ টগর বেল নত ফুল-ভরেতে॥

From Jay Nārāyan's Chandi.

arrows. There was a crown of flowers on his head, and a pair of flower-bracelets on his arms. He cast sportive glances all around. His left arm lay round the neck of his dear wife Rati and her arms were entwined with his. At this advent of the God of Love into the Himālaya mountains, with the Seasons for his gay companions,—all the flowers in the valley blossomed and the Kokilas sent aloft their far-reaching notes. Those damsels who had resolved, for some offence, not to speak to their lovers—could not restrain themselves, but ran to meet them, as soon as the high notes of the Kokila reached their ears. The trees, hitherto bereft of leaves revived and were clothed with fresh flowers and leaves. The beautiful Ketaki flower sported with the gentle breeze. The Açoka flower bloomed when the Çephalikā should bloom. Nature's laws seemed to be upset; from the bough of Jasmine, the Mālati flower shot forth, and from the bough of the Nagakeçara, by a curious sport of Nature, appeard the Vakula and the Kadamba. The humming of the bees charmed the ears and the Kokila's high note rent the air. The Mādhavī creepers, the Palāça tree, the Tagara and the Vela plants drooped under their wealth of flowers."

But all this availed not, and we know that Kāmadeva was reduced to ashes by the spark that flashed from the third eye of Çiva.

We shall have to refer to Jay Nārāyaṇa in a future chapter and so close our remarks about him here.

Çivā Charan Sen.

12. Çiva Charan Sen—the author of 'Sāradā Maṅgal' (a translation of the Rāmāyaṇa) wrote a

poem on Chandī. He was contemporary with Jay Nārāyaṇa. There are some sparkling passages in his poem.

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But the list of poems in honour of the local deities of Bengal does not end here. There are many other goddesses belonging to the Çākta-cult in whose honour long poems have been composed. It is not possible to give any detailed idea of these. But we shall briefly refer to some of them here.

(c) Poems on Gaṅgā Devī.

The sanctity of the Ganges.

We find a certain nnmber of poems written in honour of Gaṅgādevī, goddess of the Ganges. Amongst the Hindus the Ganges is sacred. When dying, we must have at least a drop of Ganges' water, or we feel disconsolate at the hour of death. This instinct is deeply engrained in the minds of our people. The late P. C. Roy of the Bengal Provincial Service, who was so advanced in his views, that at the close of his official career, he retired to England and married an English woman, literally pined for a drop of Ganges' water, during his last illness in England, and his English wife has informed her Indian relatives of this, in several touching letters.

Stripped of the mythological account given of its origin, it is possible that its present course is in some measure due to the engineering enterprises of some of the early Hindu Princes, of whom Bhagiratha, according to the tradition current in the country, was the most successful. The river

is associated with the glory of an ancient Indian monarch, but it formed, besides, in the Paurāṇik age the very nucleus of the whole Indo-Aryan-civilisation. The Aryans, here, as their numbers increased, apprehended that the strength and the compactness of their society would be lost, if they were scattered all over the country. Probably it was owing to this reason that they recommended their own men to settle and to erect dwelling houses and temples on the banks of the Ganges enjoining it to be an act of particular merit,—so that the whole Aryan population might form a compact community in the Gangetic valley. Those who lived beyond the pale of this blessed region were looked down upon by the dwellers in it and were, besides, required to travel all the distance from their homes, to come to the Ganges and bathe in its sacred waters to expiate their sins. The object of this injunction was probably to keep outsiders in touch with the main society.

The Ganges is beloved of the Hindus, not only on account of the glorious cities that adorn her banks,—not only because all that was sublime and beautiful in the past Hindu history, is, in some way or other, connected with her noble waters, but in a far greater sense, for the associations she carries, of ancient saints and sages who loved her and composed hymns to her glory. From Vālmiki, the divine sage and poet, downwards, we have a host of these hymn-makers, and the Bengali hymn of Ajodhyārām only echoes sentiments already expressed thousands of years earlier. The Ganges was worshipped because the Hindus found in the majestic sweep of her course and in the sublime

music of her waters—a divine message and revelation. In the Gitā we have it in the mouth of Kriṣṇa—"Amongst mountains, I am the Himālayas, and amongst rivers, I am the Ganges."

Mādhavāchāryya.

(1) We have dwelt upon a poem on Maṅgalā Chandī by Mādhavāchāryya written in 1679. This poet wrote a poem also in honour of Gaṅgā Devī. It contains 5000 lines.

Kamalākānta.

(2) Gaṅgā Maṅgal by Dwija Kamalākānta. The poet was a native of Kogram in Burdwan.

Jayrām Dās.

(3) Gaṅgā Maṅgal by Jayrām Dās, a Vaidya. He was a native of Guptipāḍa in Hughly. His work was written early in the eighteenth century.

Dwija Durgā Prasād.

(4) The most popular work on Gaṅgādevī is the one written by Dwija Durgāprasād—a native of Ulā in Nadia. He wrote his poem about 1778 A.D. He refers to a dream dreamt by his wife in which Gaṅgā Devī had appeared before her, and given an order to her husband requiring him to write a poem to her glory. This poem shows considerable power.

Short hymns.

Besides all these, there were numerous short hymns to Gaṅgā Devī by Kavi Chandra, Ayodhyārām, Kavikaṅkaṇa, Nidhirām and other poets.

(d) Çītalā Maṅgala—or poems in honour of Çītalā Devī.

Hāriti, and Çitalā Devi.

Çītalā Devī or the goddess presiding over small-pox and other diseases of the same class,—riding on an ass, is considered by some scholars to be identical with the Buddhistic goddess Hāriti Devī. The priests who worship her,

belong to the Doma caste—a significant circumstance, which proves the Buddhistic origin of the worship of this goddess, as prevalent in Bengal. Her form as made in clay, however, in this country does not represent a Buddhistic conception. The Brāhmins have traced her back to the Vedas. They consider the word 'Taksan' in the Atharva Veda, and also another word 'Āpdevī,' which occurs in various places in Vedic literature as signifying the goddess Çītalā. In the Skandapurāṇa and in the Picchilātantra there are accounts of this goddess. But the block of stone, roughly representing a face, covered with vermilion and with brass points fixed on it, which the Doma Pandits carry from door to door, asking for offerings in the name of the deity, does not seem to own any kinship with the figure of the goddess artistically made of clay by Bengal potters. The latter is evidently a Hindu conception.

Traces of Buddhistic influence;

Poems in honour of Çītalā Devī bear evident traces of Buddhistic influence. The goddess is described in one of them as riding on an '*uluk*' or owl. The bird '*uluk*,' which is sometimes transformed into a sage in Buddhistic tales, occurs frequently in the Çūnyapurāṇa and in the Dharmamaṅgals. This suggests that Çītalā Devī was connected with the Buddhists. In another poem on the goddess, the author (Nityānanda) says that no good poems in honour of Çītalā Devī, could be found in Bengal, while in Uḍiyā literature there was an abundance of such works which could be traced back to the very earliest times. The author describes how he took great pains to collect them from Orissā and compile a Çītalā Maṅgala on their lines, in Bengali. Orissā was a strong-hold of Buddhism

till comparatively recent times, and Uḍiyā literature, when properly explored, will, we hope, show even more traces of Buddhistic influence than old Bengali literature.

and of Hindu Renaissance.

But, like the Dharmamaṅgals and other poems of the Buddhistic cult, the Çītalāmaṅgals also bear the stamp of the influence of the Hindu Renaissance; and the Hindu writers, who undertook to write such works in later times, gradually gave them the shape of Paurāṇik poems. The story of King Chandra Ketu and the troubles he underwent, for declining to worship Çītalā Devī, with his eventual surrender of himself to the mercy of the goddess, by which he recovered his lost fortune and achieved other rewards, forms the subject-matter of these poems.

The subject-matter.

Daivakinandan and other poets.

The first poet of Çītalāmaṅgala, on whose work we were able to lay our hands, was Daivakīnandana. He wrote his poem about three hundred years ago. The father of Daivakīnandana was one Gopāl Dās. The ancestors of our poet were formerly inhabitants of Hatinā in Burdwan, and the family latterly settled in Vāiḍyapur in that district. The next work, a voluminous one, was written by Nityānanda Chakravarti, who was a Pandit in the court of Rajnārāyaṇa Rāy, a Zamindar of Kāçigāon in Midnapur. Of other works in honour of Çītalā Devī we may mention those by Kriṣṇarām, Ramprasād and Çaṅkarachāryya.

(e) Laksmī Charita—or poems on Lakṣmī, the Goddess of Wealth.

The worship of Lakṣmi may also be traced back to the very earliest times. The autumn is the season for harvests, and in an agricultural country like

India the deity presiding over the rice and oat-fields naturally obtained homage from her rural population in this season. In the Rāmāyaṅa we find the description of a golden image of Lakṣmi with two elephants on either side pouring water over her head in the Açoka-Banika of Rāvana. The goddess in that particular form and position is known here as Gaja Lakṣmi, and after more than two thousand years, the Jaypur sculptors still make images of the goddess exactly answering the description of the Rāmāyaṅa. The goddess Lakṣmi or Çrī was one of the most familiar deities worshipped by the Buddhists. On the door-way of many Buddhist temples the image of this goddess is found in a prominent position curved in bas-relief. It is curious to observe, that a class of rural Muhammedan folk of Bengal have, for their sole occupation, the reciting of hymns in Bengali in honour of Lakṣmi-Devi. This function exclusively belongs to them, and their Hindu brethern do not seem to grudge this. In Java, Lakṣmi is worshipped by the Muhammedans of the place. Alas, the humble agricultural Hindu or the Buddhist could give up the worship of all gods and goddesses after his conversion to Islam but not of his harvest-goddess !

Lakṣmī's hymns recited by Muhammedans;

who also worship her in Java.

A long poem was written three hundred years ago in honour of this goddess by Çivānanda Kar, who had the title of Guṇarājkhān. The next poem on the subject was written by Jagamohan Mitra, who seems to have been a clever poet. He devotes a part of his book to a description of Çiva and Umā in Kailāça and other matters. The last poem of the Lakṣmi-cult was written by Ranjitrām Dās in 1806.

Çivānanda Kar and other poets.

Poems in honour of Sarasvati, the goddess of learning.

The goddess of learning, Sarasvatī, was not without her votaries among the early Bengali poets. Of the numerous poems, which glorify her, one by Dayārām Dās displays some poetic skill. The book is divided into seventeen cantos and tells an animated story describing how by the grace of the goddess one might achieve scholarship without much study. Dayārām was an inhabitant of the village of Kiçarchawk in Perganna Kāçīgaon in the district of Midnapur.

Dayārām Dās.

Ṣaṣṭhīmaṅgala or poems in honour of Ṣaṣṭhī Devī.

This goddess is the presiding deity of babies. She rides on a cat. It is her function to preserve little children from falling a prey to sickness and premature death. As is natural, she is held in great respect by the women-folk of Bengal. We find mention of Ṣaṣṭhī Devī in the Vrahmhavaivarta purāṇa and in Devī-bhāgavata. Kriṣṇarām wrote a poem in honour of Ṣaṣṭhī Devī in 1687 A.D. The poem as usual tells a story of more or less interest with occasional passages of poetic beauty, and ends in establishing the glory of Ṣaṣṭhī Devī by bringing to a happy termination all adverse incidents by her grace. Sātgāon (Saptagrām,) was in a highly flourishing condition, when Kriṣnarām wrote his poem; he refers to that historic city in the following lines :—

Kriṣṇarām.

Sātgāon.

* "I saw Rāḍha, Vaṅga, Kaliṅga, and Nepāl; I saw Gayā, Prayāg, and Kāmpal and travelled

* রাঢ় বঙ্গ দেখিলাম কলিঙ্গ নেপাল।
গয়া পইরাগ দেখিলাম নিষাদ কাঁপাল।

through various cities besides ; everywhere did I see Ṣasṭhi Devī worshipped with great pomp ; and nowhere in the whole country did I find a city so flourishing as Sātagāon, where people dwelt in dense array on the banks of the Ganges."

5. Dharma Maṅgal-poems recast by the Brahmins.

Paurāṇik spirit prominent in the poems.

As I said before, these poems were originally written to glorify Dharma Ṭhākur who represented Buddha in the days of the degenerecy of Buddhism in Bengal. A wave of Hindu thought came surging upon the story, however, in later days, and the poems were transformed in such a manner that Buddhistic ideas fell into the lower stratum and the Paurāṇik spirit became prominent in them. The original conception is Buddhistic notwithstanding, and scholars are still able to trace it.

Mayur Bhatta and other poets.

The earliest poet who sang of Dharma Ṭhākur was Mayur Bhatta. To him encomiums and tributes of respect were paid by all subsequent writers on the subject. Next comes Rūpa Rām who is often called Ādi-Rūprām. Khellārām wrote his poem in 1527 A.D. and Sītārām Dās was probably his contemporary. Sītārām refers to the poem of Mayur Bhatta as having been partially lost or become obsolete during his time, which makes us suppose that Mayur Bhatta wrote in the 13th century or earlier. A manuscript of Dharmamaṅgal by Prabhu Rām secured by Babu Nagendra Nāth

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একে একে ভ্রমণ করিলাম দেশ দেশ।
দেখিনু দেবীর পূজা অশেষ বিশেষ
সপ্তগ্রাম দেখিলাম নাহি তার তুল।
চালে চালে ঠেকে লোক ভাগিরথী কুল।

Vasu is 300 years old, so this poet also probably lived at the time when Khelārām and Sītārām were writing their poems.

Mānik Gāngooly, 1547 A.D.

Mānik Gāṅguli's poem has lately been pulished by the Vaṅgīya Sāhitya Pariṣat of Calcutta. He seems to have been the first amongst respectable Brāhmins who undertook to write a poem in honour of Dharma-Ṭhākur. As the subject was Buddhistic, he was naturally averse to taking it up, and in the preliminary account of himself, he speaks of the undertaking with evident diffidence and misgivings. Mānik Gāṅgulī finished his work in 1547. His poem is a long one, being twice the size of 'Paradise Lost.'

Other Dharma-mangals. Ghanarām, 1713 A.D.

We come next to the Dharma Maṅgal by Dwija Rāmachandra and Çyāma Dās. But by far the most popular writer of Dharmamaṅgal was Chakravartī Ghaṇarām who wrote in 1713 A.D. by order of Kriṣṇa Chandra, Rājā of Kriṣṇapur. The poet's father's name was Gauri Kāntha and his mother's Sītā. The poem was published by Vaṅgavāshī Press of Calcutta, some years ago.

The poems known as Dharmamaṅgal are as a rule full of historical accounts which though distorted, throw light on some of the darker pages of our history before Muhammedan rule began. They have this interest, though we fail to see in most of them any great literary merit. Ghaṇarām was not, however, altogether without talents; occasionally only we come across vivid description of warfare, of the Darbār of Hindu kings, and of the wily stratagems of Mahudīyā which while suggesting incidents of the past history are, at the same time, full

of genuine poetic animation. But the poem generally lacks in that interest which good poetry inspires in the mind of the readers. Those who do not specially seek for historical material will often find it dull and uninteresting. Here is a passage in which a wounded soldier—a sprightly young man Çākā—when on the point of death in the battle-field speaks to his brother Çiṅgādār.*

Çakā's dying words.

"O brother Çiṅgādār, see what is the lot that was at last reserved for me! Woe is to me! I die in nocturnal fight, and at this last moment of life I cannot have a glimpse of my parents and friends. Here is the locket which I have always worn on my

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* শিঙ্গাদার ওরে ভাই এই ছিল আমার কপালে
নিশায় নিধন রণে, পিতা মাতা বন্ধুগণে
দেখিতে না পেনু শেষকালে।
গলার কবচ মোর, শিঙ্গাদার ধর ধর
দিহ মোর যেথানে জননী।
নিশান অঙ্গুরী লয়ে, ময়ুরার হাতে দিয়ে।
ক'য়ো তারে হ'লে অনাথিনী॥
তারে মোর মায়ের হাতে হাতে।
সঁপে সমাচার বলো, অকালে অভাগা ম'লো
অভাগিনী রাখে সাথে সাথে।
শুকার সুবর্ণ ছড়া, বাপেরও ঢাল খাড়া
সমর্পিয়ে সমাচার বলো।
রণে অকাতরে হয়ে, শত্রু শির সংহারিয়ে
সম্মুখ সমরে শাকা মলো।
কাণের কুণ্ডল ধর, শিঙ্গাদার তুমি পর
ছুরী তীরে তুষ বীরগণে।

neck; take it and give it to my poor mother;—this ring is my last token, give it, please, to my wife Mayurā, and say to her 'you have become a widow'; commend her to my mother's care and tell my mother that I die an untimely death, leaving my poor wife in her charge. Here are my father's sword and shield. My golden chain I leave to Sukā, tell him that dauntlessly fighting I killed a host of enemies, and die at last in the open field. Here are my ear-rings, O Çiṅgādār—accept them, my brother, as my last gift and here my quiver full of arrows, which, please, distribute amongst my comrades.' At these words both brothers wept, and the dying man spoke, again 'tell my parents to bless me and forgive my faults, and offer my dying respect at their feet. How sorrowful am I that I could not see them again in life. Prematurely has their unfortunate son to bid them his last adue. My heart is pierced

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শুনি শোকে শিঙ্গাদার, চক্ষে বহে জলধার,
বহে লোহ শাকার নয়নে।
কেন্দে কহে পুনর্ব্বার, অপরাধ অভাগার
খণ্ডাইতে মা বাপের পায়
প্রণতি অসংখ্য বার, দেখা নাহি হলো আর
অল্পকালে অভাগা বিদায়।
মরমে রহিল শেল, হেন জন্ম বৃথা গেল
মুখে না বলিনু রাম নাম।
ব্রাহ্মণ বৈষ্ণব দেবা, জনক জননী সেবা,
না করিনু বিধি হইল বাম॥"

From Dharma Maṅgal,
by Ghanarām, Canto., XXII.

with remorse that my life has been spent in vain. I did not recite the name of Rām, nor did I offer prayers to the gods or worship Brāhmins and Vaiṣṇavas. I did not minister to the wants of my old parents. Surely Providence was against me."

The poems look like Chandi-Maṅgals.

The worshipping of Brāhmins referred to in this speech of Çākā as if it were a highly meritorious act, for omitting which he became repentant at the hour of death, evidences how far the poems were Hinduised ; in fact Dharma Ṭhākur is thrown into the back ground in these poems and in his place the goddess Chandī has become conspicuous. The poems in fact look like those belonging to the Çākta-Cult.

Sahadeva Chakravarty, 1740 A.D.

But by far the best poem on Dharma Ṭhākur, though not so popular as Ghanarām's Dharma Maṅgal, is the one written by Sahadeva Chakravarti in 1740. This writer does not, like his predecessors, treat the subject of Lau Sen's heroic achievements. His poem has retained more Buddistic elements than any other work of the kind that we have come across. I give below a descriptive list of its cantos :—

1. Hymns in praise of Dharma Ṭhākur, Bhagavati, Lakṣmī, Sarasvati, Chaitanya, Tārakeçvara, etc.

2. Salutations offered to Jīva and other contemporary poets and to the author's parents.

3. An account of creation, how Brahmā, Viṣṇu, and Çiva came into existence. The marriage of Çiva. His agricultural operations in the field called Kāmadā. Chandī appears as a Vāgdinī woman in disguise. Çiva and Chandī catch fish. Çiva returns to Kailāsha with products of the harvest.

4. Chandī asks Çiva questions on metaphysical points. They both reach the banks of the river Vallukā. Mīnanāth who was in the womb of a fish is endowed with wisdom on hearing the truths that fall from the lips of Çiva. Mīnanāth obtains Mahājñāna or supreme knowledge.

5. Mīnanāth abuses Chandī. The curse of Chandī on Mīnanāth. Owing to the curse Mīnanāth falls into evil company at Kadali Pattan. The saint is transformed into a goat. He becomes himself again through the efforts of his disciple Gorakṣanāth.

6. A meeting of the saints Kālipā, Haḍipa, Minanāth, Gorakṣanath and Chauraṅgi. Hymns in honour of Çiva and Chandi.

7. Minanāth gets possession of a kingdom in Mahānada; the account of the origin of the dynasty of Sāgara; Çiva in the guise of a Doma worships Dharma in the town of Amarā. Bhumichandra the king of Amarā oppresses the Domas.

8. The king is afflicted with white leprosy as a result of his wickedness. He is cured by worshipping Dharma Ṭhākur.

9. Çridhara, son of Ramāi Pandit abuses Dharma. He is killed in Varadā Pattan for this act. Ramāi restores him to life.

10. The Brahmins of Jājpur oppose Dharma-worship. Dharma appears in the field with his companions in the guise of Muhammadens in order to preserve his followers. Rājā Bhumichandra cuts off his own son's head as a sacrifice to Dharma. The Rājā then goes to heaven by the grace of Dharma.

11. Rājā Hariç Chandra abuses Dharma. He goes to the forest with his queen and dies. The queen worships Dharma and the Rājā is restored to life. A son is born to them; they name him Lui Chandra. Dharma comes in the guise of a Brāhmin to try the Rājā. The Rājā kills his son Lui in order to feed the Brāhmin with his flesh. Dharma restores Lui to life.

Glimpses of history.

The subjects treated of in this poem strike us by their novelty. The saints Minanāth, Gorakṣnāth, Hāḍipā, and Kālipā had figured as great religious teachers of the masses immediately before the decadence of Buddhism in this country. The places Kadalipāttan, Sāradāpāttan, Amarā and Jājpur were, we suppose, associated in some way or other with important incidents relating to Dharma-worship. We have no historical information whatsoever as to the form in which Buddhism existed in this country and influenced the masses during the time of the Pāl Kings. The Rājās mentioned in the poem probably belonged to that dynasty. However crude and distorted the state in which we find these stories, there was, no doubt, some ground-work of fact on which they were based. When by the researches of scholars, we are put in possession of authentic accounts of later Buddhism, these stories, we venture to hope, may aid materially in unravelling the social history of Bengal at the period in question.

Sahadeva's style.

Sahadeva writes for the people; his compositions are full of provincialisms; they are always to the point, and are very little affected by the influence of Sanskrit. As in style, so in subject, he shows an affinity to the Buddhistic school. While

there are passages in his work which are full of poetry, he always uses plain homely similes taken from common objects.

These poems belong to Paurāṇik revival.

All the poems called Dharma Maṅgala which are treated of in this chapter, bear the stamp of the Paurāṇik Renaissance inspite of their Buddhistic ground-work. The writers wrote them in Sanskritic style and introduced into them thoughts and ideas which characterise the period of the revival of Hinduism and even the poem of Sahadeva Chakravarti which more than any other work of this class belongs to the people, is not without a touch of the predominant ideas of the time. The poems shew how Hindu ideals gradually rose to prominence; Buddhistic ways of thought being thrown in them, into the remote back-ground. It is for this reason that we have included these works in our review of literature belonging to the Paurāṇik Revival in Bengal.

6. Poems in honour of Dakṣin Rāi.

The god of tigers.

Yet another god and we have done with this chapter. He is Dakṣin Rāi, the god of tigers. He is worshipped in many parts of Bengal, where tigers make havac amongst men,—especially in districts adjoining the Sundarvans. The form of this god, as made in clay, is that of a warrior with bow and arrows in his hands. He rides on a tiger. His first poetic votary was Mādhavācāryya, who lived in the middle of the 17th century. The work is called Rāyamaṅgala. The next poem on the subject by Kriṣṇarām contains two significant lines, which show the god as anxious to receive wor-

ship from the country people, to whom he holds out a menace. The poet tells how he dreamt a dream in which Dakṣin Rāi appeared to him and said :—

His threat.

"If there is any one to be found, who does not like your poem, be sure, he will be devoured by tigers with his whole family."

The rustic element and the classical standard both.

So we find in this literature much that is crude, and suited only for a rustic population. But many of its good works, which form a part of the Renaissance literature, conform to a high classical standard, and there are descriptions of great beauty and marked effects in word-painting, which in a subsequent age developed into a high-flown and ornate style,—the characteristic of the age of Bhārat Chandra. The worshippers of Manasā Devī and Maṅgal Chandī were to be found all over Bengal, and many eminent poets were drawn into writing poems in their honour, and these works are characterised by a true literary excellence ; but there were other poems, which show a crudeness befitting rustic literature, as that on the god of tigers just referred to.

Some remarks about the Poems.

The popular stories presented in a new garb.

As already explained, the illeterate villagers of Bengal worshipped many gods and goddesses under the influence of Tāntrik Buddhism, and the Hindu priests gradually took these up, and associating them with the deities of the Hindu pantheon as related in the Purāṇas, Hinduised the whole spiritual atmosphere of Bengal. They connected the fables current in the country with the Çāstrik stories and thus bridged over a gap, created by the loss of Buddhistic ascendency and its traditions in Bengal.

This contact of the popular faith with the new creed, that was being introduced, created a strange force, which is to be observed in a growing literary activity all over the country. Hindus did not destroy, but improved upon, what was left of Buddhism, and the literature of the Paurāṇik Renaissance, while showing an unmistakable rebirth of Sanskritic ideals, had a place reserved for popular creeds and also for the stories current in the country, which the Brahmanic School presented in a new and attractive garb.

Development not always the rule.

But the whole of nature does not flourish at the same time; we find some buds turning into flowers, side by side with others that have withered; similarly, the stories of Chandī and Manasā Devī developed into poems of high literary excellence, but those of Rāy Maṅgal and Dhanya Purnimā Vrata Katha betray the early literary stage in which they were left,—doomed to premature decay. The worship of the sun which may be traced back to very early times, has attached to it, a number of poems whose chief exponents in Bengali were Dwija Kālidāsa and Dwija Rāmjīvan Vidyabhusana. The poems in honour of the sun-god tell a story in illustration of his glory as is usual in works of this kind. In the poem of Rāmjīvana Vidyābhuṣaṇa (written in 1689 A.D.) we find descriptions of the oppression of the Hāḍīs by the sun-worshippers. The Hāḍīs were Buddhists and the incidents related of this oppression, couched in the form of a mythical story have reference, as I believe, to an actual fight between the Buddhists and the worshippers of the sun. At one time the worship of the sun formed the most important factor in the religious func-

Poems in honour of the sun.

tions of the Bengalis. This is evidenced by the discovery of numerous images of the sun-god of great size and artistic beauty all over the country, especially in East Bengal. But the worship of this god was in later times reduced to the recitation of some hymns only, and Bengali poems in honour of him were not destined to flourish.

Supplementary Notes.

TO

CHAPTER IV.

As a result of the conquest of Bengal by the Muhammadans and their settlement in the country, a number of Persian and Arabic words were mixed with the dialect current in Bengal. In the official and business-life this foreign element naturally predominated. Sanskritic words were replaced by those imported by Moslem settlers. As the Hindus gradually lost administrative functions, the language of the court became full of Arabic and Persian words. Articles of luxury and the customs of high life bore foreign names, and the fact of a conquering nation gradually monopolizing all power, together with all the important and profitable activities is evidenced in the indelible marks left on our language,—this importation of foreign words having commenced so early as 1203 A.D. when the Muhammadans invaded Bangal.

Mixture of Arabic and Persian words in Bengali.

It is a sad history for Hindus. The words ধর্ম্মাধিকার (Justice of the peace), নিশানাথ (the town-inspector), পাত্র (minister), সেনা (soldier) and similar words denoting functionaries high and low, which we often meet with in our early literature, were gradually replaced by the words কাজি, কোটাল, উজির, পাইক etc., shewing that the courts of the Hindu Kings were being thrown into

shade while those of the Muhammadans flourished. The word নগর which means a city was replaced by the word সহর; the Bengali টাকা a rupee (from Sanskrit টঙ্কা) when received as revenue by the Muhammadan rulers became খাজনা; the words ভূমি and ভুঁঞা (from Sans ভৌমিক) signifying land and land-owner were replaced by জমি and জমিদার. The mansions of the rich and all big buildings were no longer called অট্টালিকা but became known as এমারৎ. The little earthen lamp retained its old name প্রদীপ, but the word which once implied all classes of lamps became restricted in sense. Chandeliers and the wall-lamps were now called ঝাড় and দেওয়ালগিরি respectively, and so in all departments of life, the very words imported into our tongue by the Muhammadans shew that they were enjoying the cream of things and monopolizing all power. The case was the same as that of the Saxon language after the Norman conquest. The victors who were placed in power introduced their own words into the spheres with which they were directly connected.

Conservetiveness of Hindu writers.

But, curiously, in the vernacular literature of the Hindus, inspite of this common use of foreign words, our writers showed great unwillingness to adopt non-Sanskritic words. In the old literature of Bengal we seldom come across foreign words. In the pride of what Hindus considered to be their own superior civilization, they remained aloof from Muhammadan contact as for as practicable, contented with their own social life and the cultivation of their classical literature. They cared not who administered the country; thus the word সহর (city) is of Muhammadan origin, while গাঁ (a village) remained true to the Sanskritic form. In the village the Hindu

element was not sullied by the touch of anything foreign. The word চাঁদ (moon), সূর্য্য (sun), বায়ু (air), পানী (water) ফুল (flower) and those denoting objects of nature and social life retained their original Sanskrit or Prakitic forms—not to speak of words relating to religious functions which remained unchanged. As nearly all Bengali works of the period deal with social and religious subjects, there are scarcely any foreign words in them, and only a sprinkling of these occurs in the descriptions of the Courts of kings.

The Sanskritisation of Bengali.

This was an age when Sanskritic words were being largely vernacularised, a practice to which we have already alluded. The translations are full of instances of highly artistic Sanskrit expressions as কমলাংঘ্রতল' 'অগ্নিআংশু যেন পাংশু' 'চলৎচপলা' etc. A new school had came into existence, the function of which was to Sanskritise Bengali. Even in the works of Mukundarāma who more than any other Bengali poet except Chandī Dās used provincialisms in his poetry, we come across such words as মাতুলুঙ্গ, ঈষুপাশ, নিম্ন and প্রবল-চপল-ভঙ্গ। The ingenious similes and figurative expressions which developed in a subsequent period are indicated in Mukundarāma's writings though he seemed least inclined to use them. He belonged to the school of the people but owned some kinship with that of the pedantic scholars also. We quote here a passage in illustration ;—

Pedantic style in Mukundrām.

"I cannot describe the beauty of Umā's face. Smitten by its beauty the moon dares not appear in the daytime, for this reason the moon looks pale and wears a blot which men speak of as the lunar spot. The pomegranate seeds, beaten by the beauty of Umā's teeth, have lost their

lustre. The pomegranate fruit bursts when ripe, owing to this feeling of shame." These lines of Mukundarāma, sounds a prelude to the style of which Bhārat Chandra in a later age was the finished master. In the literature of this period there will be found instances of figures of speech and clever turns of thought borrowed from Sanskrit, shewing that a new era was dawning on our literature which welcomed art in the place of nature, and valued the rules of Sanskrit rhetoric more than the dictates of the heart.

A new era.

Correction of Orthography.

Along with the resuscitation of Sanskrit words, systematic efforts were being made to correct the spelling of Bengali words, which still retained the forms prescribed by Prākrita Orthography. This process along with that of Sanskritising words, has ever since been going on in our literature. There are many words of Sanskritic origin in Bengali even now which are spelt after the rules of Prākrita grammar; such for instance are the words কাজ, সোনা, কান and সাদা which are derived from the Sanskrit কার্য্য, স্বর্ণ, কর্ণ and শ্বেত respectively, but which still retain Prākrita spelling. The purists will, I am sure, ere long correct them. In old manuscripts we find innumerable instances of কে, কাহার, কার which are no longer presented to us in such Prākrita forms. The M.S. of Chandi Kāvya, believed to be written by Mukundarāma himself, shows spellings of words which do not always conform to Sanskrit grammar; but Mukundarāma, it should be remembered, lived in an age when Prākrita forms of spelling were current in written Bengali,—when the purists had just began to correct the Vernacular

language on the model of Sanskrit grammar and its orthography. Mukundarāma lived in this transition period; he used provincial words which were latterly condemned as unworthy to find a place in decent literature, as often as he used Sanskritic. In the spelling of words also he favoured the Prākrita forms in use, as often as he adopted Sanskritic forms. The charge of mistakes in spelling cannot be laid at his door, as during his time old ways were not given up in our language, and the Sanskrit orthography was not yet fully adopted for the regulation of Vernacular writings.

The five Gauḍas;

The five Gauḍas or "five Indies" *viz.* Svārasvata (the Pānjab), Kānyakuvja (Kanoja), Gauḍa (Bengal), Mithīlā (Durbhāṅgā), and Utkala (Orissā) were formerly more allied to one another than they are now. We find the Bengalis to have been in close touch with the people of other parts of Āryyāvarta. The old Bengali poems were known by the common name of Pānchāli. This word shews that we owe at least some forms of the old Bengali metres to Panchāla or Kānoja. Svārasvata or the Pānjab gave us its Çaka era which was adopted by the Bengalis, as it was by the people of other parts of India. The civilization of Bengal—the new learning, especially that of logic, which made the *tols* of Nadia famous throughout India, came from Mithilā, when Magadha, its glorious days over, had ceased to give light to Eastern India. With Kaliṅga or Orissā, Bengal in the past was inseparably associated. Our prophet Chaitanya Deva counts more votaries amongst the Uriyā people than in Bengal itself. So we find that the five Gauḍas.

in close touch with one another.

as the five influencial Provinces of Āryyāvarta were called, had in the past ages a greater touch with one another and exchanged their thoughts and ideas more freely than now.

Affinity in language.

Vaiṣṇava literature has brought many Hindi words into Bengali. In fact a large number of songs in old Vaiṣṇava literature were composed in what is called Vrajavali—a sort of Hindi current in Durbhānga. This admixture of Hindi with Bengali was due to the predilection in favour of the dialect of Vrindāvan on the part of Vaiṣṇava writers. They also adopted it in order to imitate Vidyāpati the great master of songs, who wrote in the Maithila language. But the Hindi words occurring in the works of the Vaiṣṇavas cannot claim a place in the vocabulary of the Bengali language. Outside the pale of Vaiṣṇava literature we come across many Bengali words more or less allied to Hindi and other dialects of Āryyāvarta, the use of which has grown obsolete now. This indicates that Bengali in early times, as we might have surmised, bore a closer affinity than now to other dialects of Northern India, whose origin is Sanskritic. It branched off from the parent language at a remote point of time when the Aryan settlers divided themselves into communities and settled in different parts of the country. So in the past the dialects also were nearer to one another. This fact in the case of Bengali is evidenced by the existence of the following and other similar words in our literature of the 15th and 16th centuries.

"যেত্‌কে, তেত্‌কে, বড়্‌য়া, পইতায়, সুবোধিয়া, সরুয়া, পোখরি, বাবন, দোন, ভাবিয়া (Mānik Chandra Rājār

Gān) সাশিয়াল, বাউরী, সতাই, শিবাই, বড়ি, টিট, পাকনা সোয়াস্তি (Vijay Gupta); বহিন, শুতিল, এড়া (Krithivāsa); আবর, (আর), করিয়োহুঁ, (করিলাম), ভৈল, (হইল), বড়া, (বড়), হেয়া হ'য়ে, বহুঁতর (অনেক), হুয়োক (হউক), আবে (এখন), হইনুই (হই কি না), পালটাইয়া (ফিরে), কিস্‌ক (কেন), ভাহাই (ভাই), নজীঁব (বাঁচিবনা), পিন্দই (পরিধান করে), (Ananta-Rāmāyana); কঁরো, কৈঁলু, দোহা, আঁইলু, শকুনিয়া, করিলেন্ত, যায়, পড়িলেন্ত, আইবেন্ত, etc., মোহর, চাহসি, কহসি, করসি etc., নিয়ড়ে, কাঁহা, তুমি, সব, যাও, বোলাও, এহি, বিহা, চিহ্ন, নিঁদ, কেহ্নে, পাকায়, (Sañjaya, Kavindra, Çrikarṇa Nandi and others.)

Of the words quoted above, শুতিল is still in use in Durbhāngā. The words করেন্ত, বলেন্ত etc. are used in Orissā. The suffix 'য়া' occurring in the proper names such as শাকুনিয়া reminds us of Hindi. The Hindi word আবে changed into য়্যাবে is still in use in Eastern Bengal. The case-endings as in পরদেশকো লাগিয়া, জলকো লাগিয়া in Mānik Chandra Rājār Gān and ঘরকে গমন in Krittivāsa and কাঁধকে রুমাল in Kriṣṇa Vijay are akin to uses current in Hindi.

Agreement in habits and costumes.

Not only in the language, but also in costumes and habits, the Bengalis of past times were more like their brethern of the up-country. They used to wear a turban and tuck up the Dhuti tightly between the legs as the Hindustani people do now. When the merchant Chānd presented three silk clothes to the Rājā of Ceylon, the Rājā was taught to wear it after the fashion of the Bengalis, and Vijay Gupta thus describes it :—

* "One the Rājā wore round the loins tucking the ends tightly between the legs. Of the other he made a turban, and with the third he covered his body."—In Mānik Chandra Rajār Gān we found Nengā brother of Rājā Mānik Chandra asking him to take his turban off as his mother was dead. The ladies of Bengal used to wear a bodice called Kanchuli like the up-country women of today. We meet with description of the Kānchuli in almost all our writers from Vijay Gupta downward. The custom lingered even up to the time of Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra of Nadiā in the eighteenth century. We quote from the Bengali work called Kṣitiça Vaṁçāvalī Charita† "The queen (of Kriṣṇa Chandra) and the ladies of the royal family used to wear silk Çāḍis but during festivities and on important religious occasions they put on the Kānchuli (bodice), Ghāgrā (a sort of gown worn by up-country women), and Oḍṇa as the ladies of the North-western countries do." A description of this Oḍṇā is to be found in many of the old Bengali poems; for instance in a *pada* by Vaṁçivadana we have the following‡

* একখানি কাছিয়া পিন্ধে, একখানি মাথায় বান্ধে,
আর একখানি দিল সব্ব গায়।
Vijay Gupta.

† রাজ্ঞী ও রাজবধূ এবং রাজকন্যারা কার্পাস বা কৌশেয় সাটী পরিতেন। কিন্তু প্রায় সমস্ত শুভ কর্ম্মোপলক্ষে পশ্চিমোত্তর দেশীয় সম্ভ্রান্ত মহিলাগণের ন্যায় কাঁচুলি, ঘাঘরা ও ওড়না পরিতেন। p. 35.

‡ "নীল ওড়ণার মাঝে মুখ শোভা করে।
পাইলে ছাড়িবে নাহি দারুণ ভ্রমরে॥"

"Through a blue Oḍnā appeared her beautiful fair face; what if a bee mistakes it for a lotus and stings?" A Nivivandha or girdle is also described in many of our old poems as worn by women.

It was the fashion with the Bengalis of the higher classes to wear their hair long and in plaits. We find in Chandi Dās, Rādhā's maidens humorously asking Kriṣṇa why his braided hair hangs loosely down his back. We have many accounts of how Chaitanya Deva's long hair was perfumed and washed with Āmlaki (myrobolan) and how it was cut off by a barber named Devā (according to some Madhu) on the eve of his taking the vow of asceticism. In Vijay Gupta's Padmāpurāṇa we find the following lines:—

"*Beautiful Lakṣmindra's long and flowing hair hung loose as his kinsmen carried him to the bank of the river Gāngura."

In Krithivāsa's Rāmāyaṇa we find "the soldiers of Rāma fled precipitously, havig no time even to tie their long hair into knots."† The Bengalis up to the 16th century wore their hair long as the Madrasis and the Uriyas do now. They scented it with perfumes and plaited it like the women. In the 17th century they imitated the fashion of the Moslem gentry—who allowed their hair to grow

*"পরম সুন্দর লখাই দীর্ঘ মাথার চুল।
জ্ঞাতিগণ ধরে নিল গাঙ্গুরের কুল॥
Vijāy Gupta.

† "পলায় রামের সৈন্য নাহি বাঁধে চুল।"
Krittivās.

till it touched the shoulders in curls. This is called the Bābri—a fashion to which the Hindus stuck even till the middle of the 19th century.

The Bābri.

Kusumbhā.

The poet Bhārat Chandra of a subsequent age describes 'Kusumbhā' as a favourite food with Çiva. Present Bengali readers have no idea of what this word implies. In several editions of Bhārat Chandra, the annotators observe silence as regards the passage, but in Rājputanā, 'Kusumbhā' is an article of luxury even now. It is a preparation of opium and milk which the Rājputs take on festive occasions.

Thus a study of our old literature brings to our knowledge various points of community in language, habits, and modes of living amongst those different branches that all came from one common stock and settled in different parts of the country. This affinity can also be accounted for by the fact that politically the five provinces to which a reference has been made, often remained under the same suzerain power. The title 'Pancha Gauḍeçvara' or the 'Lord of five Indies' was assumed by the King who for the time being became ascendant among the five powers.

The five Gauḍas often under one Suzerain power.

Pancha-Gauḍeçwar

In old Bengali literature we frequently come across the title Pancha Gauḍeçvara applied to petty chiefs by their protégés—the poets, but the word always recalls the high political significance it once possessed. It is a title akin to the Bretwalda of the Saxons.

The dialect of Eastern and Western Bengal.

The literature of Western Bengal had many words which have passed out of the current dialect of that province but the use of them still lingers in

Eastern Bengal. The words করিমু, খাইমু, করিবাম, খাম, দিবাম, etc., occur in Chaitanya-Bhāgavata and in the Manasā Maṅgalas written three to four hundred years ago by authors who were born in Birbhum and contiguous districts. And curiously enough the people of these districts now ridicule the people of Eastern Bengal for continuing to use the same words. Instances of করোসি, করেন্ত, বোলেন্ত, etc., abound in the early literature of Eastern Bengal and that of the west also is not wholly free from such uses. In Çrikriṣṇa Vijaya by Mālādhara Vasu, Dāker Vachana and other works of West Bengal, many examples of পিবন্তি, যান্তি, খায়োমি, পুজসি, etc., are found. In Eastern Bengal we find the termination 'ও' affixed to a number of words after the manner of Prākrita, such as মাও for মা, পাও for পা, ঘাও for ঘা, নাও for না, রাও for রা, গাঁও for গাঁ, ছাও for ছা, দাও for দা, ভাও for ভাব, বাও for বা, তাও for তা. Occcasionally they are met with in the earlier literature of Western Bengal also, as in Dāker-vachan "রূপার দোলায় ফেলাম পাও."

Queer names of the Prakrita age.

Choice Sanskritic names.

The men and women in the Buddhistic age had curious names, not at all pleasing to the ears, such as অদুনা, পদুনা, নেঙ্গা, খেতুরি, ময়নামতী, হিঙ্গু, দুহি, দুই, রুই, কুই, আই, লহনা, খুল্লনা, সায় নেড়া, সমাই, মাহুদ্যা, লোহাটা, &c. But with the advent of the Sanskritic age, choice classical names began to be preferred. In Vijay Gupta's Padmāpurāṇa along with names which remind us of the Buddhistic period, Sanskrit names are found in large numbers; such for instance, as চন্দ্রপ্রভা lustre of the moon, অনুপমা the peerless, চন্দ্ররেখা moon-beam, মালতি jasmine, শশী the moon, সুবর্ণ রেখা gold-lining, রঙ্গিণী the playful, সরলা the sincere one, রূপমঞ্জুরী beautiful bud, মদনমঞ্জুরী

flower-sceptre of cupid, জয়-মালা garland of victory, বিমলা the pure. By far the greater number of names are found to follow those of the Hindu gods and goddesses.

Non-Sanskritic names.

We quote a passage from the same work to illustrate with one or two exceptions, its uniform use of non-Sanskritic names.

"There came a maid whose name was Rādhā; her henpecked lord, she led home like a tame ass; another maiden came of the name of Rui whose bald head was redeemed only by a tuft of hair in the middle; another whose name was Saru, her braided locks were eaten up by a cow, as she had gone to the cow-shed for lighting the fire; another maid came of the name of Kui, in the hollows of whose cheeks some two maunds of broken rice could be stored; another maid appeared called Āi whose cheeks were high, but the nose sunk deep between them, so that it could be scarcely seen; yet another maid of the name of Suā, so tall that her head touched the top of the door as she came out."*

*"একজন এয়ো আইল তার নাম রাধা।
ঘরে আছে স্বামী তার যেন পোষা গাধা॥
আর এক এয়ো আইল তার নাম রুই।
মস্তকে আছয়ে তার চুল গাছ দুই॥
আর এক এয়ো আইল তার নাম সরু।
গোয়াল ঘরে ধোঁয়া দিতে খোপা খাইল গরু॥
আর এক এয়ো আইল তার নাম কুই।
দুই গালে ধরে তার ক্ষুদ মণ দুই॥
আর এক এয়ো আইল তার নাম আই।
দুই গাল চওড়া চওড়া নাকের উদ্দেশ নাই॥
আর এক এয়ো আইল তার নাম চুয়া।
ঘর হৈতে বাহিরিতে শিরে ধরে টুয়া॥ Vijay Gupta.

A list of words.

We give below a list of obsolete words occurring in works treated of in this chapter with their meaning.

In Vijay Gupta's Padmā Purāṅa :—আসোয়াস্ত—indisposed, আগল—skilled, forward, সাসিয়াল—powerful, চোপা—face, উদাসিণী—friendless, নবগুণ—sacred thread, সম্বিধান—act of attending, খিটে—to pick up, ছামনিতে—in the front, বুড়ি—big, ধাই—mother, মাই—mother, অথান্তর—pains and hardships, মেলানি—farewell, গোহারি—humble prayer, বাহুড়িয়া—returning, পাক্না—ripe, পাঁচে—to think, আচাভুয়া—a foot, ঠান—attitude, সহিলা—maidenly friendship, ভাণ্ডালে—to deceive, পরিপাটি—skill, টনক—strong, সোসর—like, তেলেঙ্গা—stout and healthy, অবস্থা—distress, সম্ভাবনা—property, সুশ্রীত—fortunate, সানে—to make a sign, তিতা—wet (from সিক্ত, we have also got তিতিল, derived from the same word ; this should not be confounded with তিতা derived from তিক্ত—(bitter). In the Rāmāyaṅa by Krittivāsa :—সন্তোক token of favour, নিবড়ে—on the expiry of, ভোকে—in hunger, লোহ—tears, ওর—limit, রড়—run, কোঙর—son. In Mahābhārata by Saṅjay :—আম্মি—I, তুম্মি—you, মোহর—mine, সমাইরে—to all, আগুয়ান—forward, সুসারিত—best, যুয়ায়—to become fit, কেনি—why, পুনি—again, বিনি—without, খেরি—play, হনে—from, আপ্ত—own. In Kavindra Parameçvara and Çrikaraṅ Nandi's works :—সম্ভ্রম—fear, সমে—with, পাড়িমু—I shall throw, উপালেন্ত—on. In the Padmā Purāṅa by Nārāyana Dev :—খাথার—ill-fame, কথা—where. এড়িয়া—leaving. In Chandi Das's poem :—চেট্টোনেট্ট্য—young wives, টীট—a knave, উতরোল—alarmed, বড়ু—a Brāhmin student, দে—body, টাগ—thigh, আকুতে—In eagerness, লেহ—affection, ওদন—rice, পরিবাদ—blame, ফুরিছে—to

swell (from Sanskrit ফুরিছে; its present form is ফুলিছে). In Çrikrishna Vijay:—সহু—recovery, রাকড়ে—sound, আউদর—dishevelled, পোকান—a son. In various other works of this period:—তয়ু—your, থৈলা—to keep, আবর—another, আবে—now, জাঁঞ—I shall go, পুতাই—son, পোরে—son, বুড়া—old (applied to objects as বুড়া ধনু—an old bow), তেবে—then, করিলহোঁ—I did, মিলে—to be, তাইক—to him, সোমাইল—to enter, বিহদাইল—dissuaded, কাঁদিয়োক লইলা—began to cry, ছকর—a boar, নাহা—lord, সুগিঞো—Sugriva, মকমকে—loudly, পিম্পরা—ant, ভসহিল—to inform.

The word বাপু, not in the sense of a son but in that of a father or a guardian is often found in the works of Vijay Gupta and other poets. In the former poem we find the desciples of Dhanvantari addressing him as বাপু, and the goddess Padmā addressing her father Çiva by the same word. It is evident that the modern বাবু is derived from বাপু and it originally meant a father as the word বাপ does now.

The origin of Babu.

The case-endings and pronouns.

The words of which a list is given above occur in nearly all the old works comprised within this chapter. For the sake of convenience, however, I refer in most cases to particular authors from whose works I happened to note them.

The case-endings of words and forms of pronouns, the examples of which I find in the works are also included in the following list.

First person, singular, nominative আম্মি, মুই, আমি, আমিহ, মো. Second person, singular, nominative তুম্মি, তুমি, তুঁহ, তঞি. Third person nomina-

tive তিঁহ। First person, singular, nominative, accusative আম্মাতে, মোত, আম্মারে, মোহরে, মোরে. Second person, singular, nominative, accusative তোম্মারে, তোমাক, তোম্মা, তাত, তোঁহারে, তোরে. Third person singular, nominative, accusative তাক, তাতে, তায়, তাইক. First person, singular, possessive, আম্মার, আম্মা, আমার, মোহর, মোর, মোহার. Second person, singular, possessive তোম্মা, তোম্মার, তয়ু, তোহার, তোঁহার. Third person, singular, possessive তাঙ্ক, তান, তাহান.

The plural forms.

The plural forms were generally formed by adding সব, গন, and আদি, as তুম্মিসব, আম্মিসব, রাক্ষসগণ, and মৃগাদি. The verbs in the first person show such forms as দোঁহা, পঁরো, তেজিমে, নোহো, (for নহি), দেখঞ, লভিলো, বন্দম, করম, করিমু, করিমু, পাঁইলু, দিমু, করিনু. In the second person—কহোসি, দিয়োক, করিয়োক, আসিয়োক, করিহ. In the third person we have instances of হব being used for হবে (as in নিদের স্বপনে রাজা হব দরশন). There are many curious forms of verbs such as পইতায়, আইবন্ত ভৈলন্ত, করেন্ত.

Navigation for Trade.

Trade was generally carried on by a system of barter, but cowris were much used as coins, and they were counted in gandās, paṅas, and kāhaṅas. The Bengalis used to travel by sea for purposes of trade in early days, but during the period of which we are speaking, such practices fell into disuse. The sea-voyages described in old Bengali poems are monostrous fables, but they prove the existence of traditions that existed in the country, about commercial enterprises undertaken by Bengalis in the past, though couched in the forms of romances. We may, however, glean what sort of ships were made in the country from these writings. In the

pictorial illustrations of the Borra Buddar temple of Jāvā published by the Dutch Government, we find numerous pictures of ships which went to that Island from Tāmluka, Chittagong and the sea-coasts of Orissā and Guzrāt, and they represent a type on which, even yet, the modern European sailing-ships have not noticeably improved. In old Bengali literature we find that oarsmen and pilots were generally recruited from Eastern Bengal. Their peculiar accent was a subject of ridicule to poets then as now. The oarsmen were supervised by Gāvurs, who would occasionally beat them with rods called Dāngās, if found to be lagging in their work. The oarsmen used to sing a chorus as they plied their oars; such songs were called 'Sāri.' The Madhukar or the head-ship on board which a great merchant or king embarked, was adorned with many artistic designs. The prow especially was formed into various picturesque shapes; it often represented the form of a peacock. The vessels were loaded with utensils of bell-metal made in various patterns, muslin and other fine stuffs, shells and corals, and various agricultural products of Bengal. The vessels bore poetic names such as 'The Sea-foam,' 'The Royal Duck,' 'The moon light.' The descriptions of places, though mere old wives' tales entitled to little credence, have still some grains of truth in them. Of the Ceylonese, it is said that if their parents die, they keep them long without cremation. This refers to the custom of the Buddhists who sometimes allow even a whole year to pass before the corpse of a monk is cremated. In another place we find 'If they die, the son has no claim, but the

sister's son inherits the property'—a custom which is still observed in the Southern Presidency amongst the Nairs. Sea-voyages as described in the earliest Manasā Maṅgals seem to represent facts, though much distorted and exaggerated, but in later versions, we find the accounts turned into complete fiction from which it is impossible to gather any historical truth.

Old Bengali literature treated with neglect.

The works mentioned in this chapter represent only a small portion of the literature actually written in Bengal between the 13th and the 18th centuries.* As most of these are in the form of old manuscripts and as search for them has been commenced only lately, and that in a half-hearted way, by scholars who have no funds to conduct the work vigorously, by far the greater portion of this literature was lost before any attempt was made to preserve it and of existing manuscripts not a tithe could be recovered for want of funds. The enlightened section of our community who are fond of displaying their erudition in English literature, who are never weary of admiring a Cordelia, a Haidee or even a Donna Julia and who quote from the English translation of Virgil to shew their appreciation of Dido's love, would not care to read the story of Behulā—the bride of Lakṣmīndra, whose unflinching resolution and sufferings for love rise higher than many a martyrdom; or of Khullanā, the loving damsel of Ujāni, whose beauty, tender age, sufferings and fidelity all combine to make her one of the finest creations of poetic fancy; or of Ranjāvati—the wife of King

*We have not included the works by Vaisnava authors of this period in our list.

Kaṇha Sen of Maynāgar whose resignation was as great as her austerities that stripped even death at the stake of its natural horrors. The name of a Shelly, a Victor Hugo, or an Alfred de Musset evokes in the minds of enlightened Bengalis feelings of great admiration, but they do not care to know who were Chandi Dās, Mukundarām and Krittivāsa. The ears charmed by the beauty of Iambic and Trochaic measures would not stoop to favour the Payāra and the Tripadi Chhandas of the old Bengali poems. Yet it is their own literature which contains elements that they are naturally best fitted to appreciate, and their appreciation of the romantic motives of European literature is apt to be fraught with disastrous results to our society which, under its peculiar constitution, leaves no room for the betrothed pair to have the slightest share in the mutual choice.

Manuscripts lost to us.

As a natural consequence of this neglect, a large number of valuable manuscripts has been allowed to be eaten by worms or destroyed by fire, unknown and unheeded. The Battalā Printing Agencies of Calcutta, which have undertaken to minister to the literary wants of a rustic folk have preserved a considerable portion of them by printing them on paper of very inferior quality, the printer's devil having freely distorted and tampered with the readings. Yet, though meagre in number and poor in execution, the Battalā Presses have preserved what otherwise would have met with a certain destruction, and though late we have now risen to a consciousness of the gratitude which we owe to them for this invaluable service.

The laudable efforts of Battalā.

CHAPTER V.

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The Literature of the Vaiṣṅavas.

I. Vaiṣṅavism in Bengal.

II. The Life and Teachings of Chaitanya Deva.

III. Vaiṣṅava Biographies.

- **(a) Kaḍchā or Notes by Govinda Dās.**
- **(b) Chaitanya Bhāgabata by Vrindāvan Dās.**
- **(c) Chaitanya Maṇgal by Jayānanda.**
- **(d) Chaitaṅya Charitāmrita by Kriṣṅa Dās Kavirāj.**
- **(e) Chaitaṅya Maṇgal by Lochan Dās.**
- **(f) Brief accounts of Nityānanda—Advaitāchāryya—Narottam Dās—Raghunāth Dās — Rupa — Sanātaṅa — Çrinivās-Achāryya—Hari Dās and other Vaiṣṅava devotees.**
- **(g) Bhakti Ratnākar and other biographical works.**

IV. Theological books.

V. The Padas or Songs of the Vaiṣṅavas.

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I. Vaiṣṅavism in Bengal.

Chronological order not followed.

Chronologically speaking, a considerable portion of the Literature, which forms the subject-matter of this chapter, precedes works treated of in the last chapter. But as the Vaiṣṅava Literature is marked by distinct characteristics of its own and has little relation to the spirit that predominates in the rest of our Literature, we have found it convenient to group the works of Vaiṣṅava writers together and to deal with them separately in the present chapter, without observing their chronological order, in relation to non-Vaiṣṅava works.

The excellence of Vaiṣṅava Literature.

Works written by the Vaiṣṅavas form the most important and interesting portion of our literature.

They cover a varied field and contain the finest examples of poetry that are to be found in our language, and are no less important for their lofty spiritual tone inspired by the great personality of Chaitanya Deva than for the influence they have exerted on our language in all its different channels.

A contrast with the works of classical writers.

In the literature dealt with in the last chapter, we marked the hand of classical writers, who had recast the earlier recensions of rustic poems after Sanskritic models. This literature of renaissance is permeated by a taste for classical figures and classical allusions. Words were recovered from the loose Prākrita to which they had degenerated, and restored to their original Sanskrit forms. Reformed Hindus took up subjects of Buddhistic origin, cast them into the mould of their own new ideas, Hinduized their spirit and Sanskritized their language. The Vaiṣṇava Literature, however, is essentially a literature of the people. This 'people' should not be identified with those rustic folk whose language was the hated *patois* and the subjects of whose songs were fables and stories in which facts were distorted or over-coloured without any artistic sense. The people who created Vaiṣṇava Literature had warred against orthodoxy and priest-craft. They had risen out of the stupor of ignorance of ages and become conscious of a new strength. A god-man had lived in their midst and in the living example before them, they had witnessed the fulfilment of the spiritual ideal of their country, greater than what scholars could teach or poets represent with all the inspiration of their language. The freedom and latitude of their literary attempts

startle us by their boldness, as they attract us by their novelty.

A spirit of revolt against orthodoxy.

Bengal has, as I have already said, evinced in the history of her religious progress, a spirit of constant revolt against orthodoxy. Whenever an institution, basing itself on the dogmas of monastic pedants, has shut its portals against the immutable truths of nature and tried to blindfold men by learning and logic, the heterodox elements in this country have revolted against its theology and asserted themselves to break the fetters of social autocracy by proclaiming the true relation in which man stands to God and to his fellow men. It was this spirit which had at one time, made Bengal a staunch votary of the Buddhistic creed; it was for this reason that the Jain Tirthankaras had found it a suitable soil for the promulgation of their doctrines; and last but not least the Vaiṣṇavas of Bengal shewed the strength that lay dormant in her masses, a strength which by a Herculian application of its resources upset the whole social fabric, broke through the thick walls of time-honoured institutions, and opened up a vista for the passage of heaven's light.

The development of the creed of love.

This great strength of the people had been silently gathering itself in the declining days of Buddhism, when the Vaiṣṇava creed had not yet assumed a new shape in Bengal. The Mahāyāna School of the Buddhists had branched itself in a hundred ways and the theory of the void (Çunyabād), though it occasionally led to scepticism and sophistry, counted a large number of votaries who developed a creed of devotion not unlike the Vaiṣṇava

Mahāyānism and Vaiṣṇavism.

idea of love. Some of the scholarly Mahāyānists went a step further than Nagarjuna, the great promoter of the creed and founder of the Madhyamic School, and argued like atheists. This class earned for the Buddhists, the common name of sceptics in the country. But amongst the masses Mahāyānism gave rise to the worship of a hundred deities like that of Prajnā Pāramitā, Abalokiteçwar and Munjaçri, whose images have so many points in common with those of Vasudeva and other gods and goddesses of the Hindu Pantheon.

Says Mr. Kern in his Manual of Buddhism,*—"Mahāyānism lays a great stress on devotion, in this respect as in many others, harmonising with the current of feeling in India which led to the growing influence of Bhakti. It is by that feeling of fervent devotion combined with the preaching of active compassion that the creed enlisted the sympathy of numerous millions of people." Mahāyānism in its higher theology professed doctrines not unlike those promulgated by the great Sankarācharyya. It bore a distinct affinity to Hinduism in its popular forms also. According to Kern, "Mahāyānism is much indebted to the Bhāgabata Gitā and more even to Çaivism."† The Buddhist masses had therefore developed an emotional creed which led them afterwards to accept the tenets of Vaiṣṇavism with such cordiality. The 'Nām Saṅkirtan' or the recitation of god's name which forms one of the most essential points in the Vaiṣṇava creed was also prevalent amongst these Mahāyāna Buddhists with whom the "void" was sometimes contemplated as merely a name.

* P. 124. † P. 122.

The lay Buddhist society furnishing a recruiting ground for the Vaiṣṅavas.

When Buddhism ceased to be a living force, a great number of people who had adhered to that faith lost all social prestige in the country. They became out-castes—the Hindu revivalists having refused to admit them to their society. These people readily responded to the brotherly call of the Vaiṣṅavas and gathered under the flag of Nityānanda—the great apostle of Chaitanyism in Bengal in the sixteenth century. Thus the Bāuls, the Neḍa Neḍis, the Sahajiās and the sects that afterwards went by the name of Kartā Bhajās and Kisori Bhajaks, who had originally formed the bulk of the Buddhist masses, now swelled the ranks of the lay Vaiṣṅavas. Some of these people still uphold the doctrines of the Mahāyānists though they outwardly profess Chaitanyism. The Mahimā Dharmis of Orissa have a vast literature which promulgate the doctrines of Chaitanya and Nagārjuna alike. In some works of this class such as those of the Uriyā poets Chaitanya Dās and Jagannāth Dās who flourished in the sixteenth century and are popularly known as Vaiṣṅava poets, the creed of Madhyamic Mahāyānism is elaborately explained without any excuse, and the names of Dharma (Prajnā Pāramitā), and of Buddha are of frequent occurrence in them. Indeed one poet went so far as to give an account of the five Dhyani Buddhas on the lines of the Mahāyānists, calling himself a follower of Chaitanya all the while. Some of these startling facts recently discovered by Babu Nagendranath Vasu will be found embodied in his archæological Report on Orissa which is already in the press. It will be curious to observe how Chaitanyism and Mahāyānism have

commingled amongst some of these Vaiṣṇava sects. In one instance a religious mendicant of the Vaiṣṇava sect of Bāul was asked by the writer of the present treatise if he worshipped the image of Chaitanya. He said in reply that there could be really no image of Chaitanya to be worshipped as he was merely 'the void' and existed only as a name!

Thus the scattered Mahāyānists,—who lay like a disbanded army, without any great leader to govern and control them, after Buddhism had been banished from the soil of its birth,—were now brought together and made to accept the emotional creed of love, in its fully developed form; they were thus merged in the great community of the Vaiṣṇavas. The Vaiṣṇavas, while calling all people to accept their theory of spiritual love, also beat the drum of war against caste-distinction and priest-craft; and the evolution of what remained of Buddhism in the country to the highly spiritual and emotional creed of the Vaiṣṇavas came to happen as the natural sequence of this revolution; for the Buddhist masses had already developed a creed of devotion being influenced by the spirit of the Paurānic revival all around, and Vaiṣṇavism attracted them most, as it did away with caste—now the only barrier that could prevent them from joining with the Buddhists.

The points of similarity.

What distinction is there between the Buddhist Vikṣu and the Vaiṣṇava Vairagi with his shaven head and loose over coat? When we read Yuang Chuang's travels—his description of Kuçi Nagar and Benares for instance, and read mythological accounts of Buddha's killing the demons related with

a devotional fervour, are we not reminded of stories about Viṣṇu so exactly alike, described in Vaiṣṇava books as Narottam Vilās and Bhakti Ratnākar? In the latter, the mythological deeds of Viṣṇu are found marked by temples, while in the former the scenes of Buddha's conquest of demons are said to have been marked by pillars of Açoka Rājā. The religious history prevalent in the country merely changed name when the Buddhist theology passed into Vaiṣṇavism and a careful study of the two religions will shew them often to be as similar as the image of Avalokiteçwar of the Buddhists and Vasudeva of the Hindus.

Credit due to the Vaiṣṇavas

But this detracts nothing from the praise due to the Vaiṣṇavas. They infused new life, where vitality was sinking. It is true, materials lay all around in the shape of a spirit of devotion and a desire for renunciation. But in the world materials are at no time wanting. It is only when a great power works them up to their highest capacity and leads to striking success that we have opportunities of observing that they were capable of such achievements. Buddhism and Vaiṣṇavism, besides, originally differed in their tenets, one laying stress on knowledge and the other on devotion. It was only when the higher classes of the Mahāyānists had left the country, that the Buddhist masses found it possible to accept a leader who preached the doctrine of *Bhakti* (devotion), without reserving a place for *Jnan* (knowledge) in his theology.

Fundamental difference.

The message of Eastern India to the world.

Eastern India seems to have a singular mission for the world. There is no Haldighāt, no Chillinwalā, no Kurukheṣtra, no Pānipat in this part of the country. No martial feats, no acts of extraordinary bravery or patriotism mark this blessed land: but the pre-historic temples of Benares rise aloft invoking people from the furthest provinces of India to respond to their high religious call; the Sāma-songs accompanied by the evening-bells and sung in chorus by Vedic Brāhmins in the holy city carry us to the times when the Riṣis of old, set their first great utterances on religion to sublime music. The monastery of Nālendā, once one of the greatest centres of learning in the world, opened its portals to all peoples without distinction and drew pupils from every part of the then known world. The pillar-inscriptions of Açoka proclaimed from here the great truths of universal equality, forbearance, and kindness, and shewed the solicitious care of an ideal monarch who was a father to his people—nay, was full of compassion even for the dumb animals. Here, in yet earlier times, lived Rāma in Uttara Koçola whose name as that of an incarnation of God is uttered by all Hindus in the hour of death. And it was here that the great Buddha from Kapilāvastu preached his religion which has left its stamp on the civilization of the whole world, and whose influence may be traced not only in the 'Karma-bad' on which modern Hinduism is based, but even in the Catholic Church of Christians and in the creed of the Shufis amongst Mahammadans. The Jaina Tirthankaras all attained their spiritual goal in this part of India, and the great temple of Jagannāth in Purī, and the

educational institutions of Mithilā, and Nadiā in comparatively recent times, have held up a torch which has lit up the Hindu world and led it along the path of intellectual and spiritual progress. Here in Eastern India, sang Vālmiki, that master of epics, the deep pathos of whose sublime poetry flows like the noble stream of the Tamasā itself on whose banks it was first composed. Of the Rāmāyana it has been said;—"So long as the mountains of the world endure and so long as noble rivers flow, this epic will be read."

The apostles of Bengal.

The Aryans who came to Bengal and settled here had distinctly a high religious object in view. From Çīlā Bhadra, Dīpaṅkara and Mahāvīra to Mīnanāth, Gorakṣanāth, Haḍipā, Kālupā, Chauraṅgee and even Ramāi Pandit—the apostles of Bengal all proclaimed to the people the transitoriness of this world and the glory of a religious life. I have referred to the whole of Eastern India, because Bengali civilization four hundred years ago was the result of all these influences combined. The environment of a man shapes his proclivities to a great extent and the Bengal of the 16th century was pre-eminently marked by the influences that had governed Eastern India for ages. Nadiā-Tolas, represented a revival, not indeed on such a wide scale yet in a subtler way, of the learning of the Nālanda monasteries. Buddha had taught kindness to animals and a process of introspection by which a conquest over the warring passions of the soul might be gained. Peace was proclaimed, not only with the human, but also with the animal world, and when the soil was so far pre-

Chaitanya advanced a step further.

pared by Buddhism, came Chaitanya Deva into this historic land of religion, to advance a step further and teach love to God.

Born in a pious family.

He taught it unmistakably. The family to which he belonged had for many generations past been Vaiṣṇavas—which means that they had abstained from all kinds of meat. No fish or flesh could cross the threshold of a Vaiṣṇava family. The word killing is not to be found in their vocabulary; to speak of 'cutting' even a vegetable, for food, was unholy with them. They called it রানান or dressing (lit. preparing). The older phraseology current in the country had been changed by the Vaiṣṇavas. The idea of kindness to animals had reached perfection with them and how can this be explained, except as the result of Buddhism which long predominated here? The family of Chaitanya Deva were of an unworldly character. His father Jagannāth Miçra, was very poor. His wife Çachī Devī asked him one day why he did not worship Chandī—for the avocation of such a priest would bring him more money. Jagannāth Miçra smiled and said he did not care to have it.

It was a family that cared only for the grace of God,—God who was real to the Hindus of that period, and not a mere matter of speculation as he is to so many modern Bengalis. The life of Chaitanya proves that all the tender emotions of love,—the yearnings of a mother for her child,—all that friendship of man or woman may inspire in the soul, do not represent a tithe of what a man can feel or suffer when he realises the love of God. But it requires the clear vision of one in whom

all worldly desires have been extinguished, to appreciate and realise this great love. Chaitanya Deva, became completely lost in his own devotion to God. The poetry that welled up round him from those who witnessed the superb sight of his beautiful love ecstacy, has enriched our literature beyond measure in the matchless *padas* of the Vaiṣṇava poets which will remain as an invaluable treasure to us for ages to come.

He inspired the 'padas' by his love-ecstacy.

All honour to thee, O Navadwīpa,—the glory of Bengal! The historic city is now crumbling to decay. Its splendour is now a tale of by-gone ages. But Navadwīpa will remain sacred to Hindus for ever. Its very dust proclaims a history which holds us under a spell. For ages it has held a torch that has illuminated Bengal and in the 15th century a heavenly light appeared on its horizon which, moon-like, developed into a glorious luminary; verily was Chaitanya Deva 'Navadwīpa-Chandra' or the moon of Navadwīpa, as he is popularly called.

Navadwīpa, the birth-place of Chaitanya and a seat of learning.

In speaking of the glories of Navadwīpa I am not referring to the fact that it was the last seat of the Hindu kings of Gauḍa. In later times it became a far-famed seat of learning. Its great school of Logic, founded by Vasu Deva Sarvabhauma, and brought to perfection by Raghunāth Çiramaṇi, drew pupils from all parts of India. The new system of Logic called Navya Nyāya which supplemented the old system of Gautāma, indicates

Navya Nyāya.

the keenness of the Bengali intellect. The subtlety with which the Navya Nyaya has been worked out, gives it a unique character and in the brilliant mode of its exposition, it may be considered as a land-mark of progress in human thought, and an achievement of which every Indian may be justly proud. This school of Logic at Navadwīpa drew pupils from Benares, the Panjab, Poonā and all the other recognised centres of Sanskrit learning; so that by the early 16th century the Tolas or Sanskrit schools of Navadwīpa, had become the metropolis of learning in India. Narahari Chakervarty, author of Bhaktiratnākara gives a topography of Navadwīpa of this period, from which we see that the area of the city was sixteen square miles at the time. It included within this area the following among other wards :—Ātāpur, Simuliā, Majitagrām, Vāmanpukhuriā, Hāt-danga, Rātupur, Vidyanagara, Belpukhuriā, Chāmpāhāt, Mangāchi, Rāhupur, Miñāpur, Gandhavanik Pārā, Mālākara Pārā, Çānkhāri Pārā and Tānti Pārā. Vrindāvan Dās, author of Chaitanya Bhāgbata, thus describes the flourishing condition of Navadwīpa.

The area of Navadwīpa.

Its flourishing condition.

"*It is impossible to describe the glories of Navadwīpa. Hundreds of thousands of people bathe there in the Ganges every day. Various races of people dwell in the city whose num-

* নবদ্বীপের সমৃদ্ধি কে বর্ণিবারে পারে।
এক গঙ্গাঘাটে লক্ষ লোক স্নান করে॥
ত্রিবিধ বৈসে এক জাতি লক্ষ লক্ষ।
সরস্বতী দৃষ্টিপাতে সবে মহা দক্ষ॥

bers may be counted by lacs. There are hundreds of scholars in it by the grace of Sarasvati (the goddess of learning). There are many professors who are fond of displaying their learning. Even a boy there, will challenge a veteran professor to an intellectual discussion. People from various countries flock to the Tols of Navadwīpa, and when they have finished their studies there, their education becomes complete."

Sceptical tendencies of scholars

But what was this Navya Nyaya of Bengal? Those who have read the system of Logic founded by Gautāma, know that its basis is a spiritual philosophy. But this Navya Nyaya of Bengal has nothing to do with religion. It is a secular system of purely intellectual reasoning. In the latter days of Buddhism, faith in God, as I have said, had become nearly extinct amongst some of the scholarly Mahāyānists, and the creed become almost identical with scepticism in popular estimation. Human mind in this country after long ages of scepticism and mystic Tāntrik rites,—confounded and stupefied by the supernatural feats of 'siddhas' wanted to extricate itself from the mazy ways of an old and rotten institution and panted for light and for love of God. The horrors of Tān-

Tāntrikism and worldliness.

সবে মহা অধ্যাপক করি গর্ব্ব করে।
বালকে হো ভট্টাচার্য্য সনে কক্ষা করে॥
নানা দেশ হইতে লোক নবদ্বীপে যায়।
নবদ্বীপে পড়িলে সে বিদ্যারস পায়॥

Chaitanya Bhāgabata.

trikism are thus described by Narahari Chakravarty in his Narottam Vilās :—*

"Who can count their crimes? The blood of goats and buffaloes stain each house. Many of them hold in one hand the heads of men severed from the body and in another a sword and dance in frightful ecstacy. If any body falls in their way, he is sure to meet with death at their hands. There is no way to avoid the frightful doom—not even if he be a Brahmin. All of them are addicted to meat and wine and are lost to all sense of sexual morality."

Vrindāvana Dāsa's Chaitanya Bhāgabata also shews the spirit of the times.†

"The people are wealthy by the grace of Lakṣmi (goddess of wealth). But they spend their

* "করয়ে কুক্রিয়া যত কে কহিতে পারে।
ছাগ মেষ মহিষ শোণিত ঘরে ঘরে॥
কেহ কেহ মানুষের কাটা মুণ্ড লৈয়া।
খড়্গ করে করয়ে নর্ত্তন মত্ত হৈয়া॥
সে সময়ে কেহ যদি সেই পথে যায়।
হইলেও বিপ্র তার হাত না এড়ায়॥
সভে স্ত্রী-লম্পট জাতি বিচার রহিত
মদ্য মাংস বিনে না ভুঞ্জয়ে কদাচিত॥"

Narottam Vilās.—Canto VII.

† "রমা দৃষ্টিপাতে সর্ব্ব লোক সুখে বৈসে।
ব্যর্থ কাল যায় মাত্র ব্যবহার রসে॥
ধর্ম্ম কর্ম্ম লোক সব এই মাত্র জানে।
মঙ্গল চণ্ডীর গীত করে জাগরণে॥

times in vain worldly pursuits. Their religious observances consist of singing songs in praise of Chandī sometimes for whole nights together. There are some who take pride in worshipping Manasā Devī. Immense money they spend for making images of gods. They also spend money foolishly for the marriages of their sons and daughters. Thus do they spend their lives. Even scholarly professors do not interpret the sacred books in the light of faith."

The defects of the Renaissance.

This was the state of things in which the Paurānik Renaissance took its birth, and engaged in its struggle to give to the people better ideals and a purer faith; but while the Brahmins did a truly noble work on these lines, their power gradually became oppressive. The rules of caste became more and more stringent as Kulinism was stereotyped. While better ideals in religion were upheld by the Brahmins, the gap between man and man was widened by caste-restrictions. The lower strata of society groaned under the autocracy of the higher, who shut the portals of learning against the inferior classes. They were also debarred from having any access to a higher life,

দম্ভ করি বিষহরি পূজে কোন জন।
পুত্তলি করয়ে কেহ দিয়া বহু ধন॥
ধন নষ্ট করে পুত্র কন্যার বিভায়।
এই মত জগতের ব্যর্থ কাল যায়॥
যেবা ভট্টাচার্য্য চক্রবর্ত্তী মিশ্র সব।
তাহারাও না জানয়ে গ্রন্থ অনুভব।"

From Chaitanya Bhāgabata.

and the religion of the new school, became the monopoly of the Brahmins as if it were a commodity of the market-place.

The people wanted faith and a great personality to teach it.

The human mind in Bengal, as I have already said, was ready for a great faith. The people were unconsciously waiting for a democratic movement of reaction against the school of religious monopoly. They desired to be taught that an intricate system of rigid monastic rites is not needed for the attainment of salvation. A simple life, with the name of God on the lips, holy abstinence, and a pure faith, are better than all that was ever said by school-men. To say this in a society ridden by the Brahmin as Sinduavāda—the sailor by the Old Man of the Sea—in a society where theological dogmas ruled over ignorant men with iron sway, menacing those who dared any opposition, would obviously require a unique personality. That Bengal had the strength of producing not only the great man who was needed, but also the society that could recognise and appreciate him, is fully seen in the life of Chaitanya Deva. who was born in 1486 A.D.

Such a personality came.

As the Vaiṣṇava literature to be dealt with in this chapter was inspired throughout by admiration for Chaitanya Deva. and bore the stamp of his influence in all its various departments, I shall here give an account of his life at some length.

II. The Life and Teachings of Chaitanya Deva.

Chaitanya Deva was born at Miñāpur in Navadwipa in 1486. This Miñāpur has now been trans-

formed into Māyāpur by the orthodox Vaiṣṅavas who can not bring themselves to call Chaitanya Deva's birth place by a Mahammadan name. It was in the evening of the 7th day of the month of Phālgun (18th of February) when the full moon had just emerged from the shadow of an eclipse and the air was resounding with cries of 'Kriṣṇa' 'Kriṣṇa' 'O Lord' 'O Lord' as is wont of Hindus on an occasion like this, that the birth of the devotee who was to preach the Kriṣṇa-cult all his life, took place.

Birth, ancestry and family-history.

Chaitanya Deva's ancestors were inhabitants of Jājpur in Orissa who owing to the oppression of Raja Bhramarbara, had settled in the village of Dhākā-Dakṣina in Sylhet. Jagannāth Miçra the father had come to Navadwīpa to complete his education and there married Çachī Devi a daughter of Nilāmvara Chakravarty originally an inhabitant of Sylhet, who was now settled in Navadwīpa. Jagannāth Miçra and this Çachī Devi had eight daughters and two sons. The daughters all died in infancy. The elder son was Viçvarupa and the younger Viçvambhara. They called him, however, by the pet name Nimāi because he had been born in a shed under a Nimba-tree. This Nimāi afterwards became famous as Chaitanya Deva.

The eldest son Viçvarupa was about to be married when he was only sixteen. On the night previous to the date fixed for his marriage the boy whose ascetic tendencies, had been already marked, left home and took the vow of a Sannyāsin.

His parents rose in the morning with hearts full of joy at the prospect of celebrating Viçva-

rupa's marriage. But what a disappointment when they found that the bird had flown! They received information that he had turned Sannyāsin and renounced the world for ever. In what cave of the mountains, in what holy shrine or in what recess of the forests where the Indian Pine and Fir trees raise their heads to touch the skies, the young Sannyāsīn roamed for the rest of his life has remained a mystery up to now. The parents were struck dumb with sorrow, and there remained to them their Nemāi alone—the last ray of light to dispel the gloom of their house.

A mother's fears.

Jagannāth Miçra a man of strong character and of a spiritual bent of mind, bore this misfortune patiently; but Çachī Devi watched over Nemāi with an anxious mother's care, always afraid lest he also would leave home and throw her into depths of misery. At last this fear became a mania with her. "Since study makes a man realise the transitoriness of the world, let not my Nemāi be sent to school. I would much prefer that he should remain at home and be a dunce." Thus did Çachi Devi argue with her husband.

But the lad was as yet only five years old. This was the age when Hindu parents sent their boys to school. Jagannāth Miçra, however, could not do so with Nemāi owing to Çachī Devi's objections.

A wild boy.

Nemāi grew up a wild boy. He mixed with the bad boys of the village and carried on little depredations in the neighbouring houses and orchards in their company. The pious Brahmins after their bath, used to close their eyes in prayerful attitude before small figures of gods on the

banks of the Ganges. The little thief would come stealthily along, and carry away their images. Sometimes when a Brahmin's *chadar* was left on the banks while he bathed, Nimāi would take it away and conceal it under a bush for the sake of fun. The little girls that came to bathe in the Ganges were teased and subjected to his wild pranks. He would collect the thorny seeds of Okra-plants and throw them on their flowing hair. Once a little girl complained to Çachī Devī that Nimāi had threatened to marry her. The little fellow was six years old at the time. At times Nimāi would step in among unclean and refuse things which a Brāhmin would not touch. His parents would find him there, and gently admonish him for his conduct. His reply surprised them with the wisdom it disclosed. "You do not allow me to study," said he, "how I am to know what is clean or unclean. Nothing is either clean or unclean in my eyes, all things are alike to me." His words "সর্ব্বত্র আমার এক অদ্বিতীয় স্থান" are fraught with the deepest truths of Vedāntic philosophy. They strike the key-note of their speaker's subsequent work in demolishing orthodox traditions about the sacredness of particular objects. Nothing indeed could be holy or unholy in the eyes of Chaitanya, who had in subsequent years reached the stage of সাম্য দর্শন, when one looks upon all objects without prejudice for or against.

Sent to Gangā Dās's school.

But this mischief-making imp could not be tolerated any longer, inspite of his sage-like sayings, and the gentle folk of the neighbourhood went in a body to Jagannāth Miçra to complain to

him against his boy and insist on his putting him to school without delay. Gaṅgā Dās was the name of the teacher to whose care he was entrusted. Nimāi began to read in this pundit's tol. He learnt the alphabet within a short time and commenced reading Sanskrit Grammar.

"He does not leave his book for a moment," says Vrindāvan Dās, his biographer,* "while bathing or dining or going to bed, his mind wanders over the pages of his books. The rules he reads he quickly masters, and in discussions amongst students he beats every rival. He wrote a commentary on Sanskrit Grammar himself with patient application."

Yet Sanskrit Grammar was the subject least suited to a student who possessed an emotional nature like that of Nimāi. Ardent in spirit, and eccentric in temper as he was, he applied himself, with his whole soul, to whatever fell in his way, and study kept him engaged day and night in this early youth. But he was not a quiet and good-natured boy. As long as he remained engaged in his

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* "না ছাড়েন শ্রীহস্তে পুস্তক এক ক্ষণে।
কিবা স্নানে কি ভোজনে অথবা শয়নে॥
নাহিক প্রভুর আর চেষ্টা শাস্ত্র বিনে।
একবার যে সূত্র পড়িয়া প্রভু যায়॥
আর বার উলটিয়া সবারে ঠকায়।
আপনি করেন প্রভু সূত্রের টিপ্পনি॥"

Chaitanya Bhāgabata.

studies, he restrained himself. During recreation-hours, he gave free scope to his eccentricities.

Assails veteran scholars.

Murārī Gupta, an aged scholar, highly esteemed for his character and learning, and a Vaidya, or physician, by caste, was passing by, one day, when young Nimāi met and accosted him with smiling face. "Will you, sir," said he, "kindly clear up some difficulties of mine in grammar." The veteran scholar liked the child for his handsome appearance and for his talent. He proceeded to explain the passages required, but Nimāi had not approached him in the spirit of a *bona-fide* student. He wanted to puzzle the old scholar. In the discussion, that followed, Murāri was completely beaten, and young Nimāi triumphantly made some very impertinent remarks.† "You are a Vaidya. Why should you read Sanskrit Grammar at all? It is a very difficult thing to master this science. It is not like books that teach how to prescribe medicine for cough, biles and indigestion."

Not only in Sanskrit Grammar but in Logic too he shewed particular proficiency. Gadādhara, a great scholar in Logic, was once challenged by him to a free discussion on several knotty problems in that Science, and had to admit that he was no match for Nimāi.

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† "প্রভু কহে বৈদ্য তুমি ইহা কেন পড়।
লতা পাতা লৈয়া গিয়া রোগ দৃঢ় কর॥
ব্যাকরণ শাস্ত্র এই বিষম অবধি।
কফ, পিত্ত, অজীর্ণ, ব্যবস্থা নাহি ইথি।"

Chaitanya Bhāgabata.

Ridicules East Bengalmen.

The people of Navadwīpa loved the young scholar. He was so handsome, so brilliant, and so affectionate of disposition, yet withal so wild. The people of Western Bengal have always felt a delight in ridiculing the peculiar accents of the men of Eastern Bengal. Among the youths of Navadwīpa, Chaitanya Deva was the foremost in ridiculing these people for this defect. The people of Sylhet were specially marked out by Nimāi for his jokes. He teased them till they became enraged. One of them with angry looks asked him,—"You sir, can you say to which country you belong? Is it not a fact that your father and mother were born in Sylhet?"—This was quite true, for his parents had come from Sylhet, a remote place in Eastern Bengal, and settled at Navadwīpa. But fair argument was not the object of Nimāi bent on provoking them to anger; and angry they became till one pursued him with a club, and another went to the Kaji to lodge a complaint against him.

Sets up a Tol.

Nimāi set up a Tol or Sanskrit School himself at the age of twenty. His reputation as a scholar was already well-established and pupils flocked from all quarters to receive instruction from him. His mode of teaching and his treatment of scholars soon made him very popular amongst them.

Keçava Kāçmiri visits Navadwīpa.

About this time, there came to Navadwīpa, a renowned scholar named Keçava Kāçmiri. In the middle ages when learning was the chief object of admiration with the middle classes, and hundreds of scholars were taught in various centres of Sanskrit learning all over India, any one who acquired special proficiency in a particular subject

made it the mission of his life to travel to the various seats of learning, challenging scholars to free controversy. If he could win his laurels in this competition, he naturally enjoyed great esteem in the country and the scholars who were vanquished acknowledged the fact of their defeat in an open letter presented to him. This letter was called 'জয়-পত্র' or letter of victory.

Keçava Kāçmīrī after having vanquished the scholars of the rest of India had come to Navadwīpa, then the most important seat of Sanskrit learning in the country. There were veteran scholars at Navadwīpa about this time; old Vāsudeva Sarvabhauma, the first authority in Logic in India; Raghu Nandan Bhattāchāryya whose jurisprudence up till now governs Hindu society in Bengal; and Raghu Nath Çiromaṇī whose grand work, Chintāmani Didhiti, a commentary on the Tattva Chintāmoni by Gangeç Upādhāya is a monument of scholarship, and excelled the treatise it commented on, were all living. These were the intellectual giants of their period. But they were scholarly recluses who for many years had scarcely mixed with men. The people of Navadwīpa, however, were proud of the scholarship of young Nimāi, who was always eager to enter into controversy with others. They brought the veteran Keçava to Nimāi who received him cordially on the bank of the Ganges, where his Tola was situated.

Nimāi asked Keçava Kāçmiri, himself, a reputed poet, to describe the Ganges as it flowed past in an *extempore* poem. A few moments passed, and like a noble stream, rich and rhythmical flow of

verses fell from the lips of the old scholar to the wonder of the pupils of the Tol, and he surprised the audience by the brilliance of his metaphors and the sublimity and beauty of his ideas. Nimāi noted the poem in his memory. His assailant, after delivering it, looked round in haughty pride, and said to Nimāi, "You have learned Grammar only, I hear, and have no knowledge of Rhetoric. It is not in your power to appreciate or judge of the beauty of my poem."

Nimāi defeats him.

Nimāi however shewed no want of patience, nor displayed any sign of being disturbed by the remark. He praised the poetry but gently pointed out that there were some serious errors of Rhetoric in it. In the first line he had used the word ভবাণী-ভর্ত্তৃ signifying Çiva while the word really meant Lord of the wife of Çiva. This fallacy was called বিরুদ্ধ মতি. In the word বিভবতি in the next line there was the fallacy of ক্রমভঙ্গ, in the word শ্রীলক্ষ্মী the fallacy of পুনরুক্ত বদাভাস. Thus he pointed out fallacies too numerous to be mentioned and as he went on, the natural brilliance of his speech and the light that emanated from his eyes shewed that he was endowed with special gifts of genius. The veteran scholar was dumb-struck and retired with a broken heart. Thus the glory of Navadwīpa was saved. All felt that day that young Nimāi was an extraordinary man, and the reputation of his Tol spread far and wide.

Outwardly scoffer of religion.

But he always scoffed at religion. Old saint-like men, who delighted in him for his wonderful gifts and could not help loving him for his pleasing disposition, were pained to find that he was a

godless young man, sceptical in his views and conduct. Içvara Puri, a learned saint,—a very old and highly esteemed man of Kumārhatta,—frequently called on him and advised him on religious matters, explaining and illustrating how faith could be obtained—faith that cleanses the soul and lifts man to the rank of the gods. He quoted chapter and verse from various works to prove what he argued. But Nimāi would suddenly interrupt him, finding a grammatical flaw in his quotations and stop him by some such remarks as "Surely, sir, the verb that you use is not of the Āttanīpadī class!" The saint was much saddened by the failure of his attempts to reform the young sceptic. But the eccentricities of Nimāi had a limit when he grew into manhood; he stoically avoided any contact with women.

The inward faith.

Though he outwardly feigned scepticism, a deep religious faith was in fact ingrained in his nature. Çrīdhara and Gadādhara, two respectable Brāhmins were known for the piety of their characters. He ridiculed them frequently, but if a single day passed without his meeting them, his whole soul yearned for their company, and he felt that to him the oft-ridiculed Içvara Puri was as a god. His mind was as clear as the autumnal sky, and his temperament like the tender sweet-scented Çephālika flower that diffuses its fragrance in the morning air. It silently attracted all who came in contact with him by its inherent love; his ardent nature, which would not brook any restraint and seemed so often to run wild, had in it a secret spring of magnetism which facinated, even while it startled. It flowed like a noble fountain pleasing all by its playfulness,—a

and an ardent nature.

little dashing and abrupt in its course, yet nevertheless lovely and joyous, it indicated the presence of elements in his character which were destined to leap over the walls of orthodoxy and carry the world with him, by the innate force of pure and lofty natural instincts.

Father's death.

In the meantime Jagannāth Miçra had died and Nimāi had married. His wife was Lakṣmī Devī who had herself elected Nimai as her lord expressing a wish to her mother to marry the young scholar.

Marriage.

Nimāi was now settled in life. His homestead consisted of five large and beautiful houses on the banks of the Ganges. He lived a simple life devoted to his studies. The death of his father weighed on him and he contemplated a journey with a view to restoring his peace of mind. He accordingly visited Eastern Bengal making a tour through the several centres of Sanskrit learning that then existed in that part of the province. His commentaries on grammar were taught in the tols there and his name was widely known. He met with a cordial reception everywhere, and is said to have stayed at Kotālipārā in the District of Faridpur for sometime. Having received honours and rewards from his admirers, he set out again for Navadwīpa after a few months. Returning home, he caught sight of Navadwīpa, in the distance girdled by the Ganges, with its temples rising above the tops of the green trees. The place had a peculiar attraction for him, and he hastened to meet his mother and wife. His friends Çridhara and Gadādhara met him half way, with open arms, and in his height of joy he mimicked the accents of the East Bengal

Tour in Eastern Bengal.

Return.

people and the ring of his merry laughter resounded once more through the air as he came near his home. His companions left him and he went to his home in haste and threw himself at the feet of his mother, who began to weep as she saw her dear son come back.

The death of his wife.

Her tears were inexplicable to him, for he had expected glad looks and blessings from his mother on his return home. He, soon, however, discovered with sorrow that his wife Laksmī Devī had died of snake-bite. The merry and joyous young scholar collected himself in a moment and betraying no outward signs of grief, sweetly discoursed on the inevitableness of the course of nature, and tried to console his mother. A month or two passed, but the poor woman was always sorrowful; she insisted on his marrying again and Nimāi to please his mother married Viṣṇupriyā, daughter of Sanātan, a famous scholar of Nadiā.

Takes a second wife.

He was only twenty-one at the time. His mother seemed to be once more happy, but there came a change over the spirit of her son. A deep feeling seemed to weigh upon his soul and his mirth was gone; he shewed signs of a deeper nature growing in him. He asked his mother's permission to go to Gayā to offer Pinda or offerings of food and water at the feet of Viṣṇu there, by which the spirit of a deceased person is freed from sins and his passage to heaven is insured. When Nimāi wanted permission to go to Gayā to offer Pinda for the spirit of his father, Çachī Devi could not withhold it though she longed to keep her son at her side, ministering to her own comfort, old and feeble as she now was.

A deeper nature growing in him.

Starts for Gayā.

Nimāi started for Gayā ; his companions were gay, but he was sad. An emotion passed over him which brought tears to his eyes and he yearned for better company. Near Kumār Hatta he halted, and wanted to have a sight of Içvara Purī, the saint whom he had so often ridiculed. As he came to Kumār Hatta, he said, "It is heaven to me—this native land of Içvara Puri." The saint was dining when Nimāi arrived at his place. He partook of the food which the veteran Vaiṣṇava was taking and wept for joy ; he said, "Dearer than my own soul,—than anything that I possess, than my life itself, you are to me, O venerable sir, for you are a true servant of God." As he said this, tears began to flow from both his eyes, and he clasped the feet of Içvara Purī. The old man appeared as a god to him and he said again and again, "Blessed am I that I have seen such a holy man." Indeed Içvara Purī's devotion to God was such that he was admittedly the head of the Vaiṣṇava community at that time.

Meets Içvara Puri.

Nimāi set out for Gayā ; his life, his conversation and ways became altogether changed. He would speak but few words, and left Kumār Hatta as in a trance. While leaving, he took a handful of dust from the place and tied it in a corner of his cloth and said, "This is the dust of the place where Içvara Purī was born. It is sacred,—it is dearer to me than all that I have, nay than life itself." He stood there absorbed in a reverie and seemed to see nothing around.

Indeed a higher life was calling him. The portals of heaven seemed to open before him. His companions thought that there was something

wrong with his head; they tried to divert his mind to worldly matters by merry conversation; for a time he joined them and was even jovial and gay.

Arrives at Gayā.

They came to Gayā, and the great temple came in view with its crowd of pilgrims that flocked and pressed one another. At the sight of the temple he again grew pensive. This was the temple of Viṣṇu, the great God of the Hindu Trinity. Viṣṇu, while conquering the demon Gayāsura, had placed his feet on the demon's head and this foot-print was changed to stone. Nimāi stood with offerings before the lotus feet, 'পাদপদ্ম' as they were called. The Pāndās sang in sanskrit—"These feet, O Pilgrims, lead to heaven,—take ye refuge in them! These feet were adored by Vālī, the King who went into the nether worlds; from these feet flows the sacred stream of the Ganges. The great yogis in their mystic vision desire to catch a glimpse of these feet; their glory is sung by the God Çiva and rendered into divine music by the sage Nārada. They lead to Heaven, these feet of God;—there is no other way for man's salvation."

The feet of Viṣṇu.

Nimāi appeared to be listening, but in fact he heard nothing of the song. He added the tribute of tears to those of constant shower of flowers that were offered at the lotus-feet by the pilgrims, and fell straightway into a trance. His companions attended him carefully and he was soon restored to consciousness. When he came back to his senses, tears were still flowing down his cheeks and he wept and said, "Leave me, my friends, leave me, I am no longer fit for the world. Let me go to the Vrindā groves to find out Kriṣṇa, my Lord and the Lord of the Universe."

Falls into a trance.

Nimāi was brought home by his companions more or less unconscious. "Where, O, where is my God?" he cried with tears flowing night and day. When he came home they found him a changed man. "I have seen a wonderful spectacle at Gayā; and I shall relate it to you,"—he said to Gadādhara and Çrīdhara. But while attempting to tell of it, his voice became choked with emotion and he fell senseless into the arms of his friends. It was of the God-vision that he wanted to speak, but he could not, being overpowered by his feelings.

The God-vision.

Poor Çachī Devī, what was she to do with a son in such a condition! Physicians were called in, but Nimāi told them that he had no malady to be cured by medicines. The Highest had appeared to him and he could think of nothing else. Strange it was, he said, that living in His kingdom they did not feel His presence and His great love, and again tears fell from his eyes and over-powered him.

The pupils of his Tol flocked round their beloved teacher, but he told them that he could not teach them anything of earth. He spoke of God's love and wept. His mother Çachi Devi sent Viṣṇupriya the youthful wife, to him, thinking that a sight of her would divert his mind, but Nimāi did not even look at her. "Where is my Lord, my Kriṣṇa!"—he cried, and read verses from sacred books and wept.

But this over-flow of feeling was not all;—he went to the banks of the Ganges; the scene of his juvinile freaks, now witnessed acts which shewed him to be completely changed. He would carry the burdens of old and sickly people for them.

Serves people.

sometimes he would wash the clothes of others and perform acts of menial service, which as a Brāhmin he should not have done; and if people objected to being served by him, he would say "forbear, Friends! Do not, I beg of you, prevent me! While I serve you, I see God. These little acts are holy to me."

The effect of his faith and preachings.

Sometimes he would chant the name of God for hours together, and as he sang, his eyes would become full of tears. The whole day long he would recite and sing the name of Kriṣṇa in profound devotion, till the people of Navadwīpa could no longer resist his influence. When he spoke of God and his relation to man, they thronged in thousands to hear him. He preached, for instance of love. "What", he said, "is love? Is it that attraction by which man and woman are drawn to one another? I say it is not so. Only when in your eyes man and woman appear the same and sex loses all it charms, only then can true love come"—and again, "Be like a tree. The tree gives shade even to him who cuts its boughs. It asks no water of any one, though it be withering away for want of it. Rain and storm and the burning rays of the sun it suffers, but gives sweet-scented flowers and delicious fruits to others. Patiently serve others even as a tree and let this be your motto." The words that fell from his lips appeared inspired; they went to the hearts of the men and women who thronged to hear him. But he invariably finished speaking, chanting the name of Kriṣṇa,—the music of which with its deep pathos made all weep for the love of God. Multitudes were attracted

from all quarters: for the news spread on all hands that a God-man had come into their midst. By this time the sage Nityānanda, who was then a young man, had come and joined Nimāi. They became the centre of a circle of men who lived holy lives, did act of charity, and recited and chanted the name of God, night and day, till songs of great poetic beauty were composed. Their music, consisted of songs accompanied by the Khol, Karatāl and Rāmçingā, and for whole nights the music would go on, with Nimāi in the centre of the party, sometimes in a state of unconsciousness, and at others, singing enthusiastically with the rest, while his face beamed with a strange God-vision.

The breaking of caste and opposition of the Bhattāchāryyas.

The Bhattāchāryyas, the great scholars of Navadwipa, opposed this movement. Nimāi had broken the trammels of caste. He boldly declared, "Though one is a Chandāl (Pariā) he is superior to all Brāhmins, if he is pious and has love for God." If any one says, "Thou O Krishṇa art my life," he will embrace him, no matter to what caste he may belong. Nothing indeed was holy or unholy in his eyes—even as he had said in his boyhood. "If any one takes food," he said, "from the same plate with a Domā (sweeper), he becomes preeminently entitled by that act of mercy for obtaining the favour of god. If a Muchi (cobbler) prays to God with true devotion, a hundred times do I offer salutes at his feet."* In a society where the Brāhmin was held as a God, and a Doma as worse than a dog, these sayings from the lips of a Brāhmin sounded strangely bold. The company of men, drawn

* For authorities in regard to the above quotations, see my Banga-Bhāsā-o-Sāhitya, pp. 284—89.

together by his teachings and by his wonderful devotion, consisted of people from all ranks of society. They mixed freely and distinction of caste was no barrier to them. The Bhattāchāryyas who represented the orthodox community harassed him by all means that lay in their power. "Look at these men", they said, "we cannot sleep at night for their screamings. This uproar that they create is certainly no prayer to God." They applied to the Kāzi (Mahammadan Magistrate) to issue a rule prohibiting the march of the Saṅkīrtana-Party, as his procession was called, through the town. The Kazi did so. That day in the evening Nimāi with his followers, who now numbered hundreds of men, made a grand procession and led it to the very door of the Kāzi, who though at first very much enraged at this breach of orders, yet felt a desire to see the procession. When he came down, a strange spectacle met his eyes. Hundreds of men with flags and musical instruments were chanting the name of God in chorus, and in the midst of them, like a vision of heaven, young and beautifull Nimāi stood God-like,—his face beaming with superhuman light and eyes like two stars, floating in a fountain of tears. He heeded not any earthly obstruction and was evidently lifted into divine ecstacy. The Kazi said, he was delighted to see the procession.

Kazi beholds a strange sight.

Two great rogues of the Brāhmin caste—Jagāi and Mādhāi, who belonged to the Police staff of the Kāzi, dead-drunk with wine and accustomed to all manner of vice, resolved to assult Nimāi and Nityānanda and once as the two leaders were passing along the streets, Jagāi threw a brick at

Jagāi and Mādhāi.

Nityānanda who was hurt on the fore-head which bled profusely. But Nityānanda sang the name of God and only said to his assailant "Strike me again if you like, but sing the name of Krishṇa." His face became so full of tenderness that the rogues repented, and became reformed from that hour. So great was the attraction of the personality of Nimāi that sometimes for a whole night the Saṅkirtana party sang round him without minding the passing of the night and when it came to an end, they would wonderingly look at the sun thinking that he had appeared too soon.

Nimāi resolves to turn a Sanyāsīn

But Nimāi felt that there was a strong party in Navadwipa who were not slow to calumnite him everywhere. He thought that as a householder, his teachings might not commend themselves to all classes and therefore determined to renounce the world, turn a Sanyāsīn and preach the Love of God all over India. This news came as a disaster to his followers, amongst whom were the veteran scholar Murāri Gupta, the young and gifted Gadhādar Dās, the poet Narahari Dās of Çrikhanda, the singer and poet Vāsu Ghose with Nityānanda and the venerable Adaitacāryya of Çāntipur at their head.

And becomes one

But the word had passed his lips, and all who knew his character felt that he was inexorable. He left Navādwip in the month of March in 1509 A.D. and passed through the usual ceremonies required for the Sanyāsī'ns vow. The Guru or the religious preceptor elected by him for the occasion was Bhāratī of Kātwā. Nimāi thus cut off all the ties of world, threw away his sacred thread and shaved his head. He was given the name of

Kriṣṇā Chaitanyā as a Sanyāsin and has ever since been called Chaitanya or Chaitanya Deva. He went to Orissa, where he met Vāsu Deva Sarbabhauma, the greatest Indian scholar of the period. Vāsu Deva was already advanced in years. He took Chaitanya to task for turning a Sānyāsīn when only a young man, as he had no right to do. Chaitanya said in reply "O my venerable sir, do not call me by such a high epithet as that of a Sanyāsin. The Love of God has driven me mad and I have thrown away my sacred thread and shaved my head for this. Bless me sir that my mind may be ever devoted to him." Vāsu Deva was explaining the Gītā, but Chaitanya interpreted it in a new light. The veteran scholar was struck by the new ideas, by the flow of sentiment and by the remarkable intellect of the young Sanyāsīn. When after three continuous nights Chaitanya had finished his exposition, Vāsu Deva felt that he was in the presence of a superhuman man, endowed with poetical and spiritual gift, the like of which he had never before seen. From that time he became a humble disciple of Chaitanya Deva. Pratāpa Rudra the King of Orissa, who was dreaded by the Pāṭhāns and was known as a powerful prince of India at the time, became his next disciple, and his prime minister Rāma Rāy, deeply versed in Sanskrit lore and an eminent poet avowed his faith in Chaitanya Deva and was so much devoted to him that he constantly sought the company of the great master in subsequent times.

To Orissā

From Orissa with the blacksmith Govinda as his single companion, though hundreds had wanted to follow him, the young Sanyāsīn started for and travelled over the whole of southern India.

Travels over the Southern India.

He left Navadwīpa in 1509; from there he came to Katwā in Burdwan. He crossed the Dāmodara and stayed in the house of one Kāçi Miçra for a day; from there he went to Hāzipur and thence to Midnāpur where Keçava Sāmanta, a rich man, scolded him for taking the vow of a Sanyāsin when he was so young; from Midnāpur he went to Nārāyangaḍ and thence to Vateçvaram; he crossed the Sūvarna Rekhā and reached Hariharpur and next moved to Nilgaḍa; crossing the Vāitarāni he visited the temples of Gopināth, Sakṣigopāl and Nimrāja on the banks of the Mahānadi; he next came to Athāranālā whence he saw the flag of the Jagannāth temple and was lifted into an ecstacy. He stayed at Purī for three months.

His tour.

In April, (7th Vaiçak) 1510, he started again with his one follower Govinda for southern India. He came to the Godāvarī and met Rāma Rāy; thence he proceeded to Trimanda (modern Trimalgaḍa in Hydrabad) and converted Dhundi Rāma Tirtha to his faith; from Trimanda he came to Sidhavateçvara (modern Sidhavateçvaram; between Cadappa and the river Punna) where a rich young man named Tirtharām came to tempt him in a vulgar manner, and himself became a convert to his faith. He then crossed a forest extending over twenty miles called Munnā (on the river Munnā in the Madras Presidency); from Munnā he moved to Venkata (a city near Tripadī in the Madras Presidency); he next visited a forest known as the 'Vagulā woods' and converted Pāntha Bhil a notorious robber; there he passed three days and nights without food chanting the name of God. Thence he moved to Giriçvara and to Tripadi Nagara (about

forty miles to the North-west of Madras) he next visited the temple of Pānnā Narasiṁha, and arrived at Viṣṇu Kanchi (modern Kanjivaram). From there he visited two shrines Kalātirtha and Sandhi Tirtha; then he passed on to Chāipalli (modern Trichina Palli); he next went to Nāgar (about 145 miles to the east of Trichina Palli and situated on the sea-coast). From Nāgar he went to Tānjore (about 14 miles to the south of Nāgar); he crossed the mount Chandhālu there and passed on to Padmakota (about 25 miles to the south of Tānjore) and thence to Tripātra (about twenty-five miles to the south); there he crossed a forest extending over 300 miles, in 15 days; he next came to Ranga Dhāma (Sri Raṁgam) and visited the temple of Nrisiṁha; from there he went to Rāmanāth and thence to Rāmeçvar; he next travelled through a forest called Madhikavana and crossing the river Tāmraparni reached Kanyā Kumāri on the sea-coast; from there he proceeded to Trivaṅkoo (moden Trivancore). This place is described as being surrounded by hills. The King Rudrapati who reigned there at the time received Chaitanya Deva cordially; from Trivancore he proceeded to Poyaṣṇī (modern Pānāni) and thence to Matsatīrtha and Kāchār, crossed the rivers Bhadrā and Nāga-Panchapadi and came to Chitole (modern Chital Durgh, (on the northern boundary of Mysore); from Chital to Chandipur and thence to Gurjari (near Hydrabād) and thence to Pūrna (modern Poonā); from Pūrna he moved to Pāttana and thence to Jājuri. Here he preached God's love to the unfortunate women—the Murāries. From Jājuri he went to the woods called Chorānandivan where he met a famous bandit named Nāroji who became a

convert and followed him. He crossed the river Mulā and reached Nāsika; thence to Trimvak and Daman; he crossed the Tāpti and reached Varoch (modern Broāch); from Varoch he came to Varadā where Nāroji died; He visited Āhāmmādābād and crossed the river Çuvramati; he met two of his Bengali countrymen Govinda Charan and Rāmānanda, from Kulinagram; he went to Ghogā where a prostitute named Vāramukhi, beautiful and wealthy, became a convert, cut off her hair and took the vow of a nun. He next visited Somnāth in November 1510, reached Dwarakā from where he marched to Dohadanagar and thence to Amjhorā, Kooksi, Mandura, Deoghar. Thence he proceeded to Chandipur, from where he went to Roypur, Vidyānagar and Ratnapur; from the last place he crossed the Mahānadi and reached Çvarṅagaḍ, thence to Sambalpur, Dāspāl and to Allālnāth; he reached Puri on the 3rd of Māgh, (January, 1511). Thus his travelling on foot from Puri and back took one year eight months and twenty six days, and he travelled nearly 4000 miles within this time. During his travels he spent many days without any food. Whatever alms were brought to him by Govinda he would partake of only in very small quantities. Like a mad man his body lay covered with dust; he chanted the name of Kriṣṇa with tears in his eyes as he moved from place to place. Some of the scholars at Tungabhadra, Chandipur and at other places challenged him to a discussion on religious topics. He would not, however, enter into any controversy with them. He said that he was an illiterate man. He was ready to write out-letters of victory in favour of his assailants. But

Comes back to Puri in Feb. 1511.

His work in Southern India

when he was dragged into a discussion, inspite of himself, he would deal wonderfully with the questions at issue, and none was a match for him. He concluded his discussion always with that display of emotion and trust in God which gave him the look of a heavenly being ;—his eyes swam with tears, as he sang the name of Krishna in deep musical tones, which sounded, say those who heard him, like temple bells. Here is a description given of him by his servant Govinda."—

* "His influence over people was wonderful, he could move them as he liked, by his preachings. Sometimes he would speak in the Tamil language, (which he had acquired during his travels), at others in pure Sanskrit."

At Gurjari after explaining to the people their duty to men and their relation to God.—

† "He cried aloud 'O God ! O my Krishna'! and the place seemed to turn into heaven, a pleasant breeze

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* আশ্চর্য্য প্রভাব মূর্ত্তি কভু দেখি নাই।
কখন তামিল বুলি বলে গোরা রায়।
কখন সংস্কৃত বলি শ্রোতারে বুঝায়॥
Kadcha by Govinda Dās.

† এত বলি কৃষ্ণ হে বলিয়া ডাক দিল।
সে স্থান অমনই যেন বৈকুণ্ঠ হইল॥
অনুকুল বায়ু তবে বহিতে লাগিল।
দলে দলে গ্রাম্য লোক আসি দেখা দিল॥
ছুটিল পদ্মের গন্ধ বিমোহিত করি।
অজ্ঞান হইয়া নাম করে গৌর হরি॥

blew and the villagers came in groups till a crowd was formed. The fragrance of the lotus emanated from his person and charmed every one. Chaitanya lost consciousness of the world and chanted 'O Krisṇa, O my God.' All eyes were fixed on him and his eyes shed incessant tears. Mahārāttās of noble family came there, and stood statue-like hearing him recite the name of God. Behind them I saw hundreds of women with the end of their Çadi wiping away the falling tears, moved as they were by the pathos of Chaitanya thus calling upon God. Innumerable Sanyasins of the Çaiva and Çākta sects, stood there with folded hands and listened to the chanting with closed eyes."

The end in 1534.

Chaitanya came back to Puri in 1511. Thence he went to Vrindavan and spent there the following six years, after which he returned to Puri and stayed for 18 years. His earthly career came to an end on the afternoon of a Sunday, being the 7th day

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প্রভুর মুখের পানে সবার নয়ন।
ঝর ঝর করি অশ্রু পড়ে অনুক্ষণ॥
বড় বড় মহারাষ্ট্রী আসি দলে দলে।
শুনিতে লাগিল নাম মিলিয়া সকলে॥
পশ্চাৎভাগেতে মুই দেখি তাকাইয়া।
শত শত কুলবধূ আছে দাঁড়াইয়া॥
নারীগণ অশ্রুজল মুছিচে আঁচলে।
ভক্তি ভরে হরি নাম শুনিছে সকলে॥
অসংখ্য বৈষ্ণব শৈব সন্ন্যাসী জুটিয়া।
হরিনাম শুনিতেছে নয়ন মুদিয়া॥

Kadchā.

of the waxing moon in the month of Asāḍa (July) on sunday at about 3 P. M. (1534 A. D.). He was 48 years and 4 months old at the time.

His wonderful emotion and tenderness display however only one phase of the character of Chaitanya Deva. He was an ascetic of the truest type, and was always keenly alive to the holiness of the ascetic's vow. If any one amongst his companions showed the least worldliness, he was unsparing in his treatment of him. He used to sleep on the bare floor of the Puri temple and when Jagadānanda once brought a pillow for him, he indignantly said "Bring me a couch, Jagadānanda, if you desire me to taste the comforts of this world. Don't you know that I am an ascetic, that as such I ought to sleep on the bare earth and that luxury is inconsistent with my vows." One of his followers Chota Hari Das accosted a beautiful woman named Madhabi in a tender manner. Chaitanya Deva said "He has taken the ascetic's vow and still follows after women. I will not look at him again." He never again allowed Chota Hari Das to come into his presence and the man is said to have died of a broken heart. Sanātan a rich man, who became his disciple came to meet him wearing a blanket which he had purchased for Rs. 3. It was the cold season and the bare body of Chaitanya Dev and of his followers were exposed to the shivering cold but they looked contented and joyful inspite of it. Chaitanya Deva talked with Sanātan but kept his eyes fixed on his blanket. The look was too much for Sanātan who escaped it by giving the blanket to a beggar and then joined the order of the ascetics. Govinda Dās offered half his

His asceticism and severity.

portion of a *haritaki* to Chaitanya Deva after his dinner, and kept the other half for the next day. On seeing the other half, the next day he enquired of Govinda Dās where he got it. The latter replied that it was the remnant of the day before; "Would you store up things for the morrow like a worldly man? You cannot then be admitted into the order of the ascetics." He was made to retire to his home for this act. A bottle of perfumes was presented by an admirer in Puri. It was broken on the spot by his order and the perfume allowed to soak into earth. The ascetics were required to clean a temple one day at Puri. It was observed that the dust carried away by Chaitanya Deva were larger than those of the servants employed at the same task.

The fine frenzy of a poet and a lover.

There is yet another side of his character which requires prominent notice and which inspired the Vaiṣṇava poets with new ideals in their love-poems. The vision of God was always before him. It was Kriṣṇa's lovely complexion that he found painted in the newly formed clouds – and it was Kriṣṇa's divine flute that he heard in the songs of birds. When conversing with learned scholars and the devotees of the type of Rām Rāy, he would explain the meaning of this love; this was a concrete way of thinking of the universal spirit—the great soul attracting the lesser souls as the sun attracts the planets. Even in the Vedas we find a Risi praying to God that He may come to him as a husband comes to his wife. This idea was taken up and developed in the faith of the Vaiṣṇavas God, according to them, is the Lord of love. This Chaitanya explained with many

learned quotations from Sanskrit works on theology. But when the God-vision possessed him, he yielded to the fine frenzy of a poet and a lover. Whenever he would see the Kadamva flower blooming into beauty, freshened by the rains, he would fall into a trance, remembering that it was the favourite of Kriṣṇa; when the clouds appeared on the clear horizon, with the crown of the rain-bow fixed above, his eyes would not move from the lovely sight and he shed profuse tears, stretching out his arms heaven-wards and calling on his beloved Kriṣṇa to come to him. Wherever he saw a shady grove of flowering trees, he took it for the Vrinda groves where Kriṣṇa sported; and wherever he saw a river flow before him, he heard in it, the soft mumers of the river Jumna, associated with Kriṣṇa. It was a beautiful sight to see him in fits of ecstacy. The Tāmāl tree with its dark-blue foliage created an illusion in him and he ran to embrace it,—there with tears in his eyes he would chant hymns and quote verses on love. He had the highest poetical vision vouchsafed only to those who are endowed with the power to realise the presence of that primeval Poet whose creation of fancy this world is. If a great Emperor all unexpectedly calls at the lowly cottage of his poorest subject, what tribute can be offer to the monarch except the gratitude of his whole soul expressed in tears! Even so it was the case with Chaitanya; he saw the God-vision and became completely lost in it; his life was a course of thanks-giving, tears, hymns and praises offerd to God.

He reorganised the Vaisnava order.

Yet this divine man never neglected the society he lived in. He allowed the Mahammadans to

enter his order; he cared not for caste or creed; he reorganised society and formed a new order in which merit and not birth was the mark of superiority. In this new order, Gangā Narāyan Chakervarty—a renowned Brahmin scholar, openly took the dust of the feet of Narottam—a Çūdra, and acknowledged him as his spiritual preceptor and many others did similar things—violating openly all caste-prejudices.

Incarnation of God.

People took Chaitanya as an incarnation of God, and his image is now worshipped by the Vaiṣṇavas of Bengal and Orissa. He was always unsparing however during his life time, in his condemnation of such attempts to deify him. Rām Rāy the Prime Minister of Pratāp Rudra of Orissa, asked him why he was so cautious in his conduct. "We all know you to be god in human flesh, you may act as you like; why observe, so many restraints?"—he said. Chaitanya replied in firm tones "I am a man and I have taken the ascetic's vow. In body, in mind, in speech, and in all my dealings I must be spotless. As in a white cloth a dark spot becomes conspicious, so a trifling fault in an ascetic's character, is prominent in the eyes of men. He is shunned like the pitcher of milk with a drop of wine in it." Vāsu Deva Sarbabhoum, the veteran scholar, with folded palms bowed down to him on his return from Southern India, and said "I know you, O Lord! to be God on earth" Chaitanya indignantly answered "Sir! why do you talk nonsense? Speak on other subjects." So in Çāntipur when Içvar Bhārati prayed to him as to a God, he was offended. In the historic garden of Śibas' house at Navadwīp the party assembled,

instead of singing and reciting the name of God, one day sang, "Praises to you O Chaitanya"—and when Chaitanya heard it, he stopped the singing, and asked the party to retire for the night. Such instances are numerous in his several biographies.

But when in one of his trances he would lose all consciousness of the outer-world and picture-like or like a figure sculptured in fine clay, would lean on the shoulders of a comrade, his eyes over flowing with unconscious tears—wide-open yet not cognizant of this phenomenal world—a celestial joy beaming out of his countenance that spoke of the soul enjoying divine communion within, he was sometimes heard to murmur "I am He." The mystic words were cought by his followers who based their faith on them. But when reminded of this on return of his consciousness, he denied all knowledge of such unholy utterance, cried for forgiveness in remorse and said that he was a great sinner. The fact of this utterance coming from his lips during occasional fits of unconsciousness is related in Chaitanya Bhāgbata and other works which were written many years after Chaitanya Deva had pased away, and we all know how fertile is the Indian soil for the growth of wild stories about saintly characters whom, it is to the advantage of their followers to deify. In the contemporary records left by Govinda Dās, whom we consider to be one of the most authentic biographers of Chaitanya, no reference is made to any such utterances, though he describes Chaitanya Deva's ecstacies more often that any other biographer. It is for such omissions and for the rational view of the matters which he took, that orthodox Vaiṣṇavas

do not give credence to Govinda Karmakār's accounts, whereas for these very reasons his work has an historical value and deserves the highest esteem.

The greatest exponent of the Renaissance.

But whether an incarnation or not,—whether he did or did not cure leprosy and blindness ascribed to him by the later biographers, we verily believe that he was a god-man vouchsafed to Bengal in order to raise her out of the stupor of ignorance into which she had sunk for ages. He embodied in himself the perfection of that spirit of faith and love which this country aspired to reach, rising out of the extremely sceptial opinions of latter-day Buddhism. In him we find the faith that belongs to the age of the Paurāṅic Renaissance in fully developed from and in this respect he may be said to have been its greatest exponent. But he was far removed from the all pervading spirit of Paurāṅic Renaissance in disowning the Brahmin, as the unquestionable head of society, electing in his place those endowed with spirituality and high character as naturally fit to rule irrespective of their birth.

III. Vaiṣṇava biographies.

Before the advent of Chaitanya Deva, there had been no biographical literature in Bengal. The songs in praise of the Pāl Kings are monostrous fables and are as remote from history as any fiction; the facts gleaned from them are the result of the scrutinizing researches of scholars by which fables are interpreted in the light of history. During the Paurāṅik Revival, following the Buddhistic period, people liked to

hear stories related about their gods and about the mythological characters of pre-historic times as narrated in the Purāṅas. The scholars were inspired by the ideals set up in classical works and altogether lost light of the living men and women of the human world. But Chaitanya Deva's holy life and his pure devotion threw Çastras and theological works into the back ground; the Purāṅas came to occupy only a secondary place with his followers, and living examples of faith came to the fore-front. The Brahmins with Manu's jurisprudence, Yajñvalkya's laws and the caste-stories created by the Brahmavaivartha Purāṅa, lost their authority with the Vaiṣṇavas, and in the new order Çūddras, the lowest of the four original castes, often occupied equal rank with Brahmins. The Vaiṣṇavas of Bengal like the Buddhist Çramans were held in as much respect as the Brahmins, though they were recruited like the Çramans from all castes. The social order was completely upset; the followers of Chaitanya Deva often showed a fanatical disregard for caste-prejudices. A person in Hindu society cannot, according to rule, partake of cooked food at the hands of one who belongs to an inferior caste. In Chaitanya Charitāmṛita, we find one of Chaitanya's disciples named Kali Dās who belonged to one of the hightest castes in society, making it the mission of his life to partake of refuse food left on the plates of Pariahs, Doms, and Chandāls, and it is written that when Chaitanya Deva heard of this he was pleased. At a time when caste-rules held people in their iron grip, such fanaticism was necessary, in order to open the eyes of men to the truth.

Caste ignored in Vaiṣṇava biographies.

Çyāmānanda, Narottama Dās and Raghunath Dās were held in the hightest esteem by the Vaiṣṇava community; nay, many good Brahmins acknowledged them as their spiritual heads, though they belonged to inferior castes.

Narahari Chakravartī, a Brahmin author, wrote a life of Narottam, a Çūdra, with feelings verging on worship. Such a thing had been inconceivable with the orthodox community of the period and yet became too true, shewing that a new life had dawned in this land, awakening men to a right appreciation of the value of character and spirituality amongst men in preference to caste-honour. Narahari, the Brahmin, often declared himself eager to take the dust of the feet of Narottam, a Çūdra.

The biographical literature of the Vaiṣṇavas is as varied as it is rich, and it gives us a graphic account of the history of Bengal society in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries.

(a) Kaḍchā or notes by Govinda Dās.

Let us first begin with the biography of Chaitanya Deva by his servant Govinda Karmakār, who accompanied him during his travels in the Deccān. It is not a biography properly so called, the book is called Kaḍchā or notes. He says,—"I got down notes of his doings very privately."*—privately, because Chaitanya Deva would not like that his companions should take notes of the incidents of his life. He would not tolerate any act

* "কড়চা করিয়া রাখি অতি সংগোপনে॥"
Kaḍchā.

in his immediate follower—from worldly cosiderations—and much less any for the glorification of his own personality.

Govinda Das was a blacksmith by caste. "I used," he writes, "to make weapons, ladles and tongs; my mother's name is Mādhavī; my wife Çaçīmukhī quarrelled with me and called me an illiterate fool. Feeling greatly, insulted I left home one morning."*

Govinda quarrels with his wife and leaves home.

It was in the year 1508 that Govinda Dās, indignant at his wife's conduct, left Kānchannagar,—his native village in Burdwan. He heard on the way that a great saint had appeared in Navadwipa and conceived a strong desire to see him; he came to Navadwipa at noon time, and met Chaitanya Deva in the company of his friends, bathing in the Ganges. The sight charmed him, he writes:†—

Meets Chaitanya.

"With him there was an ascetic (Nityananda) whose face seemed to be lit up with true spiritual fire. Next there came Advaita Gosvāmī; never have I seen a face so full of wisdom; his beard and hair were hoary with age, giving him a venerable look; his flowing beard fell below his breast.

* "অস্ত্র হাতা বেড়ি গড়ি জাতিতে কামার।
মাধবী নামেতে হয় জননী আমার॥
আমার নারীর নাম শশীমুখী হয়।
একদিন ঝগড়া করি মোরে কটু কয়॥
নিগুর্ণ মুরুখ বলি গালি দিল মোরে।
সেই অপমানে গৃহ ছাড়িলাম ভোরে॥"
Kadcha.

† "সঙ্গে এক অবধূত প্রসন্ন বদন॥
অবশেষে আইল তথি অদ্বৈত গোঁসাই।
এমন তেজস্বী মুই কভু দেখি নাই॥
পক্ক কেশ পক্ক দাড়ি বড় মোহনিয়া।

* * * I looked at the Lord (Chaitanya). The very sight was wonderful to me. I cannot describe the feelings that came upon me. A thrill of joy passed through me; and my hair stood on end for joy like the spikes of the Kadamva flower. I stood lost in wonder and delight. I was spell-bound and transfixed to the spot; my limb trembled and I perspired till my garments were wet. What I felt I cannot exactly describe—I wished I could wash the dear feet of the Lord with my tears."

He prayed to Chaitanya to be admitted as a servant in his household which permission was at once accorded. Govinda Dās describes his new home and its inmates thus:*—

Govinda Das's new home.

"There are five large and beautiful houses standing on the banks of the Ganges. Çacī Devi (mother of Chaitanya) is short in stature and of

দাড়ি পড়িয়াছে তার হৃদয় ছাড়িয়া ॥
ঘাটে বসি এই লীলা হেরিনু নয়নে
কি জানি কেমন ভাব উপজিল মনে ॥
কদম্ব কুসুম সম অঙ্গে কাঁটা দিল।
থর হরি সব অঙ্গ কাঁপিতে লাগিল ॥
ঘামিয়া উঠিল দেহ তিতিল বসন।
ইচ্ছা অশ্রু জলে মুই পাখালি চরণ ॥"

Kadcha

* "গঙ্গার উপরে বাড়ি অতি মনোহর।
পাঁচ খানি বড় ঘর দেখিতে সুন্দর ॥
শান্ত মূর্ত্তি শচী দেবী অতি অল্প কায়
নিমাই নিমাই বলি সদা ফুকরায় ॥
বিষ্ণুপ্রিয়া দেবী হন প্রভুর ঘরণী।
প্রভুর সেবায় রাত্র দিবস রজনী ॥
লক্ষ্মীবতী বিনায়ণী মৃদু মৃদু ভায়।"

Kadcha.

quiet and unassuming appearance. She is always making enquiries about her son. Viṣṇupriyā Devī is the wife of our Lord, and is always busy in ministering to his comforts. Humble in spirit, of a shy and retiring nature, she speaks very gently."

No meat, no fish could enter their home, as indeed is the case in all true Vaiṣṇava families. All food prepared in the house was first offered to Kriṣṇa, and then the inmates of the house partook of it as *prasad*. Various kinds of vegetables and preparations of milk were used in Chaitanya Deva's house, and Govinda Dās relished them exceedingly. He writes*:—

He relishes the home-meal.

"There were sweet vegetable-roots, fruits, thickened milk, butter, cream and excellent preparations of herbs, vegetable soup, gruel, puddings and various sorts of sweetmeats. Çachī Devī cooks delicious food which is first offered to Kriṣṇa and then distributed amongst the members of the household. I, the prince of gluttons, became a willing servant in the house."

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* প্রতিদিন ভোগ হয় বিষ্ণুর মন্দিরে।
কত ফল মূল ছানা ননী সর ক্ষীরে॥
শাক সূপ দধি সুক্তা মোদক পায়স।
বড়া লাড্ডু মিষ্টকাদি খাইতে সুরস॥
প্রতি দিন শচী মাতা করেন রন্ধন।
আনন্দে করেন সবে প্রসাদ ভোজন॥
পেটুকের শিরোমণি মুই হই দাস।
দয়াল প্রভুর পাত্রে খাই বার মাস॥

Kadchā.

Chaitanya's emotions.

But Chaitanya's mind was not on earthly matters. "His mind is lost in love for Krisṇa; his eyes overflow with tears." "If any one cries 'Oh! Krisṇa, Oh! my soul' Chaitanya immediately runs to embrace him."*

He resolves to turn an ascetic.

After Govinda Dās had stayed a litttle more than a year in the house, Chaitanya expressed his wish to renounce the world, and become an ascetic. He thus described his mission† :—

"I shall have my head shaven, cast off the sacred thread, and wander as a Sannyāsī from house to house, preaching the love of Krisṇa. Youngmen, children, old men, wordly men and even

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* "কৃষ্ণ অনুরাগে সদা ব্যাকুল হৃদয়।
শুনিলে কৃষ্ণের নাম অশ্রু ধারা বয়॥
যদি প্রাণ কৃষ্ণ বলি উচ্চৈস্বরে ডাকে।
ধেয়ে গিয়ে আলিঙ্গন করেন তাহাকে॥"

Kadchā.

† "একারণ মুহি শিখা সূত্র তেয়াগিয়া।
বেড়াইব দ্বারে দ্বারে হরি নাম দিয়া॥
সেই নাম পথে ঘাটে করিব প্রচার॥
চণ্ডাল যুবক গৃহ বাল বৃদ্ধ নারী।
নামে মত্ত হইয়া দাঁড়াবে সারি সারি॥
বালকে বলিবে হরি বালিকা বলিবে।
পাষণ্ড অঘোরপন্থী নামে মত্ত হবে॥
আকাশ ভেদিয়া নামের পতাকা উড়িবে।
রাজা প্রজা এক সঙ্গে গড়াগড়ি যাবে॥
সন্ন্যাস করিয়া যদি না লই কৌপিন।
তবে কিসে উদ্ধারিব পাপী তাপী দীন॥
কলির জীবের দশা মলিন দেখিয়া।
থাকিতে পারিনা আর কাঁদে মোর হিয়া॥"

Kadchā.

the Pariahs will stand round me charmed with the name of God. The very boys and girls will cry "Oh! Kriṣṇa!" The infidels and the *Aghorapanthis* (a vicious class of Tāntrikas) will be drawn by the charm of Kriṣṇa's name. Thge fla of his name will wave on high, piercing the very skies. Kings and poor men alike will feel the irresistible charm of His name. If I do not renounce my home, how can sinners be saved? My heart feels deep pangs for the sinners of the world, and for those who are stung by the world's woes."

Govinda Dās describes minutely all that happened to Chaitanya on his way from Purī to the Deccān, and thence to Guzerat and back to Purī. In Siddhavaṭeçvaram occurred the tempting of Chaitanya, to which I referred in a previous chapter. Govinda Dās describes the incident thus* :—

Tirtharam tempts him.

"There came a rich man of the name of Tirtharāma, with two harlots, to try Chaitanya and see if he should prove a mere pretender. Of the two women, one was called Satyavāi and the other Lakṣmivāi. They began to speak of many things before Chaitanya. Being instructed by

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* হেন কালে আইল সেথা তীর্থ ধনবান।
দুইজন বেশ্যা সঙ্গে আইলা দেখিতে।
সন্ন্যাসীর ভারি ভুরি পরীক্ষা করিতে॥
সত্যবাই লক্ষ্মীবাই নামে বেশ্যাদ্বয়।
প্রভুর নিকটে আসি কত কথা কয়॥
ধনীর শিক্ষায় সেই বেশ্যা দুইজন।
প্রভুরে বুঝিতে বহু করে আয়োজন॥
তীর্থরাম মনে মনে নানা কথা বলে।

the rich man, they tried to tempt him in various ways and Tirtharāma thought, the ascetic will surely be wrecked this time. Satyavāi adopted coquettish manners, and sat smiling near Chaitanya. She partially uncovered herself displaying her charms. Chaitanya addressed her saying 'Oh! Mother,' Satya was frightened at this address, and Lakṣmi's fears were apparent on her face. Chaitanya was not in the least affected by their presence. Satya fell at his feet in remorse. Chaitanya said 'Oh! Mother, why do you make me a sinner by falling at my feet?' He could say no more. His matted locks hung loose—covered over with dust. The ecstasy of love passed over him and he began to tremble for joy; everything of this world seemed to pass away from his sight. He became unconscious in the presence of Satyavāi and Laksmīvāi, and

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সন্ন্যাসীর তেজ এবে হরে লব ছলে ॥
কত রঙ্গ করে লক্ষ্মী সত্যবালা হাসে।
সত্যবালা হাসি মুখে বসে প্রভু পাশে ॥
কাঁচলি খুলিয়া সত্য দেখাইলা স্তন।
সত্যরে করিলা প্রভু মাতৃ সম্বোধন ॥
থর থরি কাঁপে সত্য প্রভুর বচনে।
হহা দেখি লক্ষ্মী বড় ভয় পায় মনে ॥
কিছুই বিকার নাই প্রভুর মনেতে।
ধেয়ে গিয়ে সত্যবালা পড়ে চরণেতে ॥
কেন অপরাধী কর আমারে জননী।
এই মাত্র বলি প্রভু পড়িলা ধরণী ॥
খসিল জটার ভার ধূলায় ধূসর।
অনুরাগে থর থর কাঁপে কলেবর।

danced in the very ecstasy of love crying out 'Oh! Krishna, Oh! Krishna.' He was like one under a spell, and his eyes overflowed with tears of joy. His outer robes fell from his body, and thus uncovered he stood breathing deeply Sometimes he fell to the ground unconscious of the hurt he received from the thorns. His rosary were unstrung. His body was reduced to a skeleton by much fasting and it bled being torn by the thorns. Charmed with the name of Krishna, he danced in ecstasy of heavenly joy. A strange light shot forth from his person. The rich man was lost in admiration at this sight. He fell at his feet, but Chaitanya was unconscious.

সব এলো থেলো হ'ল প্রভুর আমার।
কোথা লক্ষী কোথা সত্য নাহি দেখি আর॥
নাচিতে লাগিলা প্রভু বলি হরি হরি।
লোমাঞ্চিত কলেবর অশ্রু দর দরি॥
গিয়াছে কৌপীণ খসি কোথা বহির্বাস।
উলঙ্গ হইয়া নাচে ঘন বহে শ্বাস॥
আছাড়িয়া পড়ে নাহি মানে কাঁটা খোঁচা।
ছিঁড়ে গেল কণ্ঠ হতে মালিকার গোছা॥
না খাইয়া অস্থি চর্ম্ম হইয়াছে সার।
ক্ষীণ অঙ্গে বহিতেছে শোনিতের ধার॥
হরি নামে মত্ত হয়ে নাচে গোরা রায়।
অঙ্গ হইতে অদ্ভুত তেজ বাহিরায়॥
হহা দেখি সেই ধনী মনে চমকিল।
চরণ তলেতে পড়ি আশ্রয় লইল॥
চরণে দলেন তারে নাহি বাহ্যজ্ঞান।
হরি বলি বাহু তুলে নাচে আগুয়ান॥
সত্যেরে বাহুতে ছাঁদি বলে বল হরি।

With arms lifted towards heaven he danced on. He took Satyavāi by the arm and told her to call on the name of Krisṇa. All were charmed at the sight. He lay unconscious of the physical world, his mind fixed on Krisṇa,—his head drooped on one side, and saliva flowed from his lips—his body was covered with dust—eyes were shut yet still shedding tears. The Buddhists who were on the spot, deeply moved by the sight, cried 'Oh! Krisṇa, Oh! Krisṇa', and as Chaitanya heard the name of God from the mouth of these sceptics, tears—incessant tears streamed forth from his eyes. Tirtharāma was deeply affected at the sight. He said 'Oh! sinner and faithless man that I am, be gracious Oh! Lord, and show me how I may obtain God's mercy!' Chaitanya embraced Tirtharāma and said 'You are really a virtuous soul, Oh! Tirtharāma, I feel myself hallowed by your

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হরি বল প্রাণেশ্বর মুকুন্দ মুরারী ॥
কোথা প্রভু কোথায় বা মুকুন্দ মুরারী
অজ্ঞান হইলা সবে এই ভাব হেরি ॥
হরি নামে মত্ত প্রভু নাহি বাহ্য জ্ঞান।
ঘাড় ভাঙ্গি পড়িতেছে আকুল পরাণ ॥
মুখে লালা অঙ্গে ধূলা নাহিক বসন
কণ্টকিত কলেবর মুদিত নয়ন ॥
ভাব দেখি যত বৌদ্ধ বলে হরি হরি
শুনিয়া গোরার চক্ষে বহে অশ্রু বারি ॥
ইহা দেখি তীর্থরাম কাঁদিয়া উঠিল।
বড়ই পাষণ্ড মুই বলে তীর্থরাম ॥
কৃপা করি দেহ মোরে প্রভু হরি নাম।
তীর্থরাম পাষণ্ডেরে করি আলিঙ্গন ॥

touch.' And again and again he said 'Tirtharāma, you have won the love of God.' Tirtharāma fell at his feet and wept. When remorse came to him, and with that a spirit of resignation, Chaitanya embraced him and raised him by his arms. He said 'Cast away all earthly wealth like a straw, and then only you will have true love for God. Cast off your fine apparel and jewels;—by renouncing these transitory riches you will secure permanent riches. This body of yours, covered with skin, will rot and perish in a few years; and when your soul has departed, it will be reduced to ashes or eaten by worms or turned into clods of earth. There is nothing in the world, my friend, in which to glory save only devotion to God. Know all earthly things to be fleeting; renounce them and correct yourself of your habits of luxury. I cannot say how God's grace can be obtained. God

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প্রভু বলে তীর্থরাম তুমি সাধুজন।
পবিত্র হইনু আমি পরশি তোমারে।
তুমিত প্রধান ভক্ত কহে বারে বারে।
তীর্থরাম ধনী তবে চরণে পড়িয়া।
আকুল হইল কত কান্দিয়া কান্দিয়া।
কান্দিতে কান্দিতে যবে ভক্তি উপজিল
অমনি ধরিয়া হাত প্রভু আলিঙ্গিল।
প্রভু কহে তৃণ সম গণহ বৈভবে।
ভক্তি ধন অমূল্য রতন পাবে তবে।
দেহ হতে প্রাণ পাখী উড়ে যাবে যবে।
হয় কীট নয় ভস্ম নয় মাটী হবে।
গৌরবের ধন কিছু নাহি ত্রিভুবনে।

Himself carries His grace to the soul of man. It is not in my power to say more than this. The whole world bears unfailing testimony to divine grace. What other proof will a wise man require to bring conviction to him? Nothing is gained by fruitless discussion. To one whose soul yearns for divine love, God himself comes and inspires him with faith."

These and other teachings moved Tīrtharāma so much that he took the ascetic's vow and he began to chant the name of Krishna day and night. "His infidel friends came and pitied the condition of Tīrtharāma, and said 'Lo, Tīrtharāma is ruined."

The account of how Nārojī and Bhīlapantha, two great robbers, were reformed, and how Vāramukhī, an exceedingly beautiful woman of Guzerat, left her evil ways by the influence of Chaitanya Deva, are vividly described by Govinda Dās.

His influence irresistible.

The frenzy of divine love seen in Chaitanya Devā had attractions which could not be resisted by any feeling soul. Wherever the young ascetic

কেবল গৌরব আছে ঈশ্বর ভজনে।
বিলাস বৈভব সব অনিত্য জানিয়া।
একে একে ফেলে দাও দূরেতে টানিয়া।
ঈশ্বরে বিশ্বাস ঈশ্বর আনিয়া মিলায়।
আর কিছু প্রমাণ ত কহনে না যায়।
অসংখ্য জগৎ হয় প্রমাণের ঠাই।
প্রমাণ নাহিক চাহে পণ্ডিত গোসাই।
নাহি প্রয়োজন বহু বাদ বিতণ্ডায়।
কৃষ্ণ আনি সাধকের বিশ্বাস মিলায়

Kadeha

went, people thronged round him, in large numbers; scholars admired his profound learning, and the common people his ecstasies of love. And here in Bengal the village artists still paint him as standing in a trance, with his hands uplifted towards heaven and his eyes shedding tears.

His followers, who inspite of their earnest entreaties to be permitted to accompany him on his tour were all left at Purī, grieved at the separation and waited eagerly there for his return, longing for the happy meeting. Chaitanya wandered through Southern India all this time, like a mad man, reduced to a skeleton by the fatigues of the journey, by fasts and by vigils,—all borne with a gladsome heart because of his great love. Children used to throw dust at him, sometimes taking him to be a mad man as he passed by; but when he spoke, the wandering gaze of thousands fell upon him and they saw his face glow with a celestial light, which is a never-failing sign of spirituality, vouchsafed to one, who, in a pure heart rests on His great love.

Joy at the re-union.

Govinda's description of the meeting of Chaitanya Deva with his followers, when he came back to Purī, vividly pictures the animation and joy of the event. Murāri Gupta fell on his knees before him; with clasped palms the veteran Vāsudeva said "My heart is made of stone, or it would have broken long ago, at being separated from you." Narahari met him in great joy carrying a flag in his hand, and Khanjan Āchāryya though lame came swiftly before all others because of his great love for Chaitanya. The news of his arrival

spread quickly all over the country, and Govinda Dās gives an interesting and animated description of how the musicians Laksman and Valarām Dās who sounded the horn called Rām Çingā in the procession, together with Giri Purī, Nārāyan Tīrtha and other great scholars speedily appeared on the scene to pay their respects to their beloved master. Rājā Pratāp Rudra used to visit the procession every day and when Chaitanya marched with it, the King followed him on foot, with the humility and respects of a disciple. On the 3rd of Māgha Chaitanya came back to Purī, and Govinda Dās finishes his diary here.

Govinda Dās and his wife.

A word is now necessary about Govinda Dās and his literary powers. Shortly after he had left home in a fit of anger he met again with his wife. Chaitanya Deva came to Burdwan on his way to Purī, Govinda being with him; and here the interview took place.

*"Knowing somehow or other that I had come to Burdwan, she hastened to meet me. Tears were flowing from her eyes, while she fell at my feet saying 'O come back and let us go home together.

* এই কথা বলিতে বলিতে মোর নারী।
কেমনে শুনিয়া তথা আইলা ত্বরা করি॥
ঝর ঝর পড়িতেছে অশ্রু দুনয়নে।
পড়িলা আছাড় খেয়ে আমার চরণে॥
অশ্রু হয়ে বলিতে লাগিলা এই বাত।
ফিরে চল গৃহে মুই যাই তব সাত॥
সামান্য কথায় তুমি সংসার তেজিলে।
বাসীর উপায় তবে বল কি করিলে॥

For a slight fault of mine you have renounced home; what provision will you make for me—your poor and devoted servant? Where am I to go, and who will give me charity? I cannot tell what fate is reserved for me! To support a cursed life, now I must go and beg.' Hearing these words I hung down my head and said to myself "O God, O God." Since God's name makes the heart pure and raises it above all earthly attachments I took refuge in His name." Chaitanya heard all that my wife had said and sweetly talked with her on the aims of the spiritual life. Hearing his words she was very sorrowful. She said nothing but began to weep bitterly,—looking round helplessly. Chaitanya tried to soothe her with religious advice, but she hid her face in her

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কার দ্বারে গিয়া ভিক্ষা করিব কোথায়।
দয়া করি কেবা ভিক্ষা দিবে গো আমায়॥
কি আছে অদৃষ্টে মোর কার দ্বারে গিয়া।
ভিক্ষা করি বেড়াইব পেটের লাগিয়া॥
শুনিয়া তাহার বাণী মাথা হেট করি।
মনে মনে বলিতে লাগিনু হরি হরি॥
হরি স্মরণেতে কাটে যতেক বন্ধন।
তেকারণে মনে করি হরির চরণ॥
দয়াময় শ্রীচৈতন্য হেরিয়া তখন।
কহিতে লাগিলা তবে মধুর বচন॥
শুনিয়া প্রভুর বাণী হইয়া দুঃখিনী।
অশ্রুজলে ভিজাইতে লাগিলা মেদিনী॥
কান্দিয়া আকুল বামা চারিদিকে চায়।
তত্ত্ব কথা বলি প্রভু তাহারে বুঝায়॥

sāḍi and wept even more bitterly. Seeing her in this condition, Chaitanya became full of compassion and said turning towards me:—"You need not go with me, Govinda, I shall take another servant; you had better go home with your wife."

But how could poor Govinda leave the company of that divine man whose attraction had proved too strong for the princely Raghunath and Narattam, for Sanātan and Rupa, the ministers of the court of the Emperor of Gour, who had all left their vast worldly possessions, and joined the order of the Sannyāsins for the great love they bore to the master? In fact he who makes us understand our relation to God, the only true relationship worth caring for, wields an irresistible power over us. When a prophet or a seer causes us to see the highest truth, this phenomenal world, —the fleeting and the perishable passes out of our sight and He becomes more real to us than any object of the senses. So it was with Govinda and others. When Chaitanya expressed his desire to leave Govinda at Burdwan:—

শুনিয়া প্রভুর সেই কথা আচম্বিতে।
চক্ষু চাপি আঁচলেতে লাগিলা কান্দিতে॥
তাহার রোদনে প্রভুর দয়া উপজিল।
অমনি ফিরিয়া মোরে কহিতে লাগিল॥
প্রভু কহে গোবিন্দরে গৃহে থাক তুমি।
অন্য ভৃত্য সঙ্গে করি পুরী যাই আমি॥"

Kaḍchā.

Chaitanya leaves Govinda.

*"I clasped his feet in deep anguish of heart and washed them with tears, but Chaitanya turned away and left me."

Govinda could not, however, stay at Burdwan. He hastened to overtake Chaitanya Deva dismissing a number of friends, who had in the meantime assembled there to dissuade him from his resolve to renounce home as a Sannyāsin. The devotion of Chaitanya's followers was wonderful. In the last page of the Kaḍchā Govinda writes that he was entrusted by Chaitanya Deva while at Puri to carry a letter from him, to Advaitāchāryya at Çāntipur. This meant his absence from Puri for a few days. But when entrusted with this task :—

The devotedness of his followers.

†"Hearing this, tears started to my eyes, for I could not bear separation from the Lord." Vāsu Deva Sārvabhauma—the veteran scholar, had once said ‡"If a thunder bolt falls on my head or if my son dies, even that is bearable, but I cannot bear to hear Chaitanya abused."—The great love in which Chaitanya Deva was held in Bengal continues even now among her people, not to speak of his more special followers—the Vaiṣṇavas who believe him to be God himself. Even now in the village homes of Bengal parents clasp their little children to

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* এই বাক্যে মোর চক্ষু হ'তে অশ্রু ঝরে।
অমনি চরণ ধরি পড়িনু কাতরে॥
অশ্রুজলে পাখালিনু যুগল চরণ।
অমনি ফিরিয়া প্রভু করিলা গমন॥ Kaḍchā.

† এই বাক্য শুনি মোর চক্ষে বারি বহে।
প্রভুর বিরহ বাণ হৃদয়ে না সহে॥ Kaḍcha.

‡ শিরে বজ্র পড়ে যদি পুত্র মরি যায়।
তবুও প্রভুর নিন্দা সহন না যায়॥

their breasts and give them such tender names as 'Gour Chandra,' 'Navadvipa Chandra,' 'Nadevāsi,' 'Nagarvāsi',—all indicating Chaitanya Deva or Navadvipa his birth place, hallowed in their eyes by his associations. In Tippera, close to the Rānir Dighi, there is a locality inhabited by the Mālis or sweepers—a very low caste in Hindu society. I lived close to this neighbourhood for about eight years and scarcely a night passed that I did not hear these people sing in chorus for hours together, songs in praise of Chaitanya. "Come, if you would see the god-man who does not believe in caste" was the burden of one of these familiar songs. Not only in Tippera but everywhere in Bengal, people of the low castes show an unusual enthusiasm in singing songs in praise of the great Brāhmin who proclaimed the equality of all men in our society.

Descriptions of Nature.

Govinda Dās' writings are simple and unassuming. The deep spirituality of his mind lends a charm to his descriptions of nature. In speaking of the Nilgiri hills he compares them to a great yogi lost in divine contemplation. He describes the sea near Kanyākumāri in the following few lines:—

"We crossed Tāmraparni and Chaitanya felt a desire to see the sea. We heard the roar of its waves from a distance. There is no mountain, no

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" তাম্রপর্ণী পার হয়া সমুদ্রের পারে।
প্রভু কন্যাকুমারী চলিলা দেখিবারে॥
পর্ব্বত কানন দেশ নাহি সেই ঠাঁই।
কেবল সিন্ধুর শব্দ শুনিবারে পাই॥

forest, no land,—no sound but that of the sea moaning incessantly! No word can express it but it looked so grand! There is no object that meets the eye, yet it is so impressive! One who has a sinless heart can alone appreciate the grandeur of the sea."

Free from orthodoxy.

Govinda's writings are free from narrow and orthodox views on religion. Chaitanya Deva visited the temple of Çiva, of Çakti, of Ganapati and of Surja. Wherever and under whatever form or name, God was worshipped, Chaitanya Deva took that as the emblem of the Lord of his heart; it acted as a sign to remind him of One whom he loved supremely. The feeling that burnt like holy incense in the temple of his heart was nourished by all that he saw, and in his enlightened and spiritual view, gross forms and superstitious ideas were translated into the edifying truths of pure faith.

Hinduism accepts all worship and rejects none.

It is in the descriptions of Govinda Dās in the above strain that we find how the prophets and seers of India rejected nothing in the faith of the people however gross it might apparently seem. They always interpreted the thing worshipped in the highest light of faith and thus bridged over the gap between Fetichism and Vedantism. The lower classes in

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হুঁ হুঁ শব্দে সমুদ্র ডাকিছে নিরন্তর।
কি কব অধিক সেথা সকলি সুন্দর॥
দেখিবার কিছু নাই তথাপি শোভন।
সেখানে সৌন্দর্য্য দেখে শুদ্ধ যার মন॥"

Kadcha

all parts of the world are bound to be superstitious, but in Hinduism the gross forms of worship are always in touch with the superior light of pure faith and thus without disturbing the faith of the illiterate, Hinduism makes its vast religious system a homogeneous whole in which the lowest represents merely a step in the ladder that reaches the highest. This catholic trait in the character of Chaitanya Deva is deliberately omitted or ignored by many of his subsequent biographers, who wanted to represent him as the leader and upholder of their own party,—the god of a special class of men and not the prophet for all that he was undoubtedly.

b. Chaitanya Bhāgabata by Vrindāvan Dās.

Vrindāvan Dās, born 1507 A.D.

After Govinda Dās's account of the few years of Chaitanya's life, the next biographical work about the great Vaiṣṇava prophet was written by Vrindāvan Dās born in 1507 A.D. He was a grandson of Çrinivās, whose brother Çrivāsa's devotion to Chaitanya Deva is well known to the Vaiṣṇava community. The spacious lawn before Çrivāsa's house was the favourite haunt of the Sankirtan parties led by Chaitanya Deva; many a night from the rise of the evening star on the western horizon till the appearance of the sun, the deep chanting of God's name was heard accompanied with the unceasing sounds of *khol* and *kartal* in this historic '*angina*' of Çrivāsa, but Vrindāvan Dās was only two years old when Chaitanya Deva left Navadwipa for good. The biographer regrets in many passages of his work that he had not had the good fortune of seeing Chaitanya Deva.

Çrivāsa's *angina*.

Vrindāvan Dās's Chaitanya Bhāgavata is one of the standard works on his life and commands great influence amongst the Vaiṣṇavas; it contains about 25000 lines and is written throughout in the metre called the Payār Chhanda. Vrindāvan Dās represents the views of the orthodox Vaiṣṇavas and takes great pains to establish Chaitanya as an incarnation of Viṣṇu. He resents the opposition to such views by the unbelieving non-Vaiṣṇava communities with a freedom of language that transcends all limits of decency. Outside the orthodox Vaiṣṇava society none will appreciate his rude and overbearing remarks about those who would not accept Nityānanda, the friend of Chaitanya Deva and a Vaiṣṇava apostle, as an incarnation of Valarāma.

Chaitanya Bhāgabata.

Attacks on the non-Vaiṣṇavas.

But Vrindāvan Dās shows considerable powers as a historian. We feel a greater interest in the incidental description of the contemporary events that he gives than in his delineation of the subject of his memoir. He describes Chaitanya Deva's life in the light of the Bhāgabata which gives an account of Çri Kriṣṇa's life. Yet the Kriṣṇa of Vrindāvan, Mathurā and Kurukṣetra is as different from Chaitanya of Navadvipa as ever were any two characters in history. Vrindāvan Dās in his zeal to prove the identity of the two personalities hopelessly confounds both. It is, as I have said, in the incidental description of contemporary events that he shows the hand of a competent historian, and the biography greatly interests us when we study the minor facts related in it. It is also an invaluable source of information regarding the lives of many of Chaitanya Deva's followers.

Valuable side-lights.

Chaitanya's contemporaries.

He begins his work with a reference to the great Vaiṣṇava scholars and worthies who lived at Navadwipa immediately before Chaitanya Deva's birth and also to the condition of that city at the time. We have already quoted a passage from these accounts on page 410.

* "Some of these great Vaiṣṇavas had been born in Navadwipa; others in Chittagong, Rāḍha, Orissā and Sylhet. They were born in different places, but they had all met there. As the Lord (Chaitanya) would be born there, they were drawn to the place. Çrivāsa and Çri Rāma, the scholars, Çri Chandra Çekhara Deva highly esteemed everywhere, Murari Gupta—the healer of all earthly maladies (belonging to the physician caste)—these eminent Vaiṣṇavas were born in Sylhet. Pundarika Vidyāvinoda of pearless learning, Chaitanya Vallabha Datta and Vāsu Deva Datta, were born

* "কারো জন্ম নবদ্বীপে কারো চাটিগ্রামে।
কেহ রাঢ়ে উড্র দেশে শ্রীহটে পশ্চিমে॥
নানা স্থানে অবতীর্ণ হইল ভক্তগণ।
নবদ্বীপে আসি হইল সবার মিলন॥
নবদ্বীপে হইল প্রভুর অবতার।
অতএব নবদ্বীপে মিলন সবার॥
শ্রীবাস পণ্ডিত আর শ্রীরাম পণ্ডিত।
শ্রীচন্দ্রশেখরদেব বৈলক্য-পূজিত॥
ভব রোগ বৈদ্য মুরারি নাম যার।
শ্রীহট্টে এসব বৈষ্ণবের অবতার॥
পুণ্ডরিক বিদ্যানিধি বৈষ্ণব প্রধান।
চৈতন্য বল্লভ দত্ত বাসুদেব নাম॥

in Chittagong. Hari Dās was born at Budhan in Western Bengal. In the village EkChākā (Burdwan) was born the great apostle Nityānanda. All of them had met in Navadwipa."

These men in subsequent times obtained celebrity for their great faith. They were like torches that had only required the touch of Chaitanya Deva to kindle them.

The people of Navadwipa addicted to worldliness.

After describing the glories of Navadwipa, its paraphernalia of educational institutions, and the customs, and avocations of its residents and how they spent whole nights in singing songs in praise of Yogi Pāl, Gopi Pāl, Mahi Pāl and other kings of the Pāl dynasty, Vrindāvan Dās goes on to say:— *"They sometimes sing songs in honour of Manasā Devī and keep up whole nights. There are many others who worship Vāçuli with presents, others who offer meat and wine for sacrificial purposes. Music, dances, songs are always going on

চাটিগ্রামে হইল ইহা সবার প্রকাশ।
বুঢ়ণে হইল অবতীর্ণ হরিদাস॥
রাঢ় মাঝে একচাকা নামে আছে গ্রাম।
যথা অবতীর্ণ নিত্যানন্দ ভগবান॥
নবদ্বীপে আসি সবে হইল মিলন॥"

Chaitanya Bhāgabata.

* "দম্ভ করি বিষহরি পূজে কোন জন।
বাশুলি পূজয়ে কেহ নানা উপহারে।
মদ্য মাংস দিয়া কেহ যজ্ঞ পূজা করে॥
নিরবধি নৃত্য গীত বাদ্য কোলাহল।
না শুনে কৃষ্ণের নাম পরম মঙ্গল॥
বলিলেও কেহ নাহি লয় কৃষ্ণ নাম।
নিরবধি বিদ্যাকুল করেন ব্যাখান॥

Chaitanya Bhāgavata.

in the place and there is noise and bustle on all sides and men are without faith in Kriṣṅa. Religious teachings are thrown away on them. They do not care to take the name of Kriṣṅa. They are always vaunting their caste and their learning."

Chaitanya's visit to Gayā.

I quote the passage in which Chaitanya Deva's visit to Gayā is described.

* "The son of Çachi Devi (Chaitanya) entered Gayā, the holiest shrine in India. He came to Brahmakunda and bathed in it; he paid his respect to the departed spirit of his father in a fitting manner, and being admitted to the Çakraveda he hastened to see the lotus feet of Viṣṅu. The Brahmins stood around the feet; heaps of garlands of flowers were offered there;—sweet scents, flowers, incense and clothes were offered at the feet, so numerous that no one could keep record of them. The priests, clothed in holy attire, were

* "গয়াতে প্রবিষ্ট হইল শ্রীশচী নন্দন।
গয়া তীর্থ মাঝে প্রভু প্রবিষ্ট হইয়া।
ব্রহ্ম কুণ্ডে আসি প্রভু করিলেন স্নান।
যথোচিত কৈলা পিতৃদেবের সম্মান॥
তবে আইলেন চক্র বেড়ের ভিতরে।
পাদপদ্ম দেখিবারে চলিলা সত্বরে॥
বিপ্রগণ বেড়িয়া আছেন শ্রীচরণ।
শ্রীচরণে মালা যেন দেউল প্রমাণ॥
গন্ধ পুষ্প ধূপ দীপ বস্ত্র অলঙ্কার।
কত পড়িয়াছে লেখা জোখা নাহি তার॥
চতুর্দ্দিকে দিব্য রূপ ধরি বিপ্রগণ।
করিতেছে পাদপদ্ম প্রভাব বর্ণন॥

describing the glories of the Divine Feet. 'These Feet that Ye see here' they said 'the god Çiva has placed on his breast and called himself blessed thereby. The goddess Laksmi's whole soul rests in the lotus feet of the Lord,—the king Vali took them on his head and was reconciled to his lot in the nether world. To one who contemplates the feet of Visnu for a moment, Death loses all his horror. The great Yogies in their highest vision catch but a glimpse of these feet. O how fortunate are ye who see with your eyes this holy spectacle—the feet of Visnu from which sprang the Ganges, which rest on the head of Ananta, the thousand headed serpent, and which are worshipped by Laksmi. Fortunate are ye to have a sight of these feet!"

The lotus feet.

কাশীনাথ হৃদয়ে ধরিলা যে চরণ।
যে চরণ নিরবধি লক্ষ্মীর জীবন॥
বলি-শিরে আবির্ভাব হইল যে চরণ।
সেই এই দেখ যত ভাগ্যবন্তগণ॥
তিলার্দ্ধেক যে চরণ ধ্যান করা মাত্র।
যম তার না হয়েন অধিকার পাত্র॥
যোগেশ্বর সবের দুর্লভ যে চরণ।
সেই এই দেখ যত ভাগ্যবন্তগণ॥
যে চরণে ভাগীরথী হইল প্রকাশ।
নিরবধি হৃদয়ে না ছাড়েন যার দাস॥
যোগেশ্বর সবার দুর্লভ যে চরণ।
তাই এই দেখ যত ভাগ্যবন্তগণ॥
চরণ প্রভাব শুনি বিপ্রগণ মুখে।
আবিষ্ট হইল প্রভু নিজানন্দ সুখে॥
অশ্রুধারা বহে দুই শ্রীপদ্ম নয়নে।
অবিচ্ছিন্ন গঙ্গা বহে শ্রীপাদ দর্শনে॥

Chaitanya Bhāgavata.

Overflowing emotions.

"He became overpowered with feelings of joy which could not be concealed, and he trembled in a sort of ecstasy,—the incessant streams of the Ganges, as it were, flowed from his eyes."

Içvar Puri again.

Içvāra Puri had by this time come to Gayā, eager for Chaitanya's company, and met him on the threshhold of the Gayā temple. As Chaitanya saw him he bowed to him in deep reverence and said * "Blessed is my journey to Gayā for I have seen you. If offering Pinda can secure heaven to my dead father, surely the sight of a saint like yourself is a hundred times better. You are better than all shrines, Revered Sir, for the sight of you cleanses the soul. Save me from this sea of the world! I resign my body and soul to your care. Kindly teach me how I may take refuge at the lotus feet of Visňu."

He was again in a trance and when he recovered his senses he recited Sanskrit verses and said

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* প্রভুবলে গয়াযাত্রা সফল আমার।
যৎক্ষণ না দেখিলাম চরণ তোমার॥
তীর্থে পিণ্ড দিলে সে নিস্তার পিতৃগণে।
তোমা নিরখিলে মাত্র কোটি পিতৃগণ।
সেইক্ষণে সর্ব্ব বন্ধ পায় বিমোচন॥
অতএব তীর্থ নহে তোমার সমান।
তীর্থের পরম তুমি মঙ্গল প্রধান॥
সংসার সমুদ্র হতে উদ্ধার আমারে।
এই আমি দেহ সমর্পিলাম তোমারে॥
কৃষ্ণ পাদপদ্মের অমৃত রস পান।
আমারে করাও তুমি এই চাহি দান॥"

* 'O Krisṅa, O my father, O Lord of my soul, whither hast Thou gone and left me,' and he fell on the bare ground and his handsome person was besmeared with dust.

(c) Chaitanya Maṇgal by Jayānanda.

The next biographical account of Chaitanya Deva that we come across, was written by Jayānanda. Jayānanda was born in 1513 A. D He belonged to a family, from which sprang Raghunandan, the law-giver of Bengal of the 16th century. Jayānanda's father Subuddhi Miçra, was a noted personality of the Vaiṣṇava community, about whom frequent references are found in Govinda Dās's kaḍchā, Vaiṣṇavāchāradarpana, Charitāmrita and other works. Jayānanda when a child saw Chaitanya in the house of his grandfather. He was commonly called by the pet name of Guiā. It is said that Chaitanya took some interest in the boy and gave him the Sanskritic name of Jayānanda, by which he was latterly known.

Jayānanda, born 1513 A.D.

There are certain historical points, in which Jayānanda differs from other writers, and from the traditions current in the country. It is generally believed that Chaitanya's father Jagannāth Miçra was originally an inhabitant of Dhākādakṣina in Sylhet. But Jayānanda refers to Jayanagar in Sylhet as the native village of Jagannath Miçra. The Mahomedan devotee, who obtained a great celebrity in the Vaiṣṇava community under the name of Hari Dās, by his staunch devotion to

The new facts brought to light by him.

* কৃষ্ণরে বাপরে তোমায় পাইব কোথায় ॥

Chaitanya Deva and by accepting his faith, is generally believed to have been born in Buḍaṅa, but according to Jayānanda, Hari Dās was born in the village Bhatakalāgāchi on the bank of the river Svarṇa. We come to know from Jayānanda's Chaitanya Maṇgala that Chaitanya Deva's ancestors came to Bengal from Jājpur in Orissa.

The passing away of Chaitanya Deva.

The history of how Chaitanya Deva passed away is a mystery; it is not related either in the Chaitanya Bhāgabata or in the Chaitanya Charitāmrita—the two great authoritative works on Chaitanya's life. It is said that devout Vaiṣṇavas felt such pain in describing the story, that many of them scrupulously avoided narrating it in their biographies. It is true that once Chaitanya fell into a trance at the sight of the moon reflected in the sea as he witnessed it from the Orissa coasts—the scene reminded him of Kriṣṇa and he leapt into the ocean in an unconscious condition; but it is also related that he was shortly after rescued by a fisherman and carefully tended, till restored to consciousness. This fact in his life is well known. The more advanced members of our community, finding no other clue as to how he passed away, have lately started a theory that Chaitanya Deva was at this time lost in the waters and never again found. But the old records distinctly relate how he was saved by a fisherman; so to assert in the teeth of this evidence that he met with his death in the sea is certainly unwarranted and no historian can credit it. Our country-sides are full of fables, relating to the manner in which he finally disappeared; it is said that he embraced the figure of Gopināth (Kriṣṇa) made of Nimba wood and worshipped in

a temple at Puri, and that there he suddenly vanished. The priests of the temple declare that Chaitanya Deva's corporal frame, which was not of gross matter, was lost in Gopināth's figure ; they point to a golden mark in the image, asserting that that it has been there, ever since the time when Chaitanya Deva disappeared. A similar story is related by the priests of the Puri temple, who associate the disappearance of the devotee with the figure of Jagannātha. As the biographers of Chaitanya Deva are generally silent on the point, fables like these could pass current in the Vaiṣṇava community and they have been long believed by the people.

An historical account.

Jayānanda's Chaitanya-Maṅgala, which has been recently unearthed in the shape of some old manuscript-copies of the work by Babu Nogendra Nath Vasu, gives a version of Chaitanya's passing away from the earth in a manner which we may accept as historically true. It is told by our author that in the month of Asāḍa (July) Chaitanya Deva, while leading a Saṅkirtana party in procession, fell into a trance and as he proceeded leaning on a companion, his eyes streaming with tears, and his hands up-lifted to heaven, with a smile which made his face divinely radiant, he was hurt in the foot by a brick, of which he was totally unconscious at the time. On coming to himself he felt illness with great pain in the foot and said to his companions, that after two days he would die. He caught fever that day, which increased and on Sunday the 7th day of the waxing moon, in the month of July 1534, at about 3 P.M. he left his mortal frame.

A partial corroboration of the story by Lochan Dās.

This we find in Jayānanda's Chaitanya-Maṅgala. From an account given by Lochana Dās in his life of Chaitanya—a subsequent work, we are led to surmise that his body was immediately removed to the temple of Jagannath in Puri and the priests made a grave for it in the floor of the temple. They closed the doors of the temple against all visitors,—Chaitanya's immediate followers not excepted, while they were placing the body in it and repairing the floor after burial. The passing away of Chaitanya Deva was thus made a mystery by the Pandās, who now earn money from the credulous pilgrims by relating romantic stories about his disappearance and by pointing to the golden mark in the figure of Gopinath, which, they describe as the mark of the passage by which Chaitanya Deva melted into the figure of that god.

A page of old history.

Jayānanda's Chaitanya-Maṅgala discloses some other facts of the history of Bengal. It is related in it, that Hossain Shah, the Emperor of Gour (1494—1525) heard of a prophecy in the land that the Brahmins of Navadwipa would subvert the Moslem power, establish a Hindu kingdom and occupy Gour. The prophecy was widely current and the Emperor was alarmed by it. Here is the passage describing the steps that he adopted to avert the evil.

* "By the Emperor's orders the Brahmins were deprived of their caste or killed. Whenever a conch was sounded in a house, the Emperor's

* আচম্বিতে নবদ্বীপে হইল রাজ ভয়।
ব্রাহ্মণ ধরিয়া রাজা জাতি প্রাণ লয়॥
নবদ্বীপে শঙ্খধ্বনি শুনে যার ঘরে।
ধন প্রাণ লয়ে তার জাতি নাশ করে॥

soldiers proceeded towards it at once and killed the inmates there and looted all property. If one was found wearing a *tilak* on the forehead or the sacred thread he was bound hand and foot. The temples were destroyed and shrines were desecrated. The Tulsi plants and the Açvattha trees (sacred amongst Hindus) were up-rooted by hundreds. Bathing in the Ganges was prohibited. The citizens of Navadwip became alarmed for their lives. The Mahomedans made the village of Pirulyā near Navadwipa, their station and were determined to extirpate the Brahmins of Navadwipa. A false report had reached the Emperor of Gour that the Brahmins of Navadwipa would oust the Mahomedans from the country; it was written in their sacred books and the citizens of Navadwipa were

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কপালে তিলক দেখে যজ্ঞ সূত্র কাঁধে।
ঘর দ্বার লোটে তারে সেই খানে বাঁধে॥
দেউল দেহরা ভাঙ্গে উপাড়ে তুলসী।
প্রাণ ভয়ে স্থির নহে নবদ্বীপ বাসী॥
অশ্বত্থ পনস বৃক্ষ কাটে শত শত।
গঙ্গাজল বিরোধিল হাট ঘাট যত॥
পিরুল্যা গ্রামেতে বৈসে যতেক যবন।
উচ্ছন্ন করিল নবদ্বীপের ব্রাহ্মণ॥
ব্রাহ্মণে যবনে বাদ যুগে যুগে আছে।
বিষম পিরুল্যা গ্রাম নবদ্বীপের কাছে॥
গৌড়েশ্বরের বিদ্যমানে দিল মিথ্যাবাদ।
নবদ্বীপের বিপ্র তোমা করিবে প্রমাদ॥
গৌড়ে ব্রাহ্মণ রাজা হবে হেন আছে।
নিশ্চিন্ত না থাকিও প্রমাদ হবে পাছে॥

all expert archers. The Emperor believed in this prophecy and he ordered a general devastation of Navadwipa. Vāsudeva Sārvabhouma, son of Viçārada, with his family, removed to Orissa, leaving Bengal. The king of Utkala was then the illustrious Pratāprudra, famous for his valour in war. He worshipped the great scholar of Navadwipa, presenting him with a golden throne. The brother of Sārvabhouma was Vidyāvāchaspati, who remained in Gour and their father Viçārada proceeded to Benares, where he settled."

It is further related that the Emperor was afterwards convinced that the Brahmins of Navadwipa were innocent. He became remorseful and not only stopped all oppression but ordered the Hindu temples that were damaged, to be repaired. From this time forward he was kind towards the Hindus. We have got references also in Chaitanya-charitāmrita to Hossain Shah's oppression of the Hindus of Navadwipa and other places in the

নবদ্বীপে ব্রাহ্মণ অবশ্য হবে রাজা।
গন্ধর্ব্ব লিখন আছে ধনুর্ম্ময় প্রজা॥
এই মিথ্যা কথা রাজার মনেতে লাগিল।
নদীয়া উচ্ছন্ন কর রাজা আজ্ঞা দিল॥
বিশারদ সুত সার্ব্বভৌম ভট্টাচার্য্য।
স্বয়ং উৎকলে গেল ছাড়ি গৌড় রাজ্য॥
উৎকলে প্রতাপরুদ্র ধনুর্ম্ময় রাজা।
রত্ন সিংহাসনে সার্ব্বভৌমে কৈল প্রজা॥
তার ভ্রাতা বিদ্যাবাচস্পতি গৌড়বাসী।
বিশারদ নিবাস করিলা বারাণসী॥"

Jayānanda's Chaitanya Mangala.

earlier part of his reign. But the Brahmin families whose caste was polluted by being forced to take water from the hands of the Mahomedans stationed in the village of Pirulyā, lost their status in Hindu society, and after more than four hundred years, the Tagore families of Calcutta, who represent a class of Pirulyā Brahmins, as they have been since called, have to a considerable extent regained their social position.

The Pirulyā Brahmins.

Jayānanda gives a list of authors who had written accounts of Chaitanya Deva's life before him, amongst which the works of Paramānanda-puri, Gopal Basu and Gouri Dās, mentioned by him, have not yet been recovered. We find it also mentioned in his work that Govinda Dās, a black-smith by caste, followed Chaitanya Deva in his travels in Southern India.

(d) Chaitanya Charitāmrita by Krisṇa Dās.

By far the greatest of the biographers of Chaitanya Deva,—one who by his pure and lofty character, by his unique scholarship and no less by his hoary old age commanded the greatest respect of the Vaiṣṇava community of the period, was Krisṇa Dās Kavirāj of Jhāmatpur in Burdwan. Born in 1517 of a poor Vaidya family, he was inured to hardships from his earliest childhood. His father Bhagiratha used to earn a small pittance by following the avocation which belonged to his caste viz. that of a physician. At his death Krisṇa Dās was only 6 years old. He had a brother Çyāma Dās, 2 years his junior. Their mother Sunandā could find no way to maintain herself and her two children. But an end soon came to her care and

Krisṇa Dās born 1517 A.D.

Early misfortunes and Vaisṇava influence.

anxieties; the hand of death took her away, only a few months after she had become a widow and the poor children were placed in charge of his relatives. Krishna Dās was not much cared for and he grew up to be a lad of 16, not running wild as such boys are likely to become, but sober and quiet—a prey to melancholia and occasional gloom caused by the bereavements he had suffered which weighed upon his soul. A follower of the saint Nityānanda—Mīnaketana Rām Dās by name, paid a visit to Jhāmatpur at this time. His preachings produced a deep effect upon Krishna Dās who now yearned for the religious life. Rām Dās was however treated to ridicule by Syām Dās, the younger brother of our author who took the matter sorely to heart.

A dream.

Mīnaketan had gone away, but the disappointment caused in Krishna Dās's mind by his brother's conduct, together with the impressions of a holy life left on him by the devout Vaishnava, made him give up the idea of following any wordly pursuits. It is said that at this time Nityānanda appeared to him in a dream and advised him to go to the Vrindā groves and pass his life there. The dream became a real force with him and he could not resist the command. He walked about 800 miles on foot begging alms for his subsistence and arrived at Vrindāvana, where the purity of his life and his high character even as a boy interested the six distinguished Gosvāmis, the appostles of the Vaishnava faith of that time, who volunteered to take care of the young man's education.

Goes to Vrindāvan and settles there.

The beauty of the Vrindā groves, the scenes of which are rendered ever sacred by their association with Krishna, added to the austere lives of the apostles,

Rup, Sanātan, Jība, Gopāl Bhatta and the two Raghunāths and their great learning, all combined to make lasting impressions on Krishṇa Dās. He became a ready and willing disciple of the six Gosvāmis and advanced rapidly in his studies. Within a few years, he had became a profound Sanskrit scholar and had written two works of great merit in that language. His Govindalilāmṛita is a master-piece of poetry, and his annotations of Krishṇa Karṇāmṛita attest his great erudition. He wrote some small books in Bengali, namely—Advait Sutra Kaḍchā, Svarupvarṇana and Ragmayi Kaṇā and in all of these Bengali treatises occur occasional prose-passages which may be taken—with the exception of those in the Çunya Purāṅ of the 9th century, as some of the earliest specimens of Bengali prose. It is worthwhile perhaps to point out that even the biographical notes of Govinda Dās were written in poetry. When even arithmetic was composed in rhyme, how could biography be prose?

Under the six Gosvāmis.

Govinda Lilāmṛitā Karṇāmṛita and other works.

A religious celibate and student all his life, practising the austerities of a Sannyasin,—he had reached the age of 79 when a change came over him. He had never cared for earthly fame or glory,—his aim had been only to acquire sound scholarship in the theological lore of the Vaiṣṇavas, and as an unassuming soul to quit his mortal frame in due time and quietly pass into the heaven of his Krishṇa from the sacred banks of the Jumnā. But a herculean task came upon him in his old age unsolicited and he could not avoid it.

Chaitanya Charitāmṛita commenced when he was 79.

The Chaitanya Bhāgabat of Bṛindāvana Dās used to be read in Bṛindāvana by the holy men of the place every evening, and they felt that the last portion of Chaitanya's life was not described in the work with that completeness which the Vaiṣṇava community required in a recognised biography. One evening when Kriṣṇa Dās sat in his cottage counting the beads of his rosary—old and infirm as he was and suffering from the various diseases which age brings on, a deputation of the Vaiṣṇavas of the place, consisting of Govinda Gosvāmī, Jadavācharyya Gosvāmī, Bhugarbha Gosvāmī, Chaitanya Dās, Kumudānanda Chakravarti, Kriṣṇa Dās Chakravarti, Çivananda Chakravarti and of others, waited on the old scholar requesting him to undertake to write a life of Chaitanya Deva. The hoary headed Kriṣṇa Dās pleaded his age and weakness, but they insisted on his undertaking the work. At this moment the priest of the temple of Govindaji came to him and presented him with an Adeçamālaya—a garland of flowers—a sign of divine command, from the temple, and the request made by the deputation became by this act of the priest inviolable as a religious injunction. Kriṣṇa Dās had no other alternative than to take up the work. He was helped by the materials given him by Çri Dās, Loknāth Gosvāmi, Gopal Bhatta and Raghu Nāth Dās. Besides this he received important help from the scholarly notes on Chaitanya's life by Murāri Gupta and Svarupa Dāmodar and from Chaitanya Bhāgabat by Bṛindāban Dās, and Chaitanya Chandrodaya by Kavi Karṅapur. But from these materials we can scarcely gain any idea of the vast erudition and extraordinary panis-

with which he assimilated and shaped all that came into his hands. I give in the foot notes the names of the Sanskrit works* to which reference is made in the celebrated pages of Chaitanya Charitāmṛita (lit., the nectar of the life of Chaitanya), as his great work is called. It is a monument of industry and scholarship and of the devotional features that characterise Vaiṣṇavism. Up to now no other Bengali work of such patient and varied scholarship has been produced. But the language of the book displays an uncouth admixture of the dialect of lower Bengal with that of the upper Provinces. The author had long left his native land, and his own language had grown to be a curious medley of Hindi and Bengali. His profound scholarship in Sanskrit besides made him import high sounding Sanskrit words into the mixed language used in his work, and a student of Bengali must admit that such importation did

The vast scholarship displayed by the author.

Defects of style.

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*1. Cakuntala.
2. Adipurana.
3. Ujjvala Nilmani.
4. Kavya Prakaca.
5. Krisna Sandarva.
6. Krama Sandarva.
7. Gita Govinda.
8. Chaitany Chandrodaya Natak.
9. Jagannath Vallava Natak.
10. Dankeli Kaumudi.
11. Natak Chandrika.
12. Padmavali.
13. Padmapuran.
14. Govindlailamrita.
15. Visnu Purana.
16. Vicva Prakaca.
17. Vrihat Gautamiya Tantra.
18. Amarkosa.
19. Uttarcharita.
20. Ekadasitatta.
21. Krinsakarnamrita.
22. Kurmapurana.
23. Gadura Purana.
24. Gautamiya Tantra.
25. Nanrad Pancharatra.
26. Nrinsiha Purana.
27. Panchadasi.
28. Panini Sutra.
29. Baraha Purana.
30. Vidagda Madhava.
31. Vira Charita.

not add any beauty or grace to his style. Words like সাধুমার্গানুগমন, একাদশ্যুপবাস, ধাত্রাশ্বত্থ, সেবানামপরাদধি, সধর্ম্মএলভাকপুমান, কর্ত্তুমকর্ত্তুমন্যথা, and দেহকান্ত্যা which display a peculiar formation of Sanskrit Samāsas, together with a sprinkling of Hindi words such as হুঁহ, কৈছে and করোঁয়া and even of Urdu চাচা and নানা, all combined to make the work an *omnium gatherum* of heterogenous elements, which is far from being the graceful and elegant Bengali for which some of the Vaiṣṇava works are noted. The author was no skilled hand in writing Bengali, but this does not detract, in any considerable degree from the unique merit which his work possesses and for which it has found a distinguished and a permanent place in the literature of the Bengali Vaiṣṇavas.

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32. Brihannaradiya Purana.
33. Brahma Samhita.
34. Brahma Vaivarta Puran.
35. Vaisnava Tosini.
36. Bhagabata Gita.
37. Bhakti Rasamrita Sindhu.
38 Bhakti Sandrva.
39. Bhabartha Dipika.
40. Bhagabata Purana.
41. Malamasa Tattva.
42. Manu Samhita.
43. Jamuna Caryya Vrata
44. Ramayana.
45. Laghu Bhagabatamrita.
46. Lalita Madhava.
47. Cvaçvata Tantra.
48. Svarupa Gosvami Kadca
49. Sahitya Darpana.
50. Samksep Bhagabatamrita
51. Hari Bhakti Vilas.
52. Hari Bhakti Sukhodaya.
53. Vedanta Darçan.
54. Bhakti Lahari.
55. Bharati.
56. Bhagabata Sandarva.
57. Mahabharata.
58. Kritalakamandara Stotr
59. Rupa Gosvami Kadca.
60. Stavamala.

Chaitanya Charitāmṛita contains 15050 slokas or "couplets" and is divided into three main *Khandas* or cantos,—the Ādi, the Madhya and the Antya *Khanda*. The first *khanda* contains 2500 slokas, the second 6050, and the third 6500. The poem discusses the views of the Vaiṣṇavas on religion learnedly, with profuse quotations from sanskrit texts. The doctrines of Chaitanya Deva are explained elaborately and one unacquainted with the discourses of the six Schools of Indian Philosophy cannot follow the great Bengali work properly. There are very few Bengalis within our knowledge who can interpret the scholarly expositions of the author aright. With the lay Vaiṣṇavas however the great attraction of the book lies in its delineation of Chaitanya's last days. The slokas that he recited, his religious ecstasies displaying the highest poetic flights,—which at times made him appear like a madman and at others like a heavenly spirit, and not unoften as a great scholar whose sparkling discourses were listened to with rapt attention by the multitude—all have been graphically described in this masterly work of Kriṣṇa Dās Kavirāj. The last portion of Chaitanya's life as told by Kriṣṇa Dās shows how God-vision became more and more frequent with him till the emaciated body could bear these trances no longer,—how the sight of a flower, a ripple on the sea, a tree, or a cloud would throw him into a rapture, and he would shed tears of joy seeing God in them, and stand unconscious with his hands uplifted towards heaven for hours together,—how the songs of Jayadeva sung by a Vaiṣṇava maiden in the Purī temple, made him run like a madman, his feet pierced by thorns and

The excellence of the work.

The last days of Chaitanya, his ecstasies.

dropping blood, and how in an unconscious state he was carried to his home by his followers. Sometimes for a whole night he would sing the songs of Jayadeva, Vidyāpati and Chandidās explaining as he sang—the relation of the soul to God referred to in these songs. Thoughts of the matter-of-fact world scarcely occurred to him. He had not visited his poor mother Çachi Devi and his devoted wife Viṣṇupriyā ever since he took the Sannyāsin's vow and had never visited his dear mother-land of Navadwipa. The people of that place came to Puri frequently to have a sight of one whom they named Navadwip Chandra or the moon of Navadwipa. He would occasionally send messages to his bereaved mother, saying that he was well, and that she should not feel any anxiety on his account. In the last year of his life he sent the following message :—

Last message to mother.

*"O mother, at a time when I should have ministered to your comforts, I took the vow of a Sannyāsin, I turned mad and committed a great sin; pray forgive me, for I am your child and am always bound to obey you."

But this was only a fleeting idea. The God-vision came upon him again and he fell into a trance immediately after delivering the message.

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* তোমার সেবা ছাড়ি আমি করিনুঁ সন্ন্যাস।
বাউল হইয়া আমি কৈনু ধর্ম্ম নাশ॥
এই অপরাধ তুমি না লইহ আমার।
তোমার অধীন আমি পুত্র সে তোমার॥"

Antyakhanda.

I quote below a small passage from Chaitanya Charitāmṛita in which the author points out the distinction between the love of God and earthly passions.

Kāma and Prema.

*" Kāma—earthly passion (lit. desire) and Prema (love) are two different things. One is pure gold and the other—iron. When a man seeks an object for the satisfaction of his own desire, he is said to be prompted by Kāma, but one inspired by a desire to fulfil the will of God, acts under Prema or love. Kāma makes a man seek his own pleasure but Prema makes him do things in which God, delights. The idea of satisfying people by pandering to their wishes (লোক ধর্ম্ম), the ministering to the passions that have their origin in one's own body (দেহ ধর্ম্ম), the fulfilling of the commands enjoined in the vedas (বেদ ধর্ম্ম), wordly pursuits (কর্ম্ম), feelings of shame, of physical pleasure and of personal gratification,—attention to inviolable custom and attachment for one's kith and kin—all these should be given up, and God alone should be adored. Friends and relations will be against such a man, but he should forsake all for the sake of God.

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* " কাম প্রেম দোঁহাকার বিভিন্ন লক্ষণ।
লৌহ আর হেম যৈছে স্বরূপ বিলক্ষণ ॥
আত্মেন্দ্রিয় প্রীতি ইচ্ছা তারে বলি কাম ।
কৃষ্ণেন্দ্রিয় প্রীতি ইচ্ছা তার প্রেম নাম ॥
কামের তাৎপর্য্য নিজ সম্ভোগ কেবল ।
কৃষ্ণ সুখ তাৎপর্য্যমাত্র প্রেমত প্রবল ॥
লোকধর্ম্ম দেহধর্ম্ম বেদধর্ম্ম কর্ম্ম।
লজ্জা ধৈর্য্য দেহ সুখ আত্মসুখ মর্ম্ম ॥

When one has attained this stage, a true devotion for God may be said to have sprung up in him ;— his life becomes like a white cloth without stain. So the difference between Kāma and Prema is great. Kāma or desire is darkness impenetrable, which does not allow us to see beyond self and Prema (love) is the glorious sun which illuminates the truths of the whole universe."

In describing Chaitanya Devā's visit to Vrindāvan the scholarly author displays poetic emotion. He writes :—

Chaitanya's visit to Vrindāvan.

* "On seeing Chaitanya, the very trees and creepers of the Vrindā groves burst into blossom and shed tears of joy in the dews that fell from their leaves. Their boughs gently touched the feet of Chaitanya with their tribute of flowers and fruits,

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দুস্ত্যজ্য আর্য্যপথ নিজ পরিজন।
স্বজন করিব যত তাড়ন ভৎর্সন॥
সর্ব্বত্যাগ করি করে কৃষ্ণের ভজন।
কৃষ্ণ সুখ হেতু করে প্রেম সেবন॥
ইহাকে কহি যে কৃষ্ণে দৃঢ় অনুরাগ।
স্বচ্ছ ধৌত বস্ত্রে যেন নাহি কোন দাগ॥
অতএব কাম প্রেমে বহুত অন্তর।
কাম অন্ধতমঃ প্রেম নির্ম্মল ভাস্কর॥"

Ādikhanda.

* "প্রভু দেখি বৃন্দাবনের বৃক্ষ লতাগণ।
অঙ্কুর পুলক মধু অশ্রু বরিষণ॥
ফুল ফল ভরি ডাল পড়ে প্রভু পায়।
বন্ধু দেখি বন্ধু যেন ভেট লৈয়া যায়॥

and looked as if they welcomed a friend with gifts. Chaitanya in an ecstasy of love embraced each tree and creeper and by the silent prayers of his soul dedicated the flowers and fruits to Krishna."

The author's apology.

On completing his work in 1615 after nine years of unremitting toil, Krishna Dās writes:—

* "It is foolish to assert that I am writing this book by my own power; my body is like an inert log; I am old, decrepit, blind and deaf; my hand trembles as I write, and I have no power to hold to my own ideas; I am suffering from various diseases, and can not move or sit properly."

His tragic end.

He was 97 years old at the time. The MS. however was ready and along with other works of the six Gosvāmis was sent to Bengal for circulation. The MSS. were being carried in a bullock cart and Çrinivās—one of the latter day Vaishnava-worthies—was in charge of this, under escort of several armed men from Vrindāvan. When after some days, they reached Vanavishnupur in the district of Bankura, they met a man who made

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প্রতি বৃক্ষ লতা প্রভু করে আলিঙ্গন।
পুষ্পাদি ধ্যানে করে কৃষ্ণে সমর্পন॥"
Chaitanya Charitāmrita.

* "আমি লিখি ইহা মিথ্যা করি অনুমান।
আমার শরীর কাষ্ঠপুত্তলি সমান॥
বৃদ্ধ জরাতুর আমি অন্ধ বধির।
হস্তহালে মমোবুদ্ধি নাহি রহে স্থির॥
নানা রোগগ্রস্ত চলিতে বসিতে না পারি।"
Antyakhanda.

enquiries as to what was being carried in the cart. The guard said "it was treasure"; for indeed in their eyes these valuable works were a treasure. The news was carried to Rājā Vir Hāmvira of Vanavisṇupur by the spy as the enquirer was. The Rājā had a strong party of robbers under him who carried on depredations in the neighbouring countries. In the night they beat the guards, and looted the cart and disappeared.

Çrinivās, in whose charge the valuable MSS. were, sorely dismayed at this event, instantly sent a messenger to Vrindāvan with the news. No copies of the MSS. were left there, and this meant the loss of the labours of the renowned scholars of so many years. The death of Kriṣṇa Dās is thus described in a work named Vivarta Vilās:—

"The news reached Raghunāth and Kriṣṇa Dās and both of them fell to the ground and began to lament aloud. Old and infirm Kriṣṇa Dās could not stand the shock; he could not rise from the ground and while in this condition passed away in great sorrow."

The work was subsequently recovered, however, and now enjoys the highest popularity in the Vaiṣṇava community. Pity that its learned author met so tragic a death, in his despair of its being

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* "রঘুনাথ কবিরাজ শুনিলা দুজনে।
আছাড় খাইয়া কান্দে লুটাইয়া ভূমে॥
বৃদ্ধকালে কবিরাজ না পারে উঠিতে।
অন্ত ধান করিলেন দুঃখের সহিতে॥"

Vaivarta Vilās.

ever recovered. The high esteem, in which the book is held by the Vaiṣṇavas is evidenced by the following remarks of the late veteran Vaiṣṇava Pandit Hārādhan Dutta Bhaktinidhi of Vadanganj (Dist. Hugli).

The popularity of the book.

'The day I consider as wasted, in which I have not read a chapter of this book.'

Referring to the author's unfortunate death, the Pandit writes :—

"I can not relate the story of Kriṣṇa Dāsa's death. One ought not to write about anything so sad. If I attempt to do so, my heart breaks."

(e) Chaitanya Maṅgala by Lochan Dās.

We shall here touch upon another biography of Chaitanya Deva which also enjoys a great popularity. It is the Chaitanya Maṅgal by Trilochan Dās commonly known as Lochan Dās. Lochan Dās was born in 1523 A.D. at Kogrām, a village 30 miles to the north of Burdwan and 10 miles from Guskharā, a station on the East Indian Railway. He was a Vaidya by caste. His father's name was Kamalākar Dās. Narahari Dās of Çrikhanda, one of the most noted followers and friends of Chaitanya, was the religious preceptor of Lochan Dās. In the brief autobiographical account he gives of himself in his Chaitanya Maṅgal and also in another work named Durlabha Sār, he writes :—

Lochan Dās born 1523 A.D.

* "On both my father's and mother's side I was the only male child. My maternal grandfather was

* "মাতৃকুলে পিতৃকুলে আমি এক মাত্র।
সহোদর নাই মোর মাতামহের পুত্র॥

Autobiographical notes.

without any male heir, and I had no brother. Wherever I happened to stay I was treated with great indulgence. In fact I was almost spoiled. None could succeed in giving me lessons. Thanks be to my maternal grandfather Puruṣottama Gupta, a man of high character who gave me sound thrashings and at last succeeded in teaching me the alphabet."

A good poem, though not a good biography

Lochan Dās's Chaitanya Maṅgal has half the bulk of Vrindāvan Dās's Chaitanya Bhāgavata. It does not claim the authority of a reliable biography. The Vaiṣṇavas love the work because Lochan was a fine poet; his work is more a creation of fancy than an historically accredited account of Chaitanya's life. There are professional parties of singers who sing the whole of Chaitanya Maṅgal and people delight in its high flown poetry. I quote a passage below from this book. The author is describing a conversation of Chaitanya Deva with his wife Viṣṇu Priyā on the eve of his turning Sannyāsin. It is doubtful if the stoical character of Chaitanya is consistent with the feelings attributed to him in the passage but it does credit to our author as a piece of emotional poetry.

যথা যাই তথাই দুল্লিল করে মোরে।
দুল্লিল দেখিয়া মোরে পড়াইতে নারে॥
ধন্য সে পুরুষোত্তম চরিত তাঁহার।
মারিয়া ধরিয়া মোরে শিখাল আখর॥'

Chaitanya Maṅgal.

Viṣṇupriyā and Chaitanya.

*"Near Chaitanya's feet sat Viṣṇu Priyā sighing deeply and looking at him with tearful eyes. She placed the dear feet of her lord on her breast and bound them in a loving embrace with her arms that were like gentle creepers She wept till her sadi was wet with her tears. Chaitanya awoke with a start and asked 'Why should you be weeping beloved? Tell me the reason.' He fondly touched her chin with his right hand and with sweet words asked her again and again the cause of her sorrow. Viṣṇu Priyā did not reply, but continued weeping in a manner that would rend the heart to behold. Her mind was burning with anguish and her body lay

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* "চরণ কমল পাশে, নিশ্বাস ছাড়িয়া বৈসে,
নেহারয়ে কাতর নয়নে।
হিয়ার উপরে থুইয়া, বাঁধে ভুজ লতা দিয়া,
প্রিয় প্রাণনাথের চরণে॥
দুনয়নে বহে নীর, ভিজিল হিয়ার চীর,
বুক বাহিয়া পড়ে ধার।
চেতনা পাইয়া চিতে, উঠে প্রভু আচম্বিতে,
বিষ্ণুপ্রিয়া পুছে আর বার॥
মোর প্রাণ প্রিয়া তুমি, কাঁদ কি কারণে জানি,
কহ কহ ইহার উত্তর।
থুইয়া হিয়ার পরে, চিবুক দক্ষিণ করে
পুছে বাণী মধুর অক্ষর॥
কাঁদে দেবী বিষ্ণুপ্রিয়া, শুনিতে বিদরে হিয়া,
পুছিতে না কহে কিছু বাণী।
পুনঃ পুনঃ পুছে প্রভু, সম্বরিতে নারে তবু,
কাঁদে মাত্র চরণ ধরিয়া॥

inert while her eyes shed tears. She held his feet with her hands and silently wept in spite of the questions of her lord. Chaitanya, who knew the tender ways of love, wiped her eyes with the edge of his *dhuti* and began to speak kind and sweet words to her —words which would make even a stone to blossom, and which naturally appealed to an emotional nature. As Chaitanya Deva seemed so solicitious, Viṣṇu Priyā with her face beautiful like the moon, said softly in a voice choked with tears 'O Lord of my soul, place your dear hand on my head and say if it is true that you will become a Sannyasin. When I hear of it, my heart is likely to break for pain. I shall enter the fire, O my Lord, if the report is true. This my life, my youth, my dress, my ornaments—all I prize for your sake. If you forsake me why should I bear this wretched life! My heart burns as with a firy poison when I hear this report. Who is

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অন্তরে দগধি প্রাণ, দেহে নাহি সম্বিধান,
নয়নে ঝরয়ে মাত্র পানি।
প্রভু সর্ব্বকলা জানে, কহে বিষ্ণুপ্রিয়া স্থানে,
অঙ্গবাসে বদন মুছিয়া॥
নানা রূপে কথা ভাব, কহিয়া বাড়ায় ভাব,
যে কথায় পাষাণ মঞ্জরে।
প্রভুর ব্যগ্রতা দেখি, বিষ্ণুপ্রিয়া চাঁদমুখী,
কহে কিছু গদ গদ স্বরে॥
শুন শুন প্রাণনাথ, মোর শিরে দেহ হাত,
সন্ন্যাস করিবে নাকি তুমি।
লোক মুখে শুনি ইহা, বিদরিয়া যায় হিয়া,
আগুণেতে প্রবেশিব আমি॥

there, O Lord, so fortunate as I! I have a husband like you. I have cherished the dear hope that this youth of mine should be spent in your service. Ah, miserable am I now! The thing that pains me most is to think how you must travel on foot. Through the depth of the forest and along thorny paths, who will accompany you? Your beautiful feet are tender as the Çirişa flower which I fear to touch lest I should cause you pain; how will they traverse the hard ground, amongst the thorns of the forests and whither will you go, O Lord? For a slight exertion, your face, which is like the moon, perspires; how will you wander as a Sannyāsin

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তো লাগি জীবন ধন, এ রূপযৌবন,
বেশ লীলা রস কলা।
তুমি যদি ছাড়ি যাবে, কি কাজে এছার জীবে,
হিয়া পোড়ে যেন বিষ জ্বালা॥
আমি হেন ভাগ্যবতী, নাহি হেন যুবতি,
তুমি হেন মোর প্রাণনাথ।
বড় আশা ছিল মনে, এ নব যৌবনে,
প্রাণনাথ দিব তোমা হাতে।
ধিক রঁহু মোর দেহে, এক নিবেদন তোঁহে,
কেমনে হাঁটিয়া যাবে পথে॥
গহন কণ্টক বনে, কোথা যাবে কার সনে,
কেবা তব যাবে সাথে সাথে।
শিরিষ কুসুম যেন, সুকোমল চরণ তেন,
পরশিতে মনে লাগে ভয়।
ভূমেতে দাঁড়াও যবে, প্রাণ মোর লয় তবে,
হেলিয়া পড়এ পাছে গাএ॥

exposing yourself to the sun and the rain of the hot weather, both of which are quite unbearable? I do not prize anything above these dear feet; where will you leave me and in whose care? You will forsake home to be a Sannyāsin; it is my wretched self that forms that chief bondage of your home, from which you wish to free yourself. No need, O Lord, to forsake home for me. For your least happiness, I would gladly put an end to my life with poison, so that you might stay at home and be happy there."

Further particulars about the poet.

Lochan Dās died in 1589 at the age of sixty-six. Besides Chaitanya Maṅgal he had written a Bengali work named Durlabhasār, and composed a number of very elegant songs. In the village of Kānkḍā near Kogrām (Lochan's native village) the MS. of Chaitanya Maṅgal in the handwriting of

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অরণ্য কণ্টক বনে, কোথা যাবে কোন স্থানে,
কেমনে হাঁটিবে রাঙ্গা পাএ ॥
সুখময় মুখ ইন্দু, তাহে ঘর্ম্ম বিন্দু বিন্দু,
অল্প আয়াসে মাত্র দেখি ॥
বরিষা বাদল ধারা, ক্ষণে জল ক্ষণে ক্ষরা,
সন্ন্যাস করণ বড় দুঃখী ॥
তোমার চরণ বিনি, আর কিছু নাহি জানি,
আমারে ফেলহ কার ঠাঁই ।
কি কহিব মুঁই ছার, আমি তোমার সংসার,
সন্ন্যাস করিবে মোর তরে ।
তোমার নিছনি লইয়া, মরি যাব বিষ খাইয়া,
সুখে তুমি বস এই ঘরে ॥"

Chaitanya Maṅgal.

Lochan Dās is still preserved in the house of one Rām Kriṣṇa Chakravarti who is a professional singer of Chaitanya Maṅgal.

(f) Brief accounts of Vaiṣṇava devotees.

There are numerous other works in which the incidents of Chaitanya Deva's life are described. It should be stated here that notices of Sanskrit books, such as Chaitanya Chandrodaya by Kavi Karṇapur, Kaḍchā by Murāri Gupta and other works dealing with the life of Chaitanya Deva do not fall within the scope of the present treatise.

Besides Chaitanya Deva, but inseparately associated with him, were Nityānanda and Advaitācharyya two great recognised apostles of the Vaiṣṇava faith of whom we have already spoken. Nityānanda was born at Ekchākā in 1473 A.D. and Advaitācharyya was a grandson of Narasinha, the primeminister of Rājā Ganeça. This Rāja is said to have killed the Mahomedan Emperor, and gained the throne of Gauḍa for himself by the counsel of his primeminister. Advaita's father, Kuvār Pandit was originally an inhabitant of Sylhet and had latterly settled at Çāntipur. Advaitāchāryya was born in 1434, and lived to a hoary old age till 1557.

Nityānanda born 1473 A.D.

Advait Āchāryya 1434—1557 A.D.

Accounts of Nityānanda are to be found in almost all the biographical works of the Vaiṣṇavas. His grandfather's name was Sundara Mallā, his father's name Harāi Ojhā. This apostle had two wives—Basudhā and Jāhṇavi—two sisters; they were daughters of Suryya Dās Sarkel, an inhabitant of Çāligrām near Amvikānagar in the district of Burdwan. The Vaiṣṇava singers are never weary of singing songs

Particulars about Nityānanda.

in praise of Nityānanda. In one, which is very familiar, we have the following two lines which embody briefly the main traits of his character.

* "Without anger without pride, and ever content,—he moves about the city."

Biographies of Advaitāchāryya.

The name of Advaitāchāryya was Kamalākar Chakravarti—Advaitāchāryya being his title, which indicates that he was a sound scholar in the Vedanta Philosophy. We find this line about him in the Kaḍchā by Govinda Dās:—

† "—A very handsome person. His flowing hair and beard are grey with age. His long beard falls down to the breast."

Advaita married Sitā Devi, a lady famous for her great piety. We have secured the following works on his life.

(1) The early life of Advaitāchāryya or the Vālya Lilā Sutra by Kriṣṇa Dās of Louḍa in Sylhet. The author was a contemporary of Advaitāchāryya.

(2) Advait Maṅgal by Çyām Dās. This work was written about a century after Advaitāchāryya's death.

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* "অক্রোধ পরমানন্দ নিত্যানন্দ রায়।
অভিমান শূন্য নিতই নগরে বেড়ায়॥"

An old song.

† "পক্ক কেশ পক্ক দাড়ি বড় মোহনিয়া।
দাড়ি পড়িয়াছে তার হৃদয় ছাড়িয়া॥"

Kaḍchā by Govinda Dās.

(3) Advait Prakāça by Içān Nāgar (born in 1492 A.D.) Advait Prakāça was completed by him in his seventieth year, in the year 1561. The book contains 5,500 lines.

(4) Advait Maṅgal by Hari Charan Dās. This book was written immediately after the death of Advaitāchāryya by the author, who was a disciple of the apostle. It is a voluminous book containing 23 chapters.

(5) Advait Vilās by Narahari Dās. This work was written in the latter part of the 17th century.

The princely ascetics.

The line of princely asceties has not yet been broken in India. Ages after the great Buddha had left his father's palace at Kapilāvastu, Raja Gopichānd of Bengal in the 12th century took the ascetic's bowl in hand and renounced his capital where his two beautiful queens Adunā and Padunā bemoaned their lot. Raja Gopichandra a great Prince and the handsomest young man of his age,—heeded not the enjoyments of life, but wandered through forests and dales exposing himself to unheard-of hardships, for the sake of religion. The situation involved a certain pathos the memory of which is still preserved in poems, to be found in all parts of India. When the monarch returned home still an ascetic after twelve years, the beggar's bowl still in his hand and unrecognised even by his devoted queens, they set on a bulldog to drive out one who appeared as an intruder into the palace, but the bulldog instantly recognised his old master, and falling at his feet began to wag his tail and lick them fondly; the royal elephant was sent to trample him under foot, but the elephant bent its head and moved his proboscies in fond joy

Gopichānd.

at meeting the king. The queens now believed that it was Gopichānd, the king, who had returned. All this we find in Mānik Chandra Rājār *gan* about which we have written in an earlier chapter.

With the advent of Chaitanya Deva and under the noble example of his asceticism, princes and rich men came forward to undergo sacrifices for the sake of religion. All ranks of society came to realise the vanity of human wishes, the transitoriness of life and the glorious power of faith. We find many prominent instances of princely asceties, among whom we may name Narottama Dās, son and heir of Raja Krisna Chandra Dutta of Çrikheturi, who left his vast wealth and his palace, when only a lad of sixteen and walked on foot to Vrindāvan. He lived there a life of piety and devotion which lights up the sky of the Vaisnava community immediately after the halo of Chaitanya Deva's personality has passed away from it. Narottam's life is described by Narahari Chakravarti, in his famous work Narottam Vilās. Though only a Kāyastha by birth, his influence was so great that many good Brahmins like Gangā Narayan Chakravarty became his willing disciples, and acknowledged him as their spiritual head. An interesting incident is described about him in the Narottama Vilās. The Rājā of Pakvapalli was approached by the orthodox Brahmin community with an application, that Narottama, the Prince of Kheturi, who had turned Sannyasin, was breaking caste by taking Brahmins as his disciples while he himself was a Çudra. They requested the Raja to inflict a severe punishment on Narottama for this impertinence. The Rājā sent a message to Narottama, asking him

Narottama Dās.

how it was that a man of such piety as he was reputed to be, could violate the injunctions of the Çāstras. Narottama sent a reply to the effect that there was nothing in the Çāstras, rightly interpreted, to uphold or support the views of the Brahmins and that he was willing to hold a public discussion with those who entertained the contrary opinion. If his arguments failed and he was convinced of his error he would accept the orthodox view of matters and regulate his life accordingly. The Rājā of Pakvapalli marched with a host of scholars to meet Narottama, and in the meantime Ganganārayaṇ Chakravarti, his disciple, and Rām Chandra Kavirāj his friend, contrived a device; one disguised himself as a potter, and the other as a seller of betels; they opened small shops on the road along which the Rājā was to pass. His men came to purchase betels and pitchers from the shops and they spoke to them in Sanskrit. This amazed the servants and they carried word to the Rāja that potters and betel-sellers spoke in Sanskrit in that part of the country. The news interested the Pandits, who immediately went to the spot, and being accosted in Sanskrit, were led into a controversial discussion in which the Rājās staff of Pandits, who had brought a cartful of Mss. to prove their point, were completely beaten. They afterwards came to know that one was a disciple and the other a friend of Narottama. Their arguments, however, produced so great an impression on the Rājā and his scholars that they became disciples of Narottama then and there. Narottama, though belonging to the Kayastha caste was called Thakur, a title generally applied in Bengal to Brahmins only.

Raghunāth Dās, born 1498 A.D.

Another princely ascetic of this age was Raghu nāth. Accounts of his life are to be found more or less in all the biographical works of the Vaiṣṇavas. Raghunāth Dās was the only son of Gobardhan Das of Sātgāon and was born in 1498 A.D. His father's income from landed property amounted to 20 lakhs of Rupees a year, out of which he had to pay 12 lakhs as revenue to the Mohammedan Government. The heir-apparent to a property yielding 8 lakhs of rupees a year in those days was no ordinary man, and Raghunāth was naturally brought up in the midst of pomp and luxury, and in a style befitting his high rank. While he was yet a boy, Haridas, the veteran Vaiṣṇava devotee and follower of Chaitanya, paid a visit to Sātgāon and as young Raghunāth saw the great saint, the vision of a higher life passed before him. The impression made on his mind was so great that he conceived an abhorrence for wealth and earthly glory even at that early age. While in this state of mind a further change came over his spirit on meeting Chaitanya at Çāntipur—his eyes overflowing with tears of joy and a divine ecstasy moving his beautiful frame as he spoke of the love of God before thousands of men and women assembled there to hear him. Raghunāth felt as if the portals of Heaven had been flung open to him and it was then that the world finally lost its charms for him. His parents were alarmed to find in the boy a growing tendency towards Sannyās and found a very beautiful bride for him. Besides, they, imposed great restrictions on his habits and movements; but nothing availed. Raghunāth's mind was fixed on the feet of Chaitanya, and night and day he

thought how best he could break the fetters that bound him to the world and join the great master. He studied religious books with great devotion and spent five years in a sort of spiritual agony which made him pale and emaciated,—it was the struggle of the bird in the cage that pants for the free air. By this time Chaitanya had again come to Çāntipur. People flocked from all parts of Bengal to have a sight of the great devotee who was already recognised in many circles as an incarnation of Viṣṇu. Raghunāth in deep distress threw himself at the feet of his parents and besought them with tearful eyes to grant him leave to see the god-like man. He said that he would die of grief if permission were withheld. They could not resist his pathetic appeal and with a strong escort sent him to Çāntipur. There the boy lay at the feet of Chaitanya, unable to utter a word sighing and sobbing like a maiden in love. Chaitanya's attitude towards him was severe even to rudeness. He admonished the young man for his resolution to renounce the world prematurely. "Go back home," he said; "for you have duties to do where the Lord has placed you, and it would be a sin to avoid them; be not too much attached to the worldly life, but consider yourself as serving the will of the Lord, and if in course of time there comes to you a fitness to renounce the world by His grace, there will be no tension or strain in your efforts to attain that end. It will then be a perfectly natural and easy matter, as when the fruit is ripe, it falls to the ground of itself."

Raghunāth obeyed the great master and came back to his father's palace. For a few years he

lived like an ordinary man doing the duties of domestic life—pursuing his studies with zeal, apparently contented in spirit. But it was to him a course of preparation for final renunciation—for joining that great family of saintly men, who leaving the narrow environment of the domestic life had elected the good of the world to be their principal aim in life. When barely twenty, his mind was finally fixed, and he began to show a restless desire to leave home which again caused great anxiety to his parents. Raghunāth at this stage of his life slept in the outer courtyard, and could by no means be persuaded to visit his wife. Nityananda, the most revered of the Vaiṣṇava devotees next to Chaitanya, paid a visit to Pānihāti at this time and thither Raghunāth went to see him. After this meeting his restlessness and yearning increased tenfold.

His mother proposed to secure him, by binding him hand and foot with rope so that he might not move from the palace. Gobardhan Dās, his father, replied—"Great riches, a peerless wife and all the glories of the earth could not bind him, and do you think a rope can do so?—Such a suggestion is very foolish."* Yet the guards and sentinels kept watch over him. It was the story of Buddha over again. He made his escape one night and walked all the distance to Puri to meet Chaitanya. It took him 12 days to reach that place. The

* "ইন্দ্রসম ঐশ্বর্য্য স্ত্রী অপ্সরা সম।
এ সব বাঁধিতে নারিল যার মন॥
দড়ির বাঁধনে তারে রাখিবা কিমতে।"

hardships of the journey were great, as he went barefooted, living on fruit and on the scanty food that chance brought him and resigning himself absolutely to the will of the Lord. Chaitanya saw in the face of the young Sannyasi that his renunciation was complete and embraced him in an ecstasy of joy.

The hardships undergone by Raghunāth while practising life-long asceticism have scarcely a parallel in history. He used to sleep 4 *dandas* (or a little more than an hour and a half) by day and night,—took a handful of refuse rice—the *maha-prasad* that used to be thrown away in the compound—only once a day and lived upon it. He wore rags and slept under the sky. His father occasionally sent large sums of money to his friends at Puri to minister to his comfort but he did not allow a single cowri to be spent on that account. This ascetic, whose whole life was one of austerities and holy contemplation, was cheerful and gay in spirit, and his piety was so great that though a Kayastha by birth he was rekconed as one of the six Gosvāmis, whose words carry authority and precedence in the Vaiṣṇava code compiled for the regulation of that community. The other five Gosvāmis were of course Brahmins. He wrote 29 works in Sanskrit and composed many ballads besides—the theme of which was either Gauranga Dev or the love of Rādhā for Kriṣṇa.

Rupa and Sanātan.

Next may be mentioned Rupa and Sanātan, the two brothers who were Ministers of the Court of Hosen Sāha. They were immensely rich, and possessed of great administrative powers, which were

recognised by the Emperor, who trusted them with important functions. But they felt the irresistible attraction of Chaitanya Deva's personality, and renounced the court and their homes with all their sweet bonds, took the vows of Sannyāsins, and joined Chaitanya Deva. Rupa and Sanātana trace their descent from Vipra Ray, a Rājā of Karnāt. They were required by Chaitanya Deva to pass their lives in Vrindavan, conducting religious studies and practising the austerities of the religious life. We find descriptions of their great scholarship and piety and of the austirities they practised, incidentally in many biographical works of the Vaiṣṇavas—chiefly in the first chapter of the Bhaktiratnākar by Narahari Chakravarti. They wrote in Sanskrit; so their works do not fall within the scope of our subject. The Sanskrit works written by Rupa, Sanātan and their nephew Jiva Gosvāmi form by far the best portion of the Sanskrit literature belonging to the Bengali Vaiṣṇavas.*

Sanātan was born in 1484 A.D. and died in 1558. Rupa was born in 1490 and died in 1563.

* Sanatan wrote annotations on Haribhaktivilas which he called 'The Dik Pradarçani.' His learned commentary on the tenth chapter of Crimatbhagavat is called 'The Vaisnava Tosini.' Besides this he wrote Bhagavatamrita in two parts, and a sanskrit poem called Lilastava. Rupa Gosvami wrote (1) The Hamsaduta (2) Uddhava Sandeça (3) Krishña Janmatithi (4) Ganoddeça Dipika (5) Stavamala (6) Vidagdha Madhava (7) Lalita Madhava (8) Danakeli Kaumadi, (9) Ananda Mahodadhi (10) Bhaktirasamrita Sindhu (11, Ujjvala Nilamoni (12) Prayukta Khyata Chandrika (13) Mathura mahima, (14) Padyavali (15) Raghu Bhagavatamrita (16) Govinda Virudavali and other works. Jiva Gosvami is the author of Harinamamrita Vyakaran, Sutramalika, Krisnarcona Dipika, Gopal Virudavali, Madhava Mahotsava, Sankalpa Vriksa, Bhavartha Siksa Champu, and a good many other works on miscellaneous subjects. A full account of these is to be found in Bhaktiratnakar.

Of the other great Vaiṣṅava devotees Çrīnivāsa Āchāryya, who was only a boy when Chaitanya Deva passed away, deserves prominent notice. He was as on of Gangādhara Chakravarti, an inhabitant of the village of Chākhandi on the Ganges. His mother Lakṣmi Priyā came from Jajigrām. In the early part of his life Çrīnivāsa was noted for his hand-some appearance, for his great devotion and for his scholarship. It is said that Chaitanya Deva prophesied his advent. One incident in his life interests us greatly. We have already stated that Çrīnivāsa was placed in charge of the valuable Mss. written by the great Vaiṣṅava devotees who lived at Vrindāvan, and which were sent to Bengal for circulation. We have also stated how the works were looted *en route* by the robbers employed by Vira Hāmvira, Rājā of Vana Viṣṅupur.

The loss of the precious Mss. written through years of unremitting toil by the great Vaiṣṅava worthies in Vrindāvan, and of which no copy was left with the authors, filled Çrīnivāsa's mind with an overwhelming grief and well it might, for we have already related how the news of this loss proved fatal to old Kriṣṅa Dāsa Kavirāj. A vigourous search was carried on throughout the whole night. But it gave him no clue whatsoever to trace the lost possessions. When the day dawned, pale and exhausted Çrīnivāsa thought that before he left the place he should apply to Rājā Vira Hāmvira for help, since the robbery had been perpetrated in his dominions. This prince, as I have already said, had in his employment a set of robbers who carried on depredations secretly under his instructions and who had done to the Vaiṣṅavas what seemed to be

an irreparable mischief. In the morning Çrīnivāsa asked for an interview and was immediately admitted into the Court. The Court Pandit was explaining the Bhāgavata,—the great work of the Vaiṣṇavas, to the Rājā and his suite, when Çrīnivāsa entered the hall. He was attired in the yellow robes of an ascetic, the sacred garland of Tulasi hung round his neck, and his handsome face, radiant with intelligence and spirituality, at once made an impression on the Rājā and his people. They bowed down knowing him to be a Brahmin and saint and asked him what made him seek an interview with the Rājā. Çrīnivāsa replied—"As the Bhāgavata is being read I shall not interrupt you. Only let the reading of the holy book be finished, and then I shall proceed to tell what I have to say." He kept standing in the hall patiently in the attitude of prayer and would not sit down while Bhāgavata was being read; nor did he betray the emotion that troubled his soul while listening to the recitation of çlokas with true devotion. His piety was to be seen on his face. When the reading was over, the Court Pandit Vyasāchāryya said to him "Revered sir, you seem to be a devout Vaiṣṇava. If it is not disagreeable to you, will you kindly read and explain some passages from this text for our enlightenment." He quietly responded to the call, and sitting in the midst of the assembly made a short speech on the spirit of the Bhāgavata. His mind was already full of sadness and with his sonorous voice ringing with feeling, he delivered his disquisition on the great work, showing a masterly grasp of the subject, and a power of oratory which seemed to them really wonderful. The whole Court was moved at the

words which fell from his lips—his voice almost choked with devotional sentiment; they wept and saw through their tears the saintly man who seemed as a god to them. Even Vira Hāmvira, though a notorious dacoit in the guise of a Rājā, could not resist the tender appeal, and every one present, including the Court Pandit himself, fell at Çrīnivāsa's feet and asked to be made his disciple. The Rājā and his people were thus converted to the Vaiṣṅava faith on the spot and Çrīnivāsa was acknowledged their spiritual head. In the evening Çrīnivāsa sought the Rājā again, and told him, with voice choked with tears, that unless the Mss. looted within his territory, were recovered, he could not think of continuing to live; the works of the Gosvāmis he held dearer than his own life; the blame of the great loss would be upon him, as he was in charge of the manuscripts, and this thought alone was sufficient to make his life miserable. The Rājā was taken aback by this story. He fell at the feet of Çrīnivāsa and with tears of remorse, craved a thousand pardons, confessing that he had himself been at the root of this great crime. He now had the Mss. brought from his treasury, and Çrīnivāsa was delighted to see them again. Alas for poor Kriṣṅa Dās Kavirāj, he had died of a broken heart for a loss which was so soon to be repaired, in so strange a manner! Rājā Vira Hāmvira, filled with remorse for his act placed his whole property at the disposal of the Vaiṣṅavas, and himself lived as a poor servant of the great masters. We have several beautiful songs in Bengali about Kriṣṅa and Rādhā which were composed by the Rājā and quoted by Narahari Dās in his Bhaktiratnākara.

But we cannot say that Çrīnivāsa remained the same spiritual man after taking a Rājā as his disciple. He married two wives, enjoyed the vast property presented to him by the Rājā, and lived a life of comfort totally inconsistent with asceticism. In the Premavilāsa by Nityānanda we find the following account of Çrīnivāsa. Monohar Dās, a native of Vanaviṣṇupur, was relating the incidents of Çrīnivāsa's life to Gopal Bhatta, one of the six great Vaiṣṇava masters, and a follower of Chaitanya. Manohar Dās said:—

* "My native village is 24 miles from Viṣṇupur. I live within the jurisdiction of Rājā Vira Hāmvira. We are all happy under his rule. The Rājā is a disciple and a true servant of Çrīnivāsa Āchāryya. His courtiers are all good men. We have Vyasāchāryya amongst them. Çrīnivāsa Āchāryya lives in the town. The Rājā has presented him with several villages and other properties. Āchāryya

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* "বিষ্ণুপুর মোর ঘর হয় বার ক্রোশ।
রাজার রাজ্যে বাস করি হইয়া সন্তোষ॥
আচার্য্যের সেবক রাজা বীর হাম্বির।
ব্যাসাচার্য্যাদি অমাত্য পরম সুধীর॥
সেই গ্রামে আচার্য্য প্রভু বাস করিয়াছে।
গ্রাম ভূমি বৃত্তি আদি রাজা যা দিয়াছে॥
এইত ফাল্গুণ মাসে বিবাহ করিলা।
অত্যন্ত যোগ্যতা তার যতেক কহিলা॥
মৌন হয়ে ভট্ট কিছু না বলিলা আর।
স্খলৎপাদ স্খলৎপাদ কহে বার বার॥"

Premavilāsa.

Prabhu (Çrīnivāsa) married in April last." Manohara then went on to say many things in praise of Çrīnivāsa. But Gopala Bhatta remained silent for sometime, and at last said again and again 'Oh, he is lost, Oh, he is lost!"

In the Vaiṣṅava community there were still pious men whose lives were pure gold without any alloy of worldliness,—men who shunned filthy lucre and all the other attactions of the world, remaining true to God for evermore.

Some other Vaiṣṅava devotees.

We shall here notice briefly some other Vaiṣṅava devotees, whose lives are included in the biographical literature of the Vaiṣṅavas.

Hari Dās.

1. Hari Dās—a Mahomedan. Bacause of his accepting the Vaiṣṅava faith under Chaitanya Deva's influence he was carried by the orders of a Mahomedan Magistrate to 22 different public places in each of which he was mercilessly whipped till they thought he was dead. He did not disown his faith inspite of this persecution. Hari Dās survived this fierce punishment and was not again molested but the wily Magistrate had recourse to a stratagem. Seated in a small hut Hari Das used to pray to God and recite His name for the whole night. A beautiful young woman dressed in the finest apparel was privately employed to tempt him. She called on him in the evening, where the devotee sat all alone absorved in prayer and said to him with smiles, that she desired to be his companion ; having been attracted by his pious life, she felt a great admiration for him, and would be glad to be allowed the opportunity of talking with him for a while freely to her hearts' content. The

devotee said he would fulfil all she might want of him after saying his prayers. Then, for the whole night, he sat motionless as a statue, praying, and chanting softly the name of God. Nor had the woman again the courage to speak or disturb the course of his devotion; and when the day dawned, and crowds of people assembled there, she had to depart. The next day she again sought an opportunity to lead the saint into conversation, and was again disappointed in the same way. But when the third day passed in the same way, the example of this great life and its living faith could not be resisted, and she had her head shaved, and became a Vaiṣṇava convert, abandoning all her evil ways. Hari Dās was born in Buḍhan in Rāḍha Deça and died at Puri in 1534 shortly after Chaitanya Deva had passed away.

Çyāmānanda.

2. Çyāmānanda belonged to the Satgopa caste. His father was Kriṣṇa Mandal and his mother Durikā. Çyāmānanda is known by different names such as 'Kriṣṇa Dās,' 'Dukhī' and 'Dukhinī.' Many of the songs on Rādhā and Kriṣṇa which he composed appeared under the last of his names in the Padakalpataru and Padakalpalatikā. Çyāmānanda's worthy disciple Rasika Murāri carried the work of propagating the Vaiṣṇava faith to Urissa, and a full description of the manner in which this work was conducted, will be found in a work called Rasika Maṅgal by Gopi Vallabha Dās. The Maharaja of Maurbhanja and other chiefs of Urissa who profess the Vaiṣṇava faith, acknowledge the descendants of Rasika Murāri as their spiritual directors.

Accounts of the lives of (1) Gadādhara (1486—1514 A. D.), son of Mādhava Miçra, (2) of Uddhārana Datta born in 1481 A.D., (3) of Lokanatha Dās Gosvāmi (4) and of Gopal Bhatta one of the six Vaiṣṅava Gosvāmis, son of Benkata Bhatta, are to be found amongst others in many of these biographical works.

Gadādhara, Uddhārana Datta and others.

We here give a short note on several important works of biography written by the Vaiṣṅavas in the latter part of the 16th and in the earlier part of the 17th century.

By far the greatest of the biographical works, next to that of Chaitanya's life by Kriṣṅa Dās Kavirāj is the Bhaktiratnākar by Narahari Chakravarti. He was a disciple of the celebrated Viçva Nath Chakravarti, whose commentary on the Bhāgavata is authoritative amongst Vaiṣṅavas in the interpretation of their sacred scriptures. Bhaktiratnākar is one of the most voluminous works that we have in old Bengali literature. It is divided into 15 chapters. I give here an index of its contents.

Bhakti Ratnākar.

An index of contents.

Chap. I.—An account of the ancestors of Jiva Gosvāmī; a description of the works written by the great Vaiṣṅava masters; an account of Çrīnivāsa Āchāryya.

Chap. II.—An account of Chaitanya Dās, father of Çrīnivāsa.

Chaps. III and IV.—Accounts of the travels of Çrīnivāsa to Puri and to Vrindāvana.

Chap. V.—On rhetoric interpreted in the light of Vaiṣṅava Theology.

Chap. VI.—Incidents from the lives of Narottama, Çrīnivāsa and Rāghava Pandit, while they resided at Vrindāvan; accounts of Çrīnivāsa's being put in charge of the MSS. of the works written by the Vaiṣṅava masters, and despatched to Bengal.

Chap. VII—The looting of the MSS. by dacoits employed by Vira Hāmvira, Rājā of Vanaviṣṅupur and conversion of the Rājā to the Vaiṣṅava faith.

Chap. VIII.—An account of Rāma Chandra Kavirāj and his initiation as a disciple of Çrīnivās.

Chap. IX.—An account of the great Vaiṣṅava festivals held at Kānchāgaḍiā and Çrikheturi.

Chaps. X and XI.—An account of Jāhnavi Devi, wife of Nityānanda and her pilgrimages.

Chap. XII.—An account of Çrīnivāsa marrying a second time.

Chaps. XIII and XIV.—Description of religious festivities at Verākuli.

Chap. XV.—Propagation of the Vaiṣṅava faith by Çyāmanānda in Urissa.

Narottama-vilāsa.

Narahari Chakravarti's second book called Narottamvilāsa (life of Narottama), though comparatively small in size shows a decided improvement on the Bhaktiratnākara both in style and in its arrangement of materials. Narottamvilāsa is divided into 12 chapters.

Narahari was a great scholar in Sanskrit, and the above two works, though written in Bengali, are full of learned references and quotations from the Sanskrit. In the Bhaktiratnākara we find references to the following amongst other Sanskrit